

Phoebe Jackson and the Battle of the Labyrinth

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Additional Tags:	Isekai and Transmigration , Self-Insert , Percy Jackson Has a Twin , Crack , Crack Treated Seriously , Book 4: The Battle of the Labyrinth (Percy Jackson) , Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence , Some Plot , it's still struggling to break free of the niche pop culture references , the author hates ai but loves an em dash , no beta we die like bianca , Or do we? , Swearing , Magic , Dreams , Raging Hormones , Rachel is holding the plot together with a glue gun and a prayer , Phoebe is also holding a gun! A real gun :) , Nico enters the alt-right pipeline , he's like the kid from Knives Out (they're both twink) , Paul is canonically the English teacher every gay student wants to call Dad , justice for the minor gods , rated Mature because of the cow birth , i built these tags in a cave! with a box of scraps!
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by [woobeewooo](#)

Summary

The good news: the quest into the Labyrinth had the same energy of an All-Star Game. Seriously, talk about a stacked fucking lineup. Put the five of us in the Heroes of Olympus quest, and we would send Gaea to sleep faster than the Knicks put down the Spurs. Plus this was the quest with front row seats to THE Percabeth kiss! Eeeeeee!

The bad news? Literally everything else. How was Bianca making canon her bitch going to affect the quest? How was I, shining daughter of Apollo, meant to survive a trip into Daedalus's fucked up house of horrors? Could I save Nico from the alt-right pipeline now that his sister was [spoiler alert] alive? Could I stop Luke from letting a fascist enter his body and puppet him, incel wet dream style?

I'm being serious - could I? Was this truly a fix-it fic, or had I fucked everything up forever? I had no idea, but I was about to find out!

Notes

happy pride, fuckers!!!

Chapter 1: Get A Job! Stay Away From Her!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

In my dream I stood in the great halls of Helios. Now you might be wondering how I knew that, for the palace wasn't golden, or adorned with images of a hot ball of gas that would make someone want to fall to their knees and shout, 'Praise the sun!' In fact, the palace was an oppressive, suffocating thing made of obsidian as black as night with no windows to speak of. The air was so thick and cloying it was as if I was at the bottom of the ocean, or enduring the kind of humid summer day that makes you really sit with the fact that billionaires are destroying the planet just so they can fly private jets and buy their eighth yacht.

The only source of light came from the god himself. He loomed above all others, sitting atop a silver throne twice as tall as I was. His skin was as yellow as a child's drawing of the sun. Only instead of a cheerful smile and an ironic pair of sunglasses, his eyes were like two miniature suns of their own. I could sense there was something different about this god even through the strange, murky, unrealness of the dream. Helios hailed from the Golden Age, before Kronos birthed (and then promptly ate—yuck!) his sons and daughters. He came from a time when mortals had no gender and lived in blissful ignorance, tending to their fields without silly concepts like society, or money, or class. It was a queer dialectical Marxists' wet dream, only ruled by a raging fascist.

Which I guess still made it a queer dialectical Marxist's wet dream assuming they were a tankie. Horseshoe theory goes *brrrrr!* amiright?

Aw, fuck. Where are my manners? Hi chat! Welcome back to my Youtube channel! Did you miss me? :p I missed you so much, you have no idea! There's a lot I could catch you up on, but we can deal with the boring shit later. For now, let's lock back in on my super important dream.

Where was I again? Right, the halls of Helios. Like every dream I had (which was fewer than it should have been, thanks to daddy dearest), I had no control over my limbs. I floated alongside a beautiful woman with curly brown hair and green eyes that were drawn in concentration. She made her way through the throng of nymphs and gods whose names had been lost over the millennia, and knelt at her father's feet. It was one of the many facts that I knew without anyone needing to tell me. I wasn't sure if it was an Apollo thing, or if it was because of *her*, but I supposed I was grateful. I wouldn't be like Percy, bumbling around having to ask every immortal deity I met what their name was and why he should care about them. Yes, yes, he's very cute and endearing without trying!

"Father," Circe said, in a meek voice that was not becoming of the badass bitch witch I remembered so fondly, "is it possible to make a mortal a god?"

I glared at her. "Holy foreshadow, Batman."

Helios frowned into his cup, clearly irritated. “You know it is not, unless it is in their stars already. Not even I can change the laws of the Fates.”

He did not sound particularly pleased about that fact. Circe was even less so; she rose with a deeply troubled expression and practically sprinted away, either ignorant of or purposefully ignoring the mocking whispers that followed her. I had no choice but to drift after her (and I may or may not have clicked my tongue and hit her with a ‘or nah!’ as we went, but that’s between me and the witch) as she ran through the creepy dark halls until we reached another chamber. This one was quite unlike the great hall of Helios; here, at least, there were some gods-damn windows, only they provided us a view not of the sky or the earth but of the ocean floor. I couldn’t look for long; the monsters and beasts that drifted by were of a time before gods, before mortals, before AI-slop memes. Not even Triple T could compare to the unreal things that swam in the depths.

A woman as tall as Helios sat on an oaken stool on a great dais. Her robes were puddled blue at her feet, and around her neck was wrapped a water-serpent like a scarf. She weaved from a golden loom that gleamed with its own light, her beautiful face creased in concentration. She was *old*, that much was obvious, but she was not withered. Her power was different from that of Helios. It spoke of something constant, something eternal, in a way that no other immortal had inspired in me.

Circe knelt at her feet. “Grandmother. He will die.”

The Titaness—*Thetis*, I somehow knew—did not look up from her river-stone green yarn. “Of course he will. He is a mortal, that is their lot.”

“It is not fair,” Circe sniffed. “It cannot be.”

“Those are two different things.”

Circe shook her head. “You must help me. Great goddess, will you not take him to your halls and make him eternal?”

“No god can do so much.”

“But I love him,” Circe said. “Glaucos is different.”

“Real,” I murmured under my breath. Then I shook my head; in the past, Circe had been able to interact with me when I dreamed of her. “You can’t save him. Choose the bear, girl!”

But Circe ignored me. “There must be a way,” she implored her grandmother.

Thetis sighed. “Do you know how many nymphs before you have hoped the same and been disappointed?”

“Is there not some—I do not know the word. Some bargain with the Fates, some trick, some *pharmaka*—”

The sea snake around Thetis’s neck uncoiled and flicked a black tongue out. “You dare speak of that?” she hissed, low and angry.

Circe's face was wide with shock. "Speak of what?"

Thetis rose to her full height. "Child, I have done as much for you as may be done, and there is no more. Go from here, and let me never hear you speak of that wickedness again."

Circe's face twisted in defeat, and then the scene changed into a blistering bright and sunny day. "Jesus—motherfuck, Circe, have some pity on a mortal!" I cried as I blinked bright spots away from my vision.

She ignored me, for she was too busy ogling the mortal standing opposite her as if he had hung the moon. Or should I say the sun?

Sorry.

Anyway, it was midday and hot, the soil beneath our feet dry and cracked. "Come," Circe said. "A perfect sleeping spot to ease your weary bones."

The man—who am I kidding, we all know it was Glaucos—plodded along sullenly, and complained that he could not be away from his ship for long. He had wild black hair and skin bronzed by the sun and scarred from a life at sea, his teeth stained from the brine. I personally didn't know what Circe saw in the guy, but then, I *was* a lesbian, so men as a general rule are a no go for me.

Circe coaxed him down among a field of yellow flowers and watched him eat the food she prepared with an attentiveness that bordered on outright creep status. Once he had finished all his food like a good little boy he yawned, curled into the flowers, and fell asleep. The moment his eyes closed Circe leaned over him and brushed the flowers so they draped over his bare chest.

"Change," she said. She ripped some from their roots and dropped them over his chest, blew out her breath so the scent and pollen would drift over him. "He must be a god. Change."

Nothing happened. Circe's face twisted, anguished. She pushed herself to her feet and wandered the hillside, her eyes darting quickly across the ground. I did not know what she was looking for, but after what felt like hours she returned to where Glaucos lay and wept. After a good long cry (like I said: *real*, girl), she seized a handful of the flowers and ripped them by their roots. She tore the petals and broke the stems into pieces. Damp shreds of yellow, green, and brown soon stained her hands, sap bleeding across her skin. The scent rose raw and wild, acetic as old wine.

That was when we both noticed the humming. It was so quiet one could have mistaken it for the sound of their own mind, but the more I focused, the more obvious it became, dark and persistent like a beehive full of malcontent. Circe's green eyes looked not at her mortal lover but at the horizon, where the sun had dipped beneath the crest of the earth. Her father, I remembered. His movement across the sky was at an end.

I felt a laugh try to bubble its way out of my throat. '*I see all. I know all,*' my father had said last winter. No fucking wonder! He was the god of the sun! He saw *everything* beneath him from his chariot! He was like James Dolan, and Earth was Madison Square Garden. Gods,

remember when Republicans used to call China a totalitarian dystopia because of their surveillance state and social credit system? Even John Boehner, the utter boner that he was, would not have stood for this if he were in office! Tell your representative to vote against age verification laws! We live in a technocratic hellscape! Fuck Peter Thiel!

Ah, sorry about that. If there's one thing I hate more than bad transit, it's fascist technocrats and creepy losers like gods of the sun. Which... *Huh*, I thought as I watched Circe frantically crush a handful of flowers into her hands, ripping apart stems and flowers, mashing them together and spitting into her hand for good measure. *Since when did we have **that** in common?*

Once the mess in her hands was good and goopy she held it over Glaucos's lips, which had fallen open as he dreamed, and squeezed. Sap leaked and gathered on his tongue. A stray bead landed on his lips, and she slid it onto his tongue with her finger. Even though I am, remember, super fucking gay, I couldn't deny there was something hot about it. Especially when Circe leaned over him and whispered, "Your *truest* self. Let it be." Talk about a based woke queen!

A shadow moved across his skin. Circe leaned back on her haunches and watched with rapt attention. His skin rippled and changed, brown, then purple, spreading like an old bruise until his whole body was deepest sea-blue. I had to look away when his hands transformed into crab claws and barnacles burst onto his chest and arms like crusty zits. I was hoping for a gender reveal, not a fishona reveal!

"Glaucos," Circe finally whispered. "Wake up."

I turned around at the same time he opened his eyes. No longer were they crinkled with age and mirth, black as coal. They were like the toil of the sea, a violent, inhumane, violent shade of green. He leapt to his feet, towering over Circe and I like a storm-surge, a sea-god in the flesh. "Circe!" he cried. "I am changed!"

"No shit, Sherlock," I grumbled as the scene changed once again. When it reformed Circe and I stood in a watery halls of a king, made of a certifiable rainbow of abalone and pearls set with gold and wave-wrack treasures. Circe approached where Glaucos held court to a sea (heh) of naiads and gods, still looking at him like he was the one and only love of her life.

"Oh, poor girl," I whispered. "He's a sigma male podcast bro now. It's Joeever."

She didn't seem to notice me. She pushed forward through the crowd until she reached where he lounged on his throne, smirking the smug smirk of a man on a podcast where he sits around with other men and talks about how much they hate 'bitches and foids,' then wonder why none of them are getting their dicks wet.

"It is well," he was saying. "I sent a wave to smash my father's boat, and the shock killed him. My mother I blessed. She has a new husband and a slave to help her with the washing. She has built me an altar, and already it smokes. My village hopes I will bring them a good tide."

“And will you?” I searched through the crowd and found the speaker and, well—chat, if a dreaming girl could gasp underwater, I would have. Her face was round, open wide with rapt attention, more beautiful than all others.

“We will see,” Glaucos began, then his smirk shifted into something dark and unsettling, “It depends on what they offer me.”

Once everyone else had left, Circe approached him. “Is your father truly dead?” she asked, hesitant, a slight waver to her voice that still took me by surprise considering what I knew of her future.

“Of course. He deserved it, for his blasphemy.”

He polished a trident, a gift from Poseidon himself. It surged with power, the water around its prongs bubbling with energy. Circe looked at it, then at her lover, who was a power unto himself. Annabeth would have said more about him because she was a gods-damned nerd, but even I could tell he was not some lesser god. He was in the good graces of Poseidon, a lord of the sea with his own halls, his own immortal admirers, and his own mortal worshipers.

“That round-faced nymph,” he said abruptly. “The beautiful one. What is her name?”

Circe shook herself out of her thoughts, her smile still soft and innocent. “Do you mean Scylla?”

“Yes, Scylla,” Glaucos said. “She moves like water, does she not? Silver as a flowing stream.”

“Oh, you sweet summer child,” I whispered to myself.

Circe *finally* glanced at me. “We all must begin somewhere,” she said gravely.

I surged awake like an action hero coming to on a beach after a shipwreck, comical inhale and all. It was such a jarring experience that I startled, a mess of flailing limbs and fluffy blankets and pillows until I fell out of my bed and onto the ground with a low groan.

“Phoebe?” Annabeth murmured, still half-asleep. “Another nightmare?”

I fought down a grimace. Chat, how I missed the days when my father blocked all of my dreams so I wouldn't cuss him out! “Something like that,” I murmured darkly.

As consciousness returned to me, I couldn't shake the strangeness of the dream. I could still smell the acetic mixture of flowers, the brine of the old sea god. Why had Circe shown me that? I didn't need a lesson in how much men sucked! I was such an expert in it, I could shill out a lesson about hating men on Skillshare.

Apparently, though, the universe disagreed with me, for a strange *ping!* at the window had me bounding to my feet. Our dorm was far less crowded now that Thalia wasn't rooming with us anymore, but that didn't mean it was neat. My blankets and pillows joined Annabeth's usual pile of candy wrappers, old papers, and discarded clothes. I had to step over

her basketball uniform and my guitar to reach the window, which we had left partially open since spring settled onto campus.

That's right, fuckers. It was April, and I was back at school. Back to *eighth grade*. Chat. I am SPARING you by not telling you what it was like. The smell alone was enough to make me long for another go-around the Underworld. Annabeth and I were still well-liked by our peers because *duh*, we are beautiful girlies with big brains and hearts, but the dramatic hormonal fervor of an eighth grade prep school was suffocating.

You might remember that, in canon, Annabeth went back home to San Francisco following the quest. This time around she only went home for a few weekends and all of spring break. A tiny voice in the back of my mind hoped it was because we were such great besties. An even louder voice, however, wondered if Chiron thought it was more important that Annabeth keep an eye on the loose-cannon than the swirling mists of Mount Othrys.

Annabeth rolled back over and grumbled something about how annoying boys were. It wasn't the first or the last time a group of little shits tried to convince us to sneak out to get up to some mischief on campus, so I couldn't blame her. I tore open the curtains and prepared to yell some well-thought out insults and came up short. For there, standing beneath the window like the love interest of an early 2000's campy rom-com, was a literal man. Only in the movies they didn't carry a white flag, or have a sword clasped at their side, or sport a nasty scar that seemed to bleed in the golden light of the wrought-iron lamp beside him.

"Yuck!" I cried, closing the curtain.

"Are they peeing again?" Annabeth sighed.

Just for a moment, I debated lying to her. Things had been going so *well*! Now there was a predatory fascist on campus, and everything was *fucked*!

Alright. That's not entirely true. Kronos predates the rise of fascism by like, a million years or something. But come on. If Charlie Kirk were a demigod, he would have been slurping all over Kronos's dick and calling him daddy to #pwn the libs. If that's not an indicator of fascism, I'm not sure what is.

Once I would have gone along with this insanity because it was what happened in canon... But now that I knew canon was as made up as the myth of the American Dream, I wondered if it would be best to ignore it. Ultimately, though, I didn't want to take control of Annabeth's life like that. A witch *and* a puppet-master... I was not about to accept the fanon Dumbledore accusations!

"Uh, no," I replied. "You should come look."

"I really don't want to see what they're doing now."

"Annabeth."

Something in my tone of voice must have given something away, because she sighed and joined me at the window. That meant I got an intimately close look at her honest reaction:

pupils dilated, breath caught, face flush... Then she scowled, the moment of vulnerability hidden beneath a mask. "What is *he* doing here?"

I shrugged. "Um... Are you going down there?"

She stared at me. "Are *we* going down there, you mean?"

"Oh. I thought..."

I didn't know what I thought. Luke was here for Annabeth, obviously, so why would I tag along? Annabeth hadn't exactly been the fuzziest roommate since I came out as a witch and she held up the weight of the sky? That I didn't make deals with fascist pigs? It turned out I didn't need to respond, though. Annabeth grabbed me by the wrist and pulled me away from the window. "C'mon."

We quickly changed out of our pjs and into combat gear (jeans and t-shirts). Annabeth clasped her dagger to her side while I reached into the box under my bed. "Alohomora," I whispered, purposefully not looking at Annabeth when the box glowed with black flames and clicked open. A moment later I had one of my revolvers in a holster at my side. We nodded at one another, then snuck down the hall and out the back door with the broken fire alarm.

We met Luke at the center of campus, beside the huge fountain with a statue of Emma Willard (daughter of Athena, obviously) that loomed over us with a look of disapproval I'm positive I wore as well. Not that it mattered all that much; from the moment we snuck out of our dorm, Luke and Annabeth only had eyes for each other. It was about as creepy as you're probably imagining.

To describe it without any personal biases: a nineteen year old had snuck onto a middle school campus in the dead of night to speak with a fourteen year old.

Like—*yurgh!* It made my skin crawl! I wanted to pull out my phone and call Chris Hanson. I *really* wanted to knee Luke in the balls so hard he threw up. But Annabeth was, against all odds and logical reason, hopeful. She was still doing her best to hide it under a withering glare, but her eyes shone with the same emotion as when Chiron offered to look over her homework and projects, or when Percy actually managed to say something emotionally mature instead of 14 year old boy nonsense.

Something about that itched my brain oddly, but I didn't have time to ruminate on it.

"What do you want, Luke?" Annabeth demanded, hands on her hips.

He didn't respond right away. He looked at Annabeth like she was a memory; like something he had already lost. Which was... tragic. Still really fucking weird and gross, but it was undeniable all the same.

"I made a mistake," he said in a sudden rush, like if he didn't get the words out now, he might lose the nerve to ever try it again. "I was an idiot to join Kronos. He's..." Luke swallowed heavily, like his mouth had gone bone-dry. "I can't do it anymore."

Annabeth's eyebrows had risen the longer he spoke. "What are you trying to say?" she asked, slow and delicate.

"Run away with me," he said. "It'll be like the old days. We can find Thalia, and we'll help Grover find Pan, just like we always said we would. The Titans and the gods can fight this war without us. What have they ever done for us?"

For a single moment, I saw Annabeth seriously consider Luke's proposal. This idealized future as selfish as a billionaire's doomsday bunker and unrealistic as the sixth sequel to an action movie. It only lasted a breath before it closed off. Not hardened, just... Dimmed. I was seized with a sudden confidence that we both realized what Luke would see if he ever visited the Sirens, and what it meant:

Luke didn't know how to build. He ran.

The exact *opposite* of Annabeth.

"Why should I trust you?" The bluster was gone from Annabeth's tone, the last feeble gusts of a great storm rapidly fading from her gray eyes. "A lot's changed since the old days. The last time I saw you, you tricked me into holding up the weight of the sky."

Luke's despair was haunting to see in the flesh. "*Please.*"

Annabeth hesitated. Her right arm tensed, like she was considering reaching for her dagger. *Luke's* dagger. Fuck, chat: THE dagger. I stared at it, wide-eyed and more than a little nauseous. Which unfortunately meant the little gremlin voice in the back of my head really wanted me to say something stupid so I wouldn't think about the end of the world. I wanted to tell Luke to crawl back to his sugar daddy at least once before he went all Quirremort on us, and not in the fun Starkid way. The phrase 'dumpstered your ass in San 'Francisco' was also appealing.

I didn't, though. Annabeth had the least patience for my antics, yes, but more importantly... She needed to do this herself.

"Go." Her back was straight, her words angered but clear. "I'm not coming with you."

Overhead, thunder rumbled.

Luke's face twisted harshly. "If you aren't going to join me, then you shouldn't let me leave, Annabeth. He's going to use me like a stepping stone. This is the last chance you're going to get to stop me." He threw his peace flag into the fountain and unsheathed Backbiter.

I hissed as I drew my revolver. "None of that," I declared. Beside me, Annabeth had her hand on her dagger, but her hand shook. I knew she could never fight Luke, even though she knew what he had become.

"This doesn't concern you, daughter of Apollo," Luke replied tightly.

"What the fuck? You drew a sword on me!" I wagged my revolver around. "Now scram. You aren't going to fight each other."

Luke twitched, like he was thinking of trying to pull a Deadpool and deflect my bullets with his sword. Then he scoffed, jammed Backbiter back into its scabbard, and marched away.

We watched him until he reached the edge of campus and the shadows enveloped him. Then my arms reached for Annabeth and she collapsed into me, shoulders shaking violently with suppressed sobs. I don't remember much of the walk up to our room, nor the hour or so that followed. Annabeth was inconsolable. She alternated between tears of rage and sadness, wailing and hiccuping and... It *changed* something about our friendship.

I'm sure most of you know what I'm talking about. Even best friends—which I hesitantly believed Annabeth and I were—can go years before one of them breaks *completely* in front of the other, showing the full breadth of what hides beneath the mask we all wear when we aren't alone. Not to be too fucking dramatic or anything, but like... You *know*, right? How falling apart can be the thing that brings you close together?

I felt it then, when I held Annabeth tightly as she grieved for everyone who *wasn't* there: Luke, Thalia, Grover, her family, her mother... I couldn't imagine what it must be like to feel so hopelessly alone.

Try as I might, I couldn't replace the gaping hole that had been chipped out of her. That didn't mean I shouldn't try, though. So I held her, murmuring gentle words into ear and running a hand through her hair, not complaining when a particularly thick glob of snot bubbled out of her nose and fell onto my favorite pair of pajamas...

"Why the hell did you lie to us?" Annabeth said through sobs.

"Uh—what?"

Not my best reaction, sure. But I had expected us to have a heart-to-heart about her older brother/first crush, not *me*. Annabeth pushed me back with the palm of her hand. "After Circe's Island, why didn't you tell us?"

She glared at me with red and running eyes. I didn't know how to respond right away; we had already talked about why I hid my magic from everyone last winter, hadn't we? But then I thought about the last few months. Things hadn't been *bad* between Annabeth and I, necessarily, but something had definitely shifted. I guess neither of us wanted to address the distance that had formed between us. It reminded me of the first summer we met, when Annabeth thought I might be the traitor.

With that thought in mind, I spoke honestly. "You guys were all terrified of magic. You made it sound like Circe liking you was a death sentence. Annabeth, why should I have told you?"

"Because we're your friends, you idiot!"

Then she was hugging me, and after a moment's hesitation, I hugged her back just as tightly. "I'm sorry," I blubbered, and thought, *Oh, I'm crying too*. "I shouldn't have."

"Duh!"

We cried for a little longer, snotty and messy and united. At some point I had the idea of turning on a movie, and Annabeth made popcorn, so we sat for a while munching on Orville Redenbacher's and watching *10 Things I Hate About You*.

Eventually, though, I grew aware of Annabeth's mind stewing. She had a certain face when she was thinking deeply about something, and her foot tapped irregularly when she was particularly deep in the trenches of a thought spiral. Which, while concerning, was so positively Annabeth-coded that I decided was a good thing.

"What did he mean, 'a stepping stone?'" she asked.

On screen, Kat Dennings was reading Sylvia Plath. I nodded in approval before I turned to Annabeth. "I don't know," I replied, like a liar. "What do you think it means?"

"I don't know, but I don't like it." Her voice was small. "It doesn't bode well."

"That's an understatement."

She hit me on the arm. "This is serious!"

"I know that!" I retorted. I settled back against her shoulder and sighed. "We should tell Chiron. If Kronos has something planned... We're running out of time."

Annabeth shifted beside me. It was a small thing, but there was a weight to it. She looked like she was torn about saying something. I had a sneaking suspicion I knew what it was, and after a few minutes of indecision I was proven correct. "There's something I have to tell you."

"Alright."

She looked like she wanted to hit me, which was a usual reaction to my nonchalance regarding the end of the world. "Last winter, when you were... You know..."

"Sleeping off my magical bomb trick?" I supplied.

Annabeth's expression could turn someone to stone. "Yes. That."

I popped a handful of popcorn into my mouth. "What about it?" I asked while I chewed.

I listened intently as Annabeth told me about Clarisse's quest into the Labyrinth, about how she found Chris Rodriguez, the son of Hermes who joined Kronos and was driven insane by Daedalus's maze. Unlike canon, however, Annabeth also told me about what *else* Chris had to say.

"He kept saying that Kronos's army was growing," she whispered, as if the idea was so horrible she couldn't believe it. "And it's not just monsters."

"Demigods?"

Annabeth nodded. “Children of the lesser gods have been approached by his minions over the last two years. It sounds like... It sounds like Luke started laying the groundwork when he was the head of Hermes Cabin. There were so many unclaimed kids in there, it must not have been hard.”

“Fucking fascist evangelicals,” I murmured.

Annabeth didn’t look impressed by my commentary. “Phoebe... What if the reason we can’t find Nico is because he went into the Labyrinth? And... If Luke is exploring it... What if Nico—”

“He won’t.” My voice was steady with conviction. “We’re going to find him.”

Because Bianca slay-queened her destiny or whatever, everyone’s reaction to the missing camper was a lot more involved. In canon, Chiron had largely washed his hands of the child of Hades. Now, Artemis and Chiron both promised they would keep a close eye out for him. However, it wasn’t like they had the resources to commit to a fully search and rescue mission, what with Titan of Time setting up his comeback tour or whatever. But now that Bianca was alive... I didn’t consider it. This was a fix-it fic, gods-damn it! Bianca would live, and Nico would be a happy little gay boy married to Will! Rule #3, remember?

“You think?” Annabeth asked.

I shrugged. “I mean, I’m not *confident*, but a girl can hope, can’t she?”

Annabeth looked at me, long and hard. Then her expression shifted into something coy that I did *not* like, and I knew our super-serious conversation was over. That was the thing about teenagers; we could only handle so much world-ending traumatic shit before someone had to make a stupid joke.

“Uh huh,” Annabeth said, way too casual and way too knowing, “just like you hoped that red-head who toured last month would kiss you behind the gym?”

“I’m—I don’t know—*What?*” My heart beat violently in my chest.

“Oh, please, I’m not stupid. You *never* offer to give tours, and you two were gone for *hours*. Every time I saw you, you were making puppy-eyes at her.”

And to my horror (and, somewhere, joy, because it meant that Annabeth was no longer crashing out over incel-predator and fuckboy loser Luke Castellan or the end of the world), she mimed making kissy faces at me. I crossed my arms. “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“Uh huh.”

I side-eyed her. “*Devious* of you to bring this up when you just cried so hard snot bubbled out of your nose.”

“Terrain is decisive,” Annabeth laughed.

“Don’t tell me that’s from Art of War or some shit.”

Annabeth developed a fascination with rubbing her finger along the blanket.

“Oh my gods, you are such a *nerd!*”

“Don’t laugh!” she protested. “I snot-bubbled at you, and you’re laughing!”

“Oh, when Percy hears about this—”

Despite crying for nearly three hours, Annabeth punched me so hard I woke up with a bruise.

Chapter End Notes

omg! hi! i'm so sorry i was gone for so long! i have no ao3 author notes lore to impart upon you, i was simply busy grinding and slaying and had no time to write. i am unfortunately still quite busy, so updates for this installment are going to be a bit more spaced out than they have in the past. expect a chapter or two a week :)

finally, the dream sequence is taken from Madeline Miller's Circe. there are going to be a few more in this installment, so if you have not read it yet... What the fuck are you doing? Go get it! Right now!

Chapter 2: I Learn WAY Too Much About My Brother (Thanks, Kinky Vampires!)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

“Come on, you two! I want photos of my children to look back on when I’m old and gray. Or grayer.”

Mom’s smile would put a crocodile to shame. She was right last winter—she would be a Slytherin. A pure, kind-hearted one, sure, but a Slytherin nonetheless.

Percy and I grimaced at one another. The good thing about being a demigod (other than the powers and intense trauma bonds) was that we inherited *just* enough godly DNA to be, as a rule, more attractive than our peers. However... Chat. I fear I must tear down the veil of plausible deniability. Percy and I were about to turn fifteen. Puberty was in full swing, and it was a motherfucking bitch.

I’ll spare you the details, because c’mon, chat, that’s not what we’re here for, but summer in the city was *hot* and *humid* (yes there’s a Hamilton reference in there, don’t make it! Don’t!). I had a small row of zits on my forehead that I was referring to as the Orion’s Belt, and I wondered if there was a god responsible for giving the world’s hottest, funniest, girls the worst period cramps imaginable. The only silver-lining was that Mom refused to let Percy look away from mother nature’s kindest gift to women. I only had to grimace to have that boy sprinting to the bodega for medicine and chocolate.

Now, though, we were sharing the burden of puberty hell: taking photos. An eternal reminder of the worst time of our lives. We shared a grim-faced nod, then smiled at the camera. At the very least it showed off the spread of blue food on the table and Percy’s horrible bedhead. We smiled politely for two clicks, then I tickled his side and he broke, half-gasping and half-laughing while I smirked proudly at the camera. Mom took one look at it and teared up, which turned into an impromptu group ‘selfie.’ It was angled too high, and Percy’s face was mostly cut off, but it was perfect.

Once that was taken care of we sat down to enjoy our breakfast. Or at least, we *tried* to enjoy our breakfast. Now that the cute photo was over I could feel the tension lurking in the air. For good reason, too—all of us could see the sword of Damocles hanging in the rafters overhead.

For Mom, the sword symbolized sending her trouble prone demigod children to the school her boyfriend-soon-to-be-husband worked at. I couldn’t imagine how scary that would be ordinarily; Paul definitely walked Mom through the scholarship process, because we would not have been able to afford it on our own, even with Gabe Ugliano’s generous ‘donation’ to the Sally Jackson Fund. I wondered why Chiron couldn’t do us a solid like he had for me, Thalia, and Annabeth at my last school. I had a sneaky suspicion the answer started with an A, had two N’s, ended with an H, and shared a similarity with a game called The Last of Us.

Regardless, Mom was stressed. Somehow, though, it was nothing in comparison to Percy. As soon as we were done eating he sprinted to the bathroom, and for the first time in living memory, took a shower in the morning. He wasn't even singing! Mom and I exchanged a knowing look as we did the dishes. "How are you feeling, dear?" she asked.

"I can't believe they do orientation in June. Feels like a crime against humanity. Other than that though?" I handed her a plate and shrugged. "Should be fine. I'm perfect, remember? I'll make friends."

Mom laughed and shook her head.

I waited for her to continue. When she didn't, hiding her smile from me, I splashed her with water. "Oi! I am the most perfect daughter on the planet!"

"If you say so, dear."

We lapsed into a comfortable silence. It was nice, just to do dishes with my mom. You didn't think Sally Jackson was going to freak out because I was a powerful and dangerous witch, did you? How dare you disrespect and sully her good name! Her son was the presumed hero of a prophecy that would decide the fate of the entire world. Being able to conjure little balls of black fire was a bit of a nothingburger in comparison to that.

Plus, she was Sally *fucking* Jackson, and she had more important things to worry about. Things like our love lives.

"Has your brother told you what he's doing after school?"

Now I was the one hiding a smile. "No, he just said he wasn't going to be home until later. Thought he had plans with those boys from his basketball team."

"You *cannot* tell them I told you this," Mom said warningly.

"Okay?" I said, even though I was working so hard not to smile.

"Your brother and Annabeth are going on a date."

"They *ARE*?!"

"Not officially," Mom laughed. "They're just 'going to see a movie, Mom! Gods!'"

We shared a laugh. "Finally," I sighed. "That boy has had a crush on her from the jump."

"You approve?"

"Are you kidding? She's going to whip him into shape for us! We're free!"

Mom rolled her eyes, but I could see the smile twitching at the corner of her mouth. "She is a lovely girl. She deserves happiness."

My smile grew more soft. "Yeah. She does."

A silence stretched between us that was broken with a little coy look on my mother's face. "So," she began, not at all subtle.

I threw a mug into the sudsy sink. "Nope!"

"Any cute girls catch your eye lately?" she called out to my back.

"NOPE!" I yelled over my shoulder as I ran.

The truth was that there was a very cute girl waiting for me at Goode High School on East 81st. Now, for those of you not in the know, that's in the Upper East Side(rs) of New York. Our new school was surrounded by upscale bistros, brownstones converted into some of the most expensive apartments in the entire country, luxury boutiques, luxury stores, and enough Starbucks to supply an army of basic white bitches their sugary pink drinks. It was also a *trek* from our apartment (it'd take us nearly an hour to get to school), but Mom was convinced it would be a good fit for us. Most of her words went right over Percy's head—TAs in every classroom, one-on-one work time with reading specialists, sensory rooms for students to take breaks in or study in quiet, etc. etc. It was a school designed for spoiled kids with absent parents. Dakota Fanning's character in *Uptown Girls* would have THRIVED at Goode, I'll tell you that much.

The idea that she might be canon in the Percy Jackson universe only amused me for a moment. Yes, I had just spent a year at an annoying boarding school, but even I was taken aback by what I was seeing. Burly dudes in suits with earpieces were posted outside of BMWs, Lincoln Town Cars, and black SUVs with the windows tinted; men and women drank expensive coffee and laughed richly while their kids showed off their thousand dollar backpacks...

"Just relax," Mom said, not at all relaxed. "It's only an orientation tour. And, remember dears, this is Paul's school. So try not to... You know."

"Destroy it?" said Percy.

"Yes."

Paul stood out front, greeting future ninth graders. I think Percy was (begrudgingly) coming around on our future step-dad. He was as attractive as I remembered him, only now it was even worse. He could have been an actor! Instead he taught *ninth grade English!* Yeah, he worked at an elite prep school in New York City, but still. Seeing him warmly welcome the shy students and lob jokes at kids whose shoes probably cost as much as one of his paychecks was insanely attractive. And I'm *gay*! That's how you know this man was the whole package.

Percy stared at the school like he was marching to his grave. Mom glanced at him out of the corner of her eye (I was relegated to the backseat on account of my short legs) and her face softened. "I'm sure orientation will be fine. It's only one morning."

"Great," Percy mumbled, "I can get expelled before I even start the school year."

“I can time you if that’d be helpful!” I offered. “‘Local Boy Speedruns Expulsion’ would do numbers on Youtube.”

Mom glared at me through the rearview mirror. “Think positively,” she said soothingly. “Tomorrow you’re off to camp! And after orientation you’ve got your date—”

“Mom!” Percy cried.

“I already knew about your date, Perce,” I said smugly.

He crossed his arms. “It’s not a date. It’s just Annabeth. Jeez!”

Mom smiled patiently. “She’s coming all the way from camp to meet you.”

“Yeah, where else would she come from?”

“You’re going to the movies.”

“You’re seeing Iron Man, her favorite comic book character,” I added.

“Yeah?” said Percy, confused.

“Just the two of you,” Mom finished, twisting the dagger.

“Oh my gods!”

Mom held up her hands in surrender while I cackled. “You’d better get inside. I’ll see you both tonight.”

I hugged Mom tightly from the backseat then climbed out of the car, stretching my legs and trying not to groan loud enough for all of the rich people to hear me being so undignified. I came around the other side of the car to wait for Percy and skidded to a stop. I’d like to tell you that my face didn’t immediately feel hot, my heart didn’t beat a little louder in my chest, and I didn’t worry I was hyper-ventilating, but none of that would be true. On the steps in front of me stood a girl with frizzy red hair talking to Paul. He laughed loudly at something she said, his eyes twinkling.

I didn’t hear what Percy said to Mom. I just heard him slam the door shut and say in my ear, “Come on.”

“What?” I asked, dumbly.

Percy grabbed me by the wrist and dragged me down the block. I fought valiantly, but he was much stronger than me. We probably made a sight, bickering under our breaths as we moved away from the crowd and to a quiet side entrance.

“What is your problem?” I hissed.

“I didn’t want to have to talk to Paul in front of everyone.”

“You’re getting better at lying, at least.”

“I’m not lying.”

“And I’m not a gay icon.”

“Phoebe.”

“*Percy*.”

“Hi!”

We both jumped. Standing at the top of the steps were two girls in purple and white uniforms holding pompoms. That was scary enough—seriously, have you ever met a normal cheerleader?—but the metal and horse legs were even more alarming. How could I have forgotten this? How did I not make the connection last summer? Gods, Rachel was going to be *furious* with me.

I gaped openly at the shorter of the two girls. “*Tammi*?”

“You know her?” Percy asked, eyes wide.

“Oh, we go *way* back,” said Kelli before Tammi could respond. If I focused, I saw her the way Percy did: long blonde hair, icy blue eyes, plump pink lips. She was very cute in a 'she has a boyfriend but I can convert her' way. Unfortunately, she was looking at both of us like a crossed college student looks at a plate of Egyptian food at 2:00 AM.

(Lust and hunger, if you need it laid out for you).

Kelli stepped up to my brother, whose nose wrinkled as the smell of roses and horse washed over us. “What’s your name, fish?” she asked.

“Fish?” replied Percy.

I cackled. “Yes, this is my brother, Fish—”

“It’s short for freshman,” Kelli said over me.

“Uh. It’s Percy, actually.”

The empousai exchanged glances.

“Oh, Percy Jackson,” Kelli said. “We’ve been waiting for you.”

Percy glanced at me out of the corner of his eye, his hand creeping towards his pocket. I shook my head. “I so should have been timing this,” I sighed. “Summoning Salt video when?”

“Percy? Phoebe?”

Paul stood down the hallway wearing an expression of polite concern. The empousai backed off right away. Percy hurried past and accidentally kneed Kelli. *Clang!* went her leg, like he'd just run into a flagpole. "Ow," she muttered. "Watch it, *fish*."

Paul was waiting for us at the end of the hallway, but I merely waved at him. "You coming?" asked Percy, eager to get the fuck out of there.

"Don't worry, Percy," said Kelli sweetly. "We reached out to Phoebe about joining the cheer team!"

Percy blanched. "You did?"

"Totally," I replied, straight-faced. "H-O-T-T-O-G-O! You can take me hot to go!"

"Uh—right," said Percy. Upon closer inspection, I saw his eyes were a little clouded, a little foggy.

No, that wasn't right. They were a little *misty*. The same must have been true of Paul, for he took Percy gently by the arm and walked away like I wasn't there. The moment they were around the corner and out of sight I took a step back from the empousai. "*Never* make me cosplay as a cheerleader again. I'm not hot enough to steal Natasha Lyonne's thunder."

Kelli laughed. Now that the mortals were gone I could no longer see them the way everyone else did; they were full vampire-horse-metal girls. I wondered if a Japanese demigod would make a manga about empousai during my lifetime. It'd do *numbers* with the monsterfuckers, let me tell you.

(Chat, I'm so sorry to tell you that is TOPICAL foreshadowing).

"I was *so* excited when I saw your name down with your brother's!" Kelli cried. "Tammi told me *all* about you."

"Of course she did, I'm too cunty to forget," I replied. "I'd say you're moving up in the world, but I think I'd rather work at Monster Donut than cosplay as a high school cheerleader."

Tammi smirked. "Our mother saw fit to lead me to my mistress."

I gaped at them. "She's your mistress? You mean—shit. Are you two fucking? How—What do you—Whose the—Actually, you know what? No. I don't want to know. I'm fine without mental images."

The empousai bared their fangs at me. "You are fortunate our Lady has deemed her chosen demigods off-limits," purred Kelli. "You would taste *divine*."

"Please don't say things like that," I begged. "I'm fourteen, you freak!"

"You don't *smell* fourteen," said Tammi.

I took a step back. "Um. I'm going to walk away now."

Kelli put her hand on my wrist. I felt her claws wrap around my skin and froze in fear. “Ignore my trainee, she has much to learn,” she said. “Our Lady wishes to speak to you. There is *much* to discuss, and much for you to learn.”

I yanked away, wincing in pain when the empousa’s claws dug into my skin and drew blood. “She could have spoken to me literally whenever!” I said harshly. “Tell her to IM me instead of sending you freaks next time!”

I marched off, but not before Tammi raised her claws to her lips and *licked my blood*. I blanched, yanked the sleeve of my shirt over my torn wrist, and took off in a sprint, torn between disgust at them and at myself. Circe had told me the truth of it all those months ago. I wasn’t technically a witch; no, I bore Hecate’s Blessing, whatever the fuck that meant. I had been avoiding that quirk of my life, just like I’d been avoiding so much shit, and now it was coming back to bite me in the ass. And not in a hot way, not like how Tammi served her mistress—

I followed the scent of BO to the gym. A marching band played an out-of-tune fight song more grating on the ears than Jane Remover to people without taste. Older kids stood on a theater stage behind one of the basketball hoops and showed off the uniform, which was objectively mid in comparison to my cute northeast uniform at my old school. I spotted Percy right as a guy in a pinstripe suit walked up a microphone, his voice a grating echo that nobody could understand. I hurried up the steps, whispered apologies to the students I was bowling over, and collapsed beside my brother just as I inhaled a whiff of paint, nature, and something metallic.

“What are you doing here?” Rachel asked Percy from the row behind us.

He glanced at me; he had told me briefly about Rachel at some point, but not in a lot of detail. “Rachel Elizabeth Dare,” he said.

Rachel rolled her eyes. “And you’re Percy somebody, I didn’t get your full name last December when you nearly took my head off with a *sword*.”

Oh, she was *so* enjoying this. I did my best to bite down a smile as Percy stammered, “Look, I wasn’t trying to—I didn’t mean—What are *you* doing *here*?”

“Percy, why do you think she’s here?”

He gaped at us both. “You live in New York?”

“Did you think I lived at the Hoover Dam?”

“Oh, *that* Rachel!” I cried.

“Shut up,” some guy hissed from behind us. “The cheerleaders are talking!”

Percy turned his attention to the front, where Tammi and Kelli were now giggling into the microphone. Rachel used the opportunity to knee me in the back. “Where were you?” she whispered quietly so Percy wouldn’t hear.

“Getting hit on,” I whispered back, not nearly as quiet.

“*What?!*” Percy and Rachel exclaimed in unison.

We got shushed again. I flipped the bird at the boy who had spoken. “Stop being thirsty, Brad!”

Before he could retort, Rachel stood up and grabbed me by the wrist. I winced in pain, which made her narrow her eyes, but Percy was standing with us. “What is it?” he asked.

“Later,” Rachel and I said in unison.

I offered apologies to the kids we stepped on as we hurried down the row and to the band room. “Did they follow you?” Rachel asked as she dug through the instruments.

Percy looked back and forth between us. “Are you talking about those cheerleaders? I thought you said you knew Tammi, Phoebe.”

I held out my hands. “So, about that—”

Rachel glared at me from behind Percy’s back.

“I met Tammi last summer.” I looked at Percy purposefully. “In Virginia?”

“Last summer,” he replied slowly. Then his eyes widened. “Wait, you don’t mean—she and Kelli are—”

He cut himself off and looked very purposefully at Rachel, who was now standing upright with her hands on her hips, unimpressed. “What are you two talking about?”

Percy hesitated for a breath. “Those cheerleaders... They aren’t human, are they?”

I had to give Rachel credit—she was a really good actress. Especially considering we were flying by the seat of our pants at this point. “You could see them, too?” she asked, hopeful and scared all at once.

Percy’s eyebrows rose. “You can see through the Mist.”

“The what?”

The irony of Percy explaining the Mist to Rachel when the empousai had just used it on him was not lost on me. I let Percy ‘explain’ that the Greek myths were real to Rachel, who continued to pretend like it was all new to her. “For years I thought I was going crazy,” she was saying. “I couldn’t tell anybody, I couldn’t—” Her eyes narrowed. “Wait. Who are you? I mean *really*?”

“We’re not monsters,” Percy replied quickly.

“Well I know that,” Rachel huffed, “but you aren’t human, are you?”

Percy swallowed and glanced at me. "Me and Phoebe are half-bloods," he said. "We're half human."

"And half what?"

"Half that bitch," I muttered under my breath right as the doors burst open.

Tammi and Kelli stepped into the room. "There you are, Percy Jackson," said Tammi. "It's time for your orientation!"

"We already know my brother is straight," I huffed. "So you two can go now."

"Not yet, Phoebe," Tammi replied. "We've wanted to meet your brother for a *long* time now."

Percy looked like he had just been sucker-punched, or like he had just torched the bowl of a bong and was trying not to throw up all over himself. "What do they really look like?" he said in a strangled tone. Needless to say, it did not help him beat the greening out allegations.

Tammi took another step closer and held out her pompoms. "Snap out of it!" Rachel cried.

Percy managed to take Riptide out of his pocket and uncap it. At the sight of celestial bronze, Tammi's smile turned to a sneer. "Oh come on," she said, saccharine sweet. "You don't need that. How about a kiss instead?"

"Yo, he is *way* too young for you!" I said, stepping in between them. "No biting my brother! He's taken, you tramp!"

Tammi growled. "Our Lady forbids us from harming her chosen, but if you get in the way, we will not show you leniency."

I held my ground. Behind me, Percy was swaying, still under the spell of the empousai. "You shall not pass!" I cried.

"May I, mistress?" asked Tammi.

"Our Lady?" Rachel whispered, horrified. "Mistress?"

"Yeah, they're kinky freaks," I said without looking over my shoulder. "Percy, dude, you're better than this. What would Annabeth say if she saw you thirsting over this desperate bitch?"

That got to Percy. He shook his head, his muddled expression clearing, and leveled his sword past me and at the empousa. "Stay back."

"Freshmen," she said with disgust. "This is *our* school, half-blood. We feed on whom we choose!"

"Woah, this is just like Jennifer's Body!" I cried as Tammi revealed her true form. "Gods, I'm on a tear of good 2000s queer movies..."

"Phoebe!" Rachel barked.

Percy's expression grew horrified as he stared at Tammi. "A vampire!" he exclaimed. Then his eyes fell to her legs and he added, "Uh—a vampire with—"

"Don't mention the legs!" Tammi snapped. "It's rude to make fun!"

Behind her, Kelli laughed. "A vampire, you say? That silly legend was based on us, you fool. We are empousai, servants of Hecate."

I could practically feel Rachel's glare boring a hole into my back, but I ignored her. "Vampires are actually based on the greed of capitalism," I retorted. "Marx once said—"

"Gah!" cried Tammi. "That bearded son of Nemesis was an arrogant fool!"

"Oh that's perfect," I whispered. "How do you feel about Stephenie Meyer and L.J. Smith?"

"Enough of this." Tammi licked her lips. "Dark magic formed us from animal, bronze, and ghost! We exist to feed on the blood of young men. Now come, Percy Jackson, and give me a kiss!"

She bared her fangs, and Percy—

"Gross!" I yelped when I saw his expression grow slack. His mouth had fallen open, and if I wasn't mistaken, he was close to drooling. "I did not need to know this!"

Thankfully Rachel chose that moment to throw a bongo at Tammi's head. She hissed and batted it away, but the distraction was all I needed. I raised my hand, twisted my fingers into the shape of a gun, and took aim at Tammi's head. "You shouldn't have left that Monster Donut, Tammi," I drawled in my best imitation of a cowboy, Zac Oyama Pappy style. "Bang!"

A fireball shot out of my finger. Only instead of exploding her into monster dust, the fire seemed to get absorbed into her skin. She smirked, and to my horror, her flaming hair only grew in intensity.

I stared at my finger, then at her, then back at my finger. "Motherfucker, are you serious?" I asked aloud.

"You poor baby," she teased, and *fuck* okay, fine! Maybe it was a little bit hot! "Did Circe teach you nothing about magic?"

"She must not have," said Kelli with a horrifying smile. "If she had, you would have known better than to feed me!"

"Gah! I did *not* feed you, you kinky shit!" I cried.

"Phoebe! Not the time!" Rachel cried. Gods, she and Grover were going to bond over my antics, weren't they?

She threw a xylophone at Tammi, who swatted it aside. The loud noise seemed to snap Percy out of his daze, at least. Or maybe it was Tammi settling her sights on Rachel. Either way, he

lunged forward and sliced her clean in half. With a horrible wail she exploded dust all over Rachel. “Gross!” she coughed, wiping the dust off of her face and spitting it out of her mouth.

“Monsters do that,” Percy said with a wince. “Sorry.”

“You killed my trainee!” Kelli wailed. “You need a lesson in school spirit, half-blood!”

She too began to change, which meant it was go time. While she was doing her anime-power up montage I raced over to Rachel, who handed me a true instrument of destruction. “What the fuck is going on?” she whispered to me.

“I don’t fucking know!” I hissed back.

I turned around right as Kelli’s eyes lit up with excitement. A tour group was coming. It was now or never. I picked up the bagpipes and put the reed between my lips. “Apollo, you bitch,” I garbled out.

Then I blew, and the most horrible noise known to man *exploded* out of the Scottish instrument. Tammi dropped to the ground and started wailing, and I even heard a few cries from the tour group outside of the band room. Rachel and Percy both winced, but fortunately they weren’t as affected. Percy marched up to Kelli and stabbed her in the stomach. Which, mind you, was the goal. No fireball, no firetrucks, no potential expulsion, *again*.

Only Paul threw open the door right as his future step-son stabbed a cheerleader with an Ancient Greek sword. One look at him was enough to know that Paul could see through the Mist, at least to some extent. And by that I mean he shouted, “Percy, what did you just do?”

We stood in silence, frozen. Behind Paul, a group of students all looked on with similar expressions of horror. Percy stammered out something incomprehensible. Beside me, however, Rachel was undeterred. “Phoebe,” she muttered.

I realized what she wanted me to do right away. “That’s—Rachel, I can’t—”

“You have to.”

“That’s my step-dad, dude.”

Paul followed the sound of our voices, his expression morphing into something horribly pained. “Phoebe... What’s happening here?”

Now I didn’t know Paul very well. He had stopped by for dinner a few times and we went to a Knicks game one time, but that was the extent of our relationship. Unlike Percy, I wasn’t home every time he visited Mom, which meant we couldn’t bond the way I wanted to. That didn’t make what I was about to do any easier, though.

I stepped forward and took a deep breath. Then I raised my hand, and forced myself to meet his gaze directly. “The band room door was locked. You didn’t see anything amiss. The last you saw of me and Percy, we were in the gym, joining another tour group.”

I snapped my fingers.

The wind that blew through the window was nothing like the last time I had tried this. It wasn't warm and reassuring; it was the hot, dry, wind of the desert, tearing through the room like a ventus. But the worst part was how *good* it felt. I've mentioned this before, but not casting spells leaves me feeling jittery and anxious, like a college student at 5:00 AM after writing a five page essay in one night, amped up on coffee, Red Bull, and the thrill of the pre-AI, lock-in era. So despite rationally understanding how fucked up it was to Jedi-mind trick my future step-father, I couldn't stop myself from sighing in something like relief as magic thrummed deep in my body while my mind purred like a cat in a beam of sunlight.

Paul and the rest of our future classmates stiffened, then all relaxed in unison. "Greg must have forgotten to unlock the door," Paul laughed. "The janitorial staff here at Goode is incredible, they all work hard to keep our school clean! Come on, this is a great time to meet them..."

He led the tour group out of the room. The door slowly closed behind them of its own accord, leaving me, Rachel, and Percy alone in the band room.

"Phoebe," Percy whispered, horrified.

Even though I was still torn between laughing and spinning in a circle, and throwing up at what I'd just done to the best man on the planet, I knew we couldn't afford to stay still. "We have to go," I said. "Who knows if they were the only two monsters waiting for us?"

Percy had endured mythological bullshit for long enough to go along with me without question, even though his face was a writhing storm of emotions. "Rachel should come with us," he said. "What if—What you did—What if it doesn't last?"

I glanced behind me. That hadn't been part of the plan originally, but Rachel was nodding along. "I don't know what's going on, so you better give me some answers!"

Right. We were supposed to be acting. "Yeah, sure," I replied, distracted by the euphoria in my bloodstream. "Let's find a way out of here, fast."

We wound up finding a back door that led out to an alleyway. While Percy hurried down the slight steps into the alley, Rachel held me back. "My answers?" she whispered.

"I'm bad at planning," I replied succinctly. "Now come on, we're about to—"

"Hey, you're out early!" a girl's voice laughed. "Watch where you're going, Seaweed Brain."

Me and Rachel exchanged a look. Then Rachel shouted, "Percy, wait up!"

We took off together, catching Percy at the end of the alleyway. Annabeth stood beside him—so close that I would have made fun of her under different circumstances—in a nice shirt and her favorite pair of jeans. Her hair was down and she was wearing mascara. "Not a date, my ass," I muttered to myself.

Annabeth's smile melted. She stared at Rachel, then at me, then back at Percy. "What did you do this time?" she demanded. "And who is this?"

"Oh." Percy looked between them. "Annabeth, this is Rachel. Rachel, this is Annabeth. She's a friend of mine."

I winced at the word friend. Annabeth's eyes narrowed, bouncing between me, Percy, and the flushed girl standing between us. I could practically see her start to come to conclusions. Apparently, Rachel could, too, because she chose that moment to fling her arms around my neck, hands tangled in my hair, which had curled against my wishes thanks to the humidity. "You saved me!" she babbled. "Those monsters were *horrible*, I can't believe you fought them off!"

"Monsters?" Annabeth repeated, audibly tense. "What happened in there?"

Annabeth pursed her lips when Percy got to the end of the story. To my surprise, however, she didn't berate me. "Better that than have him think you killed two cheerleaders," she decided.

Percy stared at her as if he didn't recognize her. "Paul—He's dating my mom."

"He's a mortal," Annabeth replied uncomfortably. "Didn't you say your mom was waiting to tell him?"

Percy huffed. "No. I mean, yeah, she hasn't told him about us."

"So it was probably for the best." Percy didn't look convinced by Annabeth's logic, but I offered her a grateful look for having my back.

"So you're also a demigod?" Rachel regarded Annabeth with clear apprehension. The feeling was obviously mutual, which a tiny part of me could admit was funny. A larger part remembered Annabeth's little joke from two months ago and prayed she hadn't got a good look at Rachel when I stole her away for a 'tour of campus.'

"We'll have to take a cab to camp," Annabeth muttered, reaching for her pockets. "I have some drachma—"

"No more Gray Ladies," Percy interjected vehemently.

"It'll cost a fortune to take a mortal taxi," Annabeth argued.

"I've got it," I said before they could start bickering loud enough for everyone in a three block vicinity to hear. I turned to Rachel with a grimace. "So... Guess we'll have to talk to you later, then?"

Annabeth stared at me like I was an idiot. If it wasn't such a familiar look, I might have been offended. "She's coming with us."

"She is?" I asked at the same time Rachel asked, "I am?"

Annabeth rolled her eyes. “Can you not sense it, Phoebe?”

“Um,” I replied intelligently. “Sense what?”

Annabeth rolled her eyes. “*Rachel* is a demigod. We can’t leave her behind.”

She marched off to call a taxi before we could react. Percy offered Rachel and I one confused, conflicted, look, then he hurried after Annabeth. Once they were out of earshot, Rachel and I stared at one another. “What the fuck?” I asked.

Rachel nodded sagely. “What the fuck,” she agreed.

There really wasn’t much more we could say about it than that.

Chapter End Notes

i did tag this one as being plot-divergent, chat!! who do we think rachel's parent is?? and WHY do we think Rachel is no longer a mortal? comment below :)

06/28: i slightly changed part of Annabeth and Phoebe's convo from last chapter. it's nothing major, i just realized that i needed to dig more into why Annabeth asks Phoebe to explain herself again. basically just added a paragraph :)

Chapter 3: Rachel Is (Mythologically) Gay

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

Foolishly, I thought the worst car ride of my life would be our road trip up to Maine. If only I had known then how much worse it could get.

Rachel was smart enough to call shotgun, and spent most of the drive chatting amiably with the cabby. Every few miles she would meet my eyes in the rearview mirror, alternating between the *WHAT THE FUCK IS GOING ON* face and sticking her tongue out at my misfortune.

Annabeth was practically glued to the window. Percy twitched, bounced, and squirmed beside me. Because yes, chat, I sacrificed my mental and emotional well-being and took the middle seat. “How have you been?” he hazarded over me.

Annabeth grunted.

“Have you heard anything about Nico?”

“No.”

The most painful five minutes of my life passed.

“Any word on Luke?”

I somehow managed to bite down my groan. Rachel met my eyes in the rearview, smirked openly, then went right back to her conversation with the cabbie about the new Yankee Stadium. Beneath it, though, I could sense her discomfort. At least she was *supposed* to be worried about coming to camp.

Calling Mom midway through the drive to explain what happened helped. Not just because I heard her comforting voice (“*I leave you two alone for five minutes and you fight VAMPIRES?*”), or because of the gigantic ‘I Jedi-mind tricked your future husband!’ confessional that would need to wait for a future episode, but because it was something obvious to blame my own visible nerves on, and justified my silence for the rest of the drive down the ‘Expressway.’

No. I’m still not over it! Damn you, Long Island Expresswayyyyyyy!

Apologies—I have a lot of feelings about roads. Where was I? Oh, right, going to camp with Rachel. That little situation. We inched up Half-Blood Hill like it was a minefield, or the comment section of a young Republican’s Facebook post. Rachel’s eyes were wide when she reached the crest of the hill; I figured that even with her sight—sorry, her Sight—she had been unable to see the valley until Chiron let her into camp originally. Now she was staring at

Peleus, who was curled around Thalia's tree, snorting smoke as he dreamt his cute dragon dreams. But if she could see through camp's enchantments... Then that really meant...

My hand found hers at the same time she reached for mine. I winced at the pressure but didn't let go, understanding how overwhelmed she must be feeling.

"Phoebe? Rachel?"

Percy was staring at us strangely. Right—we were supposed to have only met an hour ago. "Homophobia is *so* out, Percy, get with the times."

He was used to my antics, so he didn't stammer out any defenses. Instead he just shoved me away with a huff. Unless the car ride hadn't been enough to soothe whatever emotion he was feeling following me bewitching Paul? Which was good? I think? There was a little voice in my head that thought maybe he and Annabeth should be more worried I was willing to Hermione Granger my future father-in-law, but maybe Annabeth had the right of it. What other options did we have?

Her stormy gray eyes flicked from Rachel to me. They softened slightly, even though she was still holding herself prim and proper, like she could overcome any emotional dilemma with excellent posture and a stiff upper lip. I wondered how I had never noticed that about her before. Now that I had met her autistic military history buff father, it was obvious.

"You should bring Rachel to the Big House," she said. "Chiron will want to meet a new camper, considering..."

"Considering what?" Percy asked, oblivious.

Rachel and I shared a look.

"I need to talk to Clarisse."

Percy stared at Annabeth like she just said she wanted to use her Make-a-Wish to meet Mr. Beast. Now that we were out in the sunlight, I had a perfect view of their identical gray streaks. For as angry as it reminded me that they had to endure the weight of the sky, it was as easily the most adorable thing I had ever seen in my life. "What for?" he asked, shooketh.

"What fer?" I mumbled in my best Bill Hader impression.

"We've been trying to..." Annabeth looked at me purposefully. I'll admit I blushed; it felt pretty damn cool to be in the know with Annabeth, let me tell you! "Chiron should tell you. He'll want to see you before the hearing, anyways."

"Trying to what?" Percy said to her back as she set off into the valley. "What hearing?"

Annabeth kept jogging. I frowned when she reached the heart of camp. Campers usually started to arrive at camp around Memorial Day, with most showing up the first and second weekends of June. We got to camp around this time our first summer, and there were at least one hundred demigods. Now, there were less than forty. Camp was still camp: satyrs played their pipes in the strawberry fields to make plants grow; Hermes cabin was flying laps around

the forest atop pegasi; Athena and Demeter were having a chariot race around the track... But there was something *off*. Something that everyone seemed to determine to ignore.

Or maybe I was just projecting.

I slipped my hand back into Rachel's. Percy may as well have screamed, 'Zoinks, Scoob! Lesbians!' the way he was staring at us. I'd have to explain that girls can be friends and be totally fucking gay and it's fine (or there's a U-Haul and *a lot* of future trauma to unpack. Get it? *Unpack*? Gods I'm funny). In the meantime, we shoo'd him off to find Chiron so we could freak out in private.

"This is *really* bad," I said as soon as we were alone.

Rachel pursed her lips, but to my surprise, she didn't respond.

I sat down in the tall grass. "You're sure you weren't secretly—"

"No." Rachel jerked her head back and forth. "I was mortal. I am."

"But then how—"

"I don't know." Rachel collapsed beside me and put her head in her hands. "Phoebe. What the fuck is going on?"

I threw my hands into the air. "How am I supposed to know?"

"I don't know!"

We stewed in silence, leaving the other to their thoughts. Rachel had a habit of chewing her lip and running her fingers along her jeans, which were stained with flecks of paint and what looked like glitter. It was easy to imagine her taking a brush to the faded denim when she was anxious.

"This might not be a bad thing, actually," she ventured after a while.

"What? Are you kidding? Who's going to lead the quest through the Labyrinth now? And what about next summer? You're supposed to tell him that he *isn't* the hero. Who's going to do that now!"

Rachel frowned. "Phoebe..."

I shook my head. "*No.*"

"We have to consider the possibility that the future has changed now!"

Sometimes, she gave me this look that reminded me way too much of Annabeth. Now that I knew both of them, I better understood why Percy said they were so alike. The only difference was that *this* Rachel had *all* of her memories. So while I was a fourteen year old with the memories of reading a YA series (and enough pop culture references and hazy

recollections to put me comfortably in my 20s), Rachel was an adult trapped in the body of a fourteen year old.

There *is* a difference there, chat.

“Luke’s string was cut,” I reminded Rachel stubbornly. “Maybe this is just the universe course-correcting after you successfully dodged the love triangle!”

I knew something was really wrong when Rachel didn’t even smirk at that. “The Oracle has always been a mortal woman.”

“Oh, fuck. Really?”

Rachel regarded me like I was gum on the bottom of a railing.

“No, I’m serious!” I protested. “Since when the fuck was that a thing?”

Rachel shrugged, and continued tearing up blades of grass. “Since forever. Demigods can filter out the Mist more easily than mortals, but only a mortal can have the Sight. Which means this time around the Oracle is going to be someone else. Someone we have no idea of.”

“Are we cooked?” I whispered, then heaved a great sigh of relief. “At least mom has canonically fucked. No creepy snake powers for her.”

“*Phoebe*.”

“Sorry, sorry.” I laid down and stared at the sky, hoping it would help me focus. “If canon continues to more-or-less prevail, then we can assume this other-Rachel is going to be like you were.”

“Don’t say it—”

“*Infatuated* with my dear brother. And you’ll be a demigod. With me. Which is...” My eyes widened. “Rachel... You don’t think you’re... You know...”

Unfortunately, she understood me immediately. “Gods, I hope not.”

“It’d be so like him to annoy us both,” I sighed back. “Just wait until he shows up in your dreams and asks you for advice on what shoes to wear to the Oscars—Oh, shit.”

Belatedly we realized Chiron had approached us, looking at Rachel with something like dread. “I see you were not the only one hidden, Phoebe.”

“I—”

Chiron held up a hand and Rachel fell silent. For all that we bitched and moaned about the guy behind his back, it was hard not to listen when a horse-man thousands of years old hits you with the raised hand. The *Silence, Thot!* went unsaid, but was nevertheless perfectly communicated.

“I imagine you do not wish to explain anything to me, and I must confess, I am just as eager to remain ignorant.”

“You are?” I asked, like an idiot.

He nodded slowly, now looking back and forth between us like we were the ghost kids in *The Shining*. “If I was meant to know, I would know.”

I was surprised at how simply he spoke the words. “Just like that?” Rachel asked, confirming my suspicions.

“Just like that,” he confirmed gravely.

I gaped at him. “I thought... After the Sea of Monsters...”

“Ah.” Chiron grimaced. “I will not lie to you: when I learned that you were a witch, I wondered if the Crooked One had tricked your father.” He glanced up at the heavens warily. “Something he quickly corrected, with a long limerick extolling your graces and virtues. However... Tell me, Phoebe. Do you remember our first conversation?”

“You mean like, right after I thought my Mom died?”

It was a testament to Rachel’s patience that she didn’t punch me. Any of my other friends would have. Chiron merely smiled gently. “It’s been some time since we’ve had an optimistic hero. Most don’t get happy endings.”

“This one does,” I said, the words coming out of my lips as naturally as they had all those years ago.

Chiron nodded. “I do not know you are here, but I do know that you care immensely about your brother and your friends.”

“Then why...?”

“Have I not trained you in the art of magic?” Chiron heaved a heavy breath. “I have been forbidden.”

“You’re just a magicphobic boom—wait what?”

Chiron’s tail flickered nervously, and he once again glanced at the heavens. “I believe that your education has been entrusted to another.”

“What? Circe? You call leaving me a notebook teaching me? A few dreams? Who is she, a football coach who also happens to teach social studies? News flash, asshole! Watching a Ken Burns documentary doesn’t count as teaching!”

Chiron did nothing to hide his disdain. “I do not—”

Rachel tentatively raised her hand. “Um. Hello?”

I followed Chiron's gaze and gasped. For there, floating lazily in the air overhead Rachel's head, was a dazzling rainbow.

Once I overcame my shock at how quickly this was happening (I'd been internally preparing for a reveal in the third act), I blurted out the first thing that came to mind.

"Fuck, dude. Did the gods just out you?"

Rachel did wind up punching me that time.



News of our arrival spread quickly through camp, like gossip of the most juicy variety does at a summer camp. A new demigod was exciting in itself; satyrs were stretched so thin that it was a celebration when one returned at all, let alone with a demigod in tow. Then people found out Rachel knew the Jacksons and they were even more intrigued.

Oh, and it'd been over five decades since a child of a minor god was recognized at camp. That might have had something to do with it.

Apparently, back in the olden days of pre-World War II America, the children of the minor gods were usually placed in the cabins of the Olympian whose domain most closely overlapped with their parents. Some were easy. Children of Asclepius, report to Apollo Cabin! Deimos, you tricky bastard, send your kids to Ares now!

But what about Nemesis? What cabin does *retribution* belong to? Or Tyche, the goddess of luck? Should she go with Hermes, because he's kind of the god of poker, or Apollo, for his prophetic powers? You'd think someone would wake up and go, "Hey. What if *everyone* had a place to live?" But we're still building hostile architecture instead of investing some of the trillions of dollars floating around sociopath's pockets into public health, so I guess I shouldn't have been surprised.

The minor gods still *recognized* their children, though. That practice had only stopped following the Pact of the Big Three, which was... Suspicious. The kind of suspicious that had Rachel and I staring at one another in dread anytime we had the opportunity. Which was ridiculously uncommon; I forgot how busy days at camp were, not to mention the nosiness of my friends.

While Rachel got to know her new friends in Demeter's cabin, I was bombarded with attention. Ordinarily I'd be eating that shit up. Now I felt like I gnawing at the bit until I could confer with Rachel about what the fuck was going on. It wasn't enough that she was apparently a demigod this time around. Now she was a woke, special snowflake demigod! Tucker Carlson would have a field day if he found out.

It didn't help that there was a tension to camp that I had never seen before. Not even last year, when Thalia's tree was poisoned (yeah, chat, that was only *last year!* Being a demigod fucking sucks!), the vibes hadn't been this bad. It was a little like being at a festival that's been cancelled. Everyone is still there, and yeah, there are a few groups trying to make the most of it, but most people just want to call it a wash and come back when shit is back in order.

At first I thought it was just the usual stress. Only then I heard the whispers. The lingering glances. The hesitation. The fear.

Look, I don't want to belabor the point, because that feels very Mary Sue of me, especially when my brother is literally a son of Poseidon who was fated to save the entire world or whatever, but you guys! People were scared of me, and they were doing a *really* bad job of hiding it!

I didn't know how to react. It wasn't like I told everyone to keep it a secret, but... The only people who had been there for my magical outing were my friends. They *all* saw the aftermath of that little canon event; surely they would have thought to talk to me before they blabbed to their friends. At first I thought I had just been giving teenagers too much attention. They're about as good at hiding secrets as Drake's friends when Kendrick comes calling.

It was only when Silena, Lee, and a physically vibrating Will dragged me onto a canoe so we could 'talk in private' (like there wasn't a gaggle of naiads giggling in the water just beneath us) that I realized how stupid I'd been. Seeing no escape, I told them everything that happened between Annabeth and Percy, laughing a little when I described how often they talked about the other to me, ignorant that the other was equally as obsessed.

Then a cloud drifted over the sun and cast us all into shadow. I shivered at the lack of warmth. Silena put her hand on my arm and smiled gently. I froze at the contact, dread filling my bloodstream as everything clicked into place.

The war was well and truly on. There was a spy at camp. A spy who I had just told a lot of useful gossip for an incel and his sugar daddy to use. A spy who knew that my magic was a potential wedge to drive between me, my friends, and the rest of camp.

When the sun re-emerged from the clouds, I still felt cold.

It lingered when I sat down for dinner and saw how many empty spots there were. Hermes was the most affected, down by more than half, but there were gaps at some of the other tables, too: Ares, Demeter, and even...

Look, I know I haven't talked much about my own half-siblings lately. There's been questing to do! I bet you don't even remember their *names*, chat. How dare you! Michael sat beside Lee, face pinched as ever, while Will was exactly where he was supposed to be—with me! I fought the urge to run my hands through his hair and ask him how his school year went. Sally Jackson's mom instincts were hard to overcome in the face of such perfection. Jenny (Winona Ryder's *daughter!* You bet your ass she had been added to my popstar ascension plans) sat with her back to the table so she and her friends in Aphrodite could gossip.

Ordinarily the end of the table would be made up by the ‘youngster trio’ as I’d come to think of them in my head (I said it out loud to Lee once. He sighed, so it went back to being an inside thought). Ash, Luca, and Maya were attached at the hip. So much so that Ash convinced their parents to move their entire family to Colorado to live near Maya. ‘For security,’ of course. Me, Lee, and Silena had a bet going since my first summer about when they would start dating. Luca never seemed to mind third-wheeling; he spent all of his free-time painting. In the infirmary they worked as one mind, changing tasks and even patients seamlessly.

Now Ash and May sat huddled together and spoke quietly. Without Luca, they looked like a tricycle with its back wheel gone. I thought it was a fitting mental image for the camp at large. After all, even *Mr. D* was gone. As much as we all despised (and feared) the prick, he was a stabilizing presence that we all felt the lack of.

Not that there weren’t a few moments of levity, however. Seeing Tyson again was life-giving. He squashed me in a massive hug and babbled for five minutes about all of the projects he got to work on—

“*Under the sea!*” I sang to Percy. “*Under the seaaa!*”

I met Rachel’s eye and winked. She rolled her eyes, then went back to her conversation with Katie Gardiner about her dad’s job at General Mills. I didn’t know why she was lumped with the Demeter kids and not Hermes; wasn’t Iris a goddess of messengers, too? Maybe Rachel would be a prophet of some kind, just not *the* Oracle.

“Does that mean your mom is the god of cereal?” Rachel asked curiously.

Katie and the rest of her housemates laughed. Yeah, yeah. Rachel was a lot better at the whole ‘having memories of the future that are kind of right, but now seem very not right, but hey! It’s fine, I’m a totally normal teenage girl!’ thing. I’d made my peace with it.

I looked back at Percy, expecting him to laugh with me, but he only managed a smile that reminded me of Tina’s ‘Everything Is Okay’ face from Bob’s Burgers. I tried my best to pretend like it didn’t hurt, but that would be a complete and utter lie. I’d had enough of everyone else silently staring at me like I was an untripped land-mine. Having Percy, who had *always* stood by my side, be so conflicted... It was fucking me up, man.

*Am I losing my **gods**-damn mind? If it’s gone, where will I find, it?*

Truly, the wise words of Mr. Boss were my only comfort in such a trying time.

Grover and Chiron approached our table midway through our meal. Tyson shifted uncomfortably as soon as Grover sat. “I will go... Um... Polish my fish ponies.”

“I’ll go with,” I said quickly, like a coward.

“Nope.”

Annabeth pressed down my shoulder and forced my butt back into its seat.

Now, it wasn't *that* weird that I went to sit with Percy. Against the rules? Certainly. But because we were siblings, nobody cared that much. Annabeth, though? Whispers broke out as soon as she sat down; I even saw a child of Ares lean back so he could hand Connor a wad of cash.

I kept my mouth shut when Annabeth brought up the Labyrinth, like I always did whenever she and Grover info-dumped the plot to Percy. Plus, I was a little distracted by the irony of our conversation, considering the man totally listening in and pretending like he wasn't. Daedalus—sorry, Quintus, gods what a smug bastard—slowly chewed on a sausage, took a swig of his flask, and eyed every table but our own.

I haven't mentioned Daedalus yet, which may surprise you considering my knowledge of the future. I mean, this was *Daedalus* we're talking about. Important to the quest, sure, but the dude was a powerhouse of Greek myth. Builder of the Labyrinth, accidental (and purposeful) child-murderer, genius inventor who had clearly shaped human history behind the scenes for millennia... This dude would make any conspiracy theorist shit their britches.

So let me tell you the tea on why I was avoiding him. Daedalus was, magically speaking, totally fucked up. I could sense it coiled up in his body like a nest of squirming worms, oil and magic gushing like a million tiny rivers. I felt drawn to him the way suburban boys are drawn to videos of car crashes, the way straight trans girls are drawn to shitty men and sexy cars. There was a rush in seeing just how far he pushed himself, combining magic and metal to create something so incredibly lifelike on the surface, yet so alien just beneath the surface. I gaped openly at him.

Hey, what a minute! Hadn't I just thought that before? About the empousai? Rick, you sly, foreshadowing devil, you!

And now Daedalus was staring at me, completely unimpressed. Welp. If he didn't know I was a witch, he certainly did now considering my unabashed, jaw-dropped, glazed eye staring. Great going, me! I was really slaying lately, wasn't I?

"The Labyrinth might be Grover's last shot," Annabeth was saying.

Percy blinked. "You think Pan is underground?"

"Just like Nicole Dollanger," I said on auto-pilot.

"Who?" asked Percy.

"Exactly," I muttered darkly, and stabbed at my salad.

"Satyrs *hate* going underground," Grover said across me to Annabeth. "No searcher would ever go in *that* place. No flowers. No sunshine. No coffee shops!"

"*But*," Annabeth said, in the tone of someone who had been making this point a lot lately, and was annoyed nobody else was on the same wavelength yet, "the Labyrinth can lead you anywhere. It reads your thoughts. It was designed to fool you, to trick you and kill you; but if you could make the Labyrinth work *for* you—"

“It could lead you to the wild god,” Percy said, staring at Annabeth like she had invented the food court at Ikea. Poor boy didn’t even notice Annabeth’s flush when she looked away pointedly.

“I can’t do it.” Grover hugged his stomach. “Just thinking about it makes me want to throw up my silverware.”

“Grover, it may be your last chance,” Annabeth said. “One week or you learn to tap dance!”

“Or tightrope,” I said, elbowing him in the stomach.

Grover groaned. “Please stop.”

“Prepare the rear guard for imminent expulsion!” I cried.

Quintus cleared his throat loudly. Annabeth stiffened, then leaned forward to grab Percy’s arm tightly. “We’ll talk later.” She stood up and leveled Grover and I with a look of intense conviction. “Convince him, will you?”

I hopped to my feet and saluted. “Brace for impact, soldier.”

There were a few laughs at my back when I took off. Far less than I was expecting, though. I had a sneaking feeling it was because of something that rhymed with ‘scary bitch.’ Once I had made it down the hill I slowed to a walk, deep in thought. Rachel might not be able to lead us, but if the Labyrinth *was* as magical as Annabeth described it... I spotted her hurrying towards her cabin with the terrifying locked-in energy of a high-achieving oldest sister taking their first AP Exam.

I let her go.



The following night found everyone back at the dining pavilion. Quintus had us set up in combat armor like we were getting ready for capture the flag, but the mood among the campers was a lot more serious. Lee and the others on patrol had spotted an Aethiopian Dragon trying to breach the perimeter of camp that morning.

I was nervous for something far more consequential than a stupid dragon. Rachel and I had yet to talk; Katie and the rest of her cabin surrounded her constantly, dragging her from one activity to another like a chattering cloud of pollen. I decided to take the opportunity to catch up with my own cabinmates. Ash and Maya were as quiet and downtrodden as I expected, but the rest of us did our best to rope them into our conversations. Jenny was writing to a girl she met on a school trip to England who she kept comparing me to. Lee was going to continue his Olympic dreams at Texas A&M. I worried for my friend at a school so deep in enemy territory, but Lee was from Portland originally, which he said was just a different flavor of racist from the south.

“But you’re gay,” I said stupidly as we waited for Quintus to announce the games.

“There are gay people in Texas.” Lee glanced at Will, who was whispering with Jenny about English Girl.

I rolled my eyes. “You know what I mean.”

“Unlike you, Sunshine, I can be discreet.”

I stuck my tongue out at him right as Quintus banged the pommel of his dagger against the head table. “Right,” he said, standing up. In the torchlight, his gray hair made him look like a ghost. “Gather round, everyone.”

“The flesh reflects the madness within,” I whispered.

Lee shot me an unimpressed, but still amused, look.

“You will be in teams of two,” Quintus announced. Everybody obviously started talking and trying to grab their friends. “Which have already been chosen!” he shouted over the din.

“AWWWWW!” everyone complained.

He laid out the simple rules: collect the golden laurels tied to six ‘monsters’ in the woods. Any pairing with laurels would win glory and a ‘surprise.’ But to do that, we would need to stay alive.

Ooooooh! How spooooooky!

Everyone naturally got hyped as shit at the promise of glory and gore (Lorde reference?). I listened intently as he read through the list: The Stoll brothers were together, to nobody’s surprise. Silena and Beckendorf were paired, which made me happy and sad (*at the same time*—okay sorry I’ll stop!). They looked cute. I wondered if Aphrodite was powerful enough to keep canon on track with shipping alone. If that was the case, I wonder why she didn’t want to talk to me in New Mexico. I *so* could have convinced her that a sapphic love story is infinitely more interesting than stupid a straight ship. Percabeth excluding, of course.

And maybe, just maybe, doing so would be enough to save both their lives.

Grover was with Tyson (which neither was happy about); Katie was paired with Will, who smiled shyly at her; Clarisse, meanwhile, barred her teeth at Rachel, who merely shrugged in response and went back to polishing her dagger. Which left—

“Annabeth Chase with Percy Jackson, and Lee Fletcher with Phoebe Jackson.”

“Fuck yeah!” I cried above the din, pumping my fist in the air.

While we weren’t as naturally sneaky as the children of Hermes, we had spent enough time roaming these woods to ensure our footsteps were nearly silent. A bit of magic carried us the rest of the way home, and soon the sound of everyone else faded into the ASMR-core sounds

of the forest: owls hooting, rodents scurrying, and the occasional howl or snarl of some monstrosity of Ancient Greek myth.

Good ol' camp.

After a while, though, I found myself unable to preserve the cozy environment. "So are we going to talk about it?"

"About what?" Though his voice remained pleasant, Lee's dark eyes roamed the foliage constantly.

"Hmm, I don't know, what *could* I be talking about?"

He sighed. "Phoebe, you know that doesn't narrow it down. The Great Prophecy? You being a witch? The missing son of Hades?"

"I—you know that?"

"Dad."

"Oh that *bitch*."

"Eh, it was pretty obvious. You think Dad would pop out a kid that emo?"

"Gerard Way—"

"We don't know that."

"We *so* know that."

Lee sighed. "You want to talk about Luca?"

Now, I knew Lee was a rather laid-back dude. Being a counselor surrounded by the most energetic kids at camp for however many years can do that to a person. Plus he was an archer, which required a level of patience and dedication that I will readily admit to having none of. Shooting potshots out of a gun was more up my alley. With how much older he was than the rest of our cabin, and well... I should have known he was hiding his true feelings under a careful mask.

I hit him upside the head.

"Hey!" he complained.

"I'm not like the other kids!" I reminded him. "You don't have to sugarcoat it."

Lee rubbed his head. "Geez, Sunshine, I know that." But when he looked at me, there was still some hidden emotion, one that I couldn't name even though I knew him so well.

"Then just say it like it is!" I demanded. "Did Luca join Kronos?"

Lee's mouth turned, like he had just eaten a lemon. "He sent Ash and Maya a letter telling them to join him. But if you read it, you know he wasn't the one who wrote it. Not really."

"You mean Luke wrote it?"

"No. Ali."

Our footsteps crunched beneath our feet. "Sorry, am I supposed to know who that is?"

"She was before your time. Her last summer was before you. I had thought..."

His voice trailed out. At first I thought he was anguished. Then I realized the twist of his mouth and clenched fist were due to rage. It was the first I'd seen Lee so out of control. Not that it was anything excessive, but... Undeniably jarring.

"I thought she was going to replace me as head of Apollo one day. Then she left and never showed up. We thought something had happened to her. I reached out to her mom, but she said Ali told her she was going back to camp."

"She abandoned her mom?" I asked. "To join incel fascist Luke?"

Lee sighed. "And now so has Luca. He—really Ali, she inherited Dad's poetry, her writing was way too on the nose—sprouted the usual nonsense: the gods don't care about us, and they're the reason why the world sucks... But then he said..." Lee swallowed. "He said Dad didn't really care about us, and that's why he stopped showing up in his dreams. How he didn't realize it was because he decided to join Kronos is beyond me, but those three were never the brightest..."

"Which is ironic, considering our—"

"Dad is the sun, yeah."

Lee rolled his eyes, shook his head, then bent down and cupped his hands together. Without either of us needing to say it, we had walked to the clearing that surrounded Zeus's Fist. A much more machismo name than Zeus's shit pile if you ask me. What isn't manly about fisting? Anyway, I put a foot in Lee's hands, and with a slight grunt he launched me up to the lowest branch. I twisted around so I could pull him up, then we set about climbing so high the branches swayed in the evening breeze all around us.

Even once we were settled Lee didn't speak right away. He tapped a beat to a song I couldn't hear against his bow, cleared his throat a few times, but finally, he settled against the trunk of the tree and drew up his knee to his chin.

"If it weren't for the war, I wouldn't be coming back next summer."

"Are you shitting my dick right now?"

Lee groaned. "You know I hate it when you say that."

"Which is why I say it!"

I batted my eyes at him. He gave me the bird, which I returned without thinking. Lee rolled his eyes fondly. “Gods, I can’t wait until you have to have these conversations with them.”

My heart seemed to skip a beat. “What are you talking about?”

“When you’re head counselor next summer?”

“When I’m *WHAT?*”

Lee stared at me like I was being ridiculous. Which... I guess maybe I was. Thalia had told me last winter that he wanted me to replace him. Only it was a crazy idea; I had been at camp the least long of my half-siblings, and between all of the time I spent questing and hanging out with my brother and other friends... I still sometimes felt a bit like an outsider. The whole future memories thing certainly didn’t help me make connections with the other campers.

“But you’ll be here.”

“I’m many things, Phoebe, but I’m not a leader. Not in the way that you can be. People are drawn to you. They’ll listen to you. Me?” He smiled and shook his head. “Leave me in a tree with a bow and I’ll be happy.”

“You’re selling yourself short, Fletcher,” I argued. “You’re calm, cool, collected. *Everyone* looks up to you, dude.”

“Just like they’ll look up to you.” Lee smiled softly at me. “You won’t change my mind, Phoebe. It’s time to pass on the torch.”

I brought my knees up to my chin. And, I’ll admit it, chat: I was a tiny bit vulnerable right then. “What if they don’t accept me?”

Lee had the nerve to look at me with full incredulity. When he saw how serious the words were, however, he let out a low chuckle. His dark eyes were illuminated with the dancing stars. “Phoebe Jackson. You helped slay the minotaur, Medusa, and Echidna, mocked Ares to his face, and went to the Underworld and survived, all when you were twelve years old. At thirteen you went to the Sea of Monsters, where you found the *Golden Fleece*, fought Luke and his army, and oh yeah, *learned magic from Circe!*”

“I didn’t—”

He waved his hand. “Only the younger kids haven’t figured that out yet. Because, in case you forgot, you are the *only person in history* to have slain the Spartoi. With magic. And you apparently tried to shoot them to death in a hare-brained attempt at self-sacrifice straight out of an action movie. Besides,” he added with a smirk, “do you think any of them could say no to Miss Piggy?”

I groaned. “I’ve put that joke on the shelf.”

“So Miss Piggy isn’t still dormant inside you?”

“Now that’s just blasphemous.”

We shared a small smile. “You really know how to make a bitch sound badass,” I said with a snuffle.

He pulled me into a one-armed hug. “Don’t let it get to your head. I *really* just want to see how Annabeth deals with you at counselor meetings.”

“Oh, fuck you. I hope you have absolutely no gay sex in college.”

“So I can have straight sex?”

I wrinkled my nose. “Gross.”

“So I shouldn’t ask about that daughter of Iris—”

“Rot in hell.”

Lee’s laughter had just faded from the breeze when Annabeth and Percy appeared in the clearing below us. A clearing that would see a terrifying battle in less than a month.

A clearing where Lee Fletcher was supposed to die.

Chapter End Notes

t'was a very fast reveal, i know, but i promise there's a reason for it!

i debated for a long time who rachel's godly parent would be. apollo was certainly up there for the 'Sweet Home Alabama' jokes (shout out to That_witch_from_the_woods who called that joke like a wrestler from the top rope), and i floated a few other ideas as well: athena (or even Minerva for a future HOO idea), one of the muses, hell, with her green eyes i even considered poseidon or neptune! i would love to hear your thoughts on who it could have been, but in this universe, we're rockin with Iris.

also, is lee not the best? that dude fucking rocks.

let me know what you think! your comments are always appreciated <3

Chapter 4: I Support Child Abduction

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

Chat: I need to come clean to you about something. I haven't been fully honest with you about what I was up to between last installment and this one.

What? Do you think I learned someone else knew the future and *didn't* have an ungodly amount of tea time with them? Do you think we didn't try to figure out how Bianca not being unalived would impact things?

No, Rachel and I spent *a lot* of time planning out the next two years of our lives. Some more context of how those months went is probably in order now that we're entering questing territory or whatever. So this might not come as a surprise, but Rachel was way better at the whole 'outlining' thing. Unlike me, who suffered from the whole isekai thing (yeah, remember when *that* was my biggest source of anxiety?), her memories were immediate and perfect. While I only knew the broad strokes, she knew all of the little details: specific dates, demigods' strengths and weaknesses... So although things felt pretty firmly off the rails already, we had discussed, debated, and disagreed on a dozen different plans.

I really had to hand it to Rachel. It turned out there was a time and place for subtlety.

In this case, it meant 'accidentally' bumping into Lee when he drew an arrow to defend Annabeth and Percy from what I was mentally calling blast-ended skrewts. That half-second was all it took for Percy's butt to collide with Annabeth and she fell into the gap between the rocks. She grabbed Percy like a kitten, fingers scrunching the back of his collar and dragging him in after her. The last we heard was his strangled yelp before they vanished into thin air.

Or so it would have looked to Lee. To me, it was...

Um...

Different.

Very different.

"It *eats* people?" I whispered.

Lee stared at me. "*What* eats people?"

"Oh, gods, Annabeth doesn't know the half of it," I whispered to myself. "That means—"

I bit my lip. Rachel and I may have been able to plan out a lot, but this was something we had yet to revisit due to recent events of the rainbow goddess variety.

"Phoebe?" Lee asked.

I shook my head. “There’s something *weird* down there, and those skrewts are begging to be slain in the name of righteous glory. Get ready, and try not to let me die, okay?”

“What are you—Phoebe Jackson!”

I fell from the tree and hit the ground in a roll, coming to my feet with a revolver in either hand. Now that Percy and Annabeth had taken a tumble through the pile of poop and into the Labyrinth, we needed a crowd so nobody could get any ideas before Chiron established a perimeter around the SCP anomaly that was the Labyrinth. I figured me firing an entire chamber into one of the skrewts while screaming “BANG!” at the top of my lungs was a pretty good way of doing so.

Lee’s arrows peppered the shells of the skrewts, doing little more than annoy them. Which was fine—a distracted skrewt was not a skrewt actively focused on killing me. I alternated between firing potshots and dodging out of the way of skrewt attacks like I was in a Dark Souls game. I also wondered if I weren’t being helped by outside efforts. There was no denying I moved with the agility and, dare I say it, chat, grace of a Hunter. My gay aunt *was* based as hell, and my dad was a fuckboy twink. Really, what *else* could explain it except gay? Happy pride, bitches!

By the time the rest of camp showed up I had secured two of the laurels, but had yet to kill any of the skrewts. That little problem was saved by Clarisse, who flew into the clearing with a great roar and made mincemeat of the monstrosities. Rachel entered the clearing behind her with a bemused expression. I raised one eyebrow at her, but she only smirked and gestured at Clarisse, who threw her a laurel with a grunt and a shit-eating smirk.

That promised to be a good story (and definitely didn’t make something twist violently in my stomach), but we had the story to get through. Boo! I’ll speed run the boring parts for you: Lee and I told Chiron about the strange hole in the pile of poop, he went all, ‘dear heavens!’ and ordered everyone back, Percy and Annabeth crawled out an hour later and were all like, ‘Woah! We were in that hole for *how* long?’, and then everyone knew there was an entrance to the Labyrinth in camp.

Because we were kids or whatever, Chiron ordered us to bed. Naturally we spent most of the night talking about it. Michael, Maya, and Ash whispered about what they would need to establish a medical tent like they had last summer, while Jenny alternated between writing a letter to her friend about the situation (altered to remove anything mythological) and working on a painting, leaving Will, Lee, and I to enjoy the subtle additions to the cabin I hadn’t yet enjoyed.

A fireplace now crackled along the opposite wall of the bunkbeds, which Will and Jenny had shoved together so everyone could climb into each other’s beds. There were a few comfy chairs, a really plush rug, and some boardgames stacked beneath a coffee table that magically supplied water, juice, and even hot chocolate when the mood demanded it. Which, obviously, this situation was. I’d like to say I was annoyed with Apollo, but the cabin was significantly better now, so... Fine! The twink got a pass!

The following morning (and following a long argument that Will enjoyed *way* too much) I trudged behind Lee to the Big House. I’d broken a lot of rules in my time at camp, but

something about this felt decidedly too foreshadowey for my liking. If I had been anyone else I doubt I would have been welcomed into the head counselor meeting, but looking around the table, I realized I was now good friends with just about everyone there. I hadn't spoken much to Castor and Pollux, but then, they didn't talk much with anyone. That left Katie, who was nice enough, and Clarisse, who merely grunted when I sat down beside Lee. Everyone else smiled when they saw me, and without a word Silena put her hand into mine when I sat down beside her.

Rachel looked at it intently. I met her gaze curiously. "What are you doing here?"

"She's technically head of her cabin," Katie explained with a shrug. "Even if there isn't a physical cabin, she is a claimed daughter of Iris."

"Why doesn't she have a cabin?" Percy asked innocently.

All of the older counselors exchanged a quick flurry of looks. "The cabins are also shrines to the gods," Annabeth explained after everyone's eyes landed squarely on her. "In the old days, only the Olympians were honored with shrines so important: Zeus, Poseidon, Hera, Artemis, Hephaestus, my own mother. To have shrines for the minor gods..."

"It might offend the Olympians," Lee explained when Percy continued to stare at the room blankly. "Wish Mr. D were here. He'd be able to explain it."

"You *wish* Mr. D were here?" Beckendorf stared at Lee like he had just revealed he enjoyed pineapple on his pizza.

Chiron and Quintus entered the rec room before we could devolve into an argument about our favorite camp director. Both men eyed me speculatively at the beginning of the meeting but didn't verbally acknowledge my presence. Rachel stayed quiet as well, though she occasionally leaned over to Katie to whisper a question in her ear, like she was entirely ignorant of the conversation happening around her.

Then her eyes settled on mine and darkened. I didn't understand why at first—maybe she wanted more of a celebration for her queer-coded mother?—but then I saw her eyes were locked on where Silena and I held hands atop the ping pong table. I was about to raise my eyebrow in confusion when realization hit me like a bucket of cold water, again.

Look, it was hard to remember that Silena, the girl who had helped me prepare for my first quest, who taught me how to do my makeup and braid my hair, who snuck out to the city with me on the weekends to laugh at the boys... That my *friend* was a spy for Kronos.

Or maybe I just didn't want to believe it. Not even when I knew with absolute certainty that it was true.

"We have to get to Daedalus's workshop first," Annabeth insisted. Gods, was it hard not to look at Quintus when we kept talking about him. "We'll find Ariadne's string, and prevent Luke from using it."

"But if nobody can navigate in there," Percy said, "what chance do we have?"

“I’ve been studying architecture for years,” Annabeth retorted. “I know Daedalus’s Labyrinth better than anybody.”

“From reading about it.” Percy didn’t hide his disbelief.

“Well, yes.”

“That’s not enough.”

“It has to be!”

“It isn’t!”

“Are you going to help me or not?”

They both seemed to realize at the same time everyone was watching them like they were a ping pong match. I waved at Percy, who scowled and stared at the table, face bright red.

Chiron cleared his throat. “First things first. We need a quest. Someone must enter the Labyrinth, find the workshop of Daedalus, and prevent Luke from using the maze to invade camp.”

“To get the crown, save the town, and Mr. Krabs!” I sang under my breath.

Everyone ignored me.

“We all know who should lead this,” Clarisse said. “Annabeth.”

The room murmured its agreement. I hoped it would sooth the balm my brother wrought with his stupidity; Annabeth had wanted to lead a quest for as long as I had known her. Now she just looked uncomfortable. “You’ve done as much as I have, Clarisse. You should go, too.”

“I’m *not* going back in there.”

Travis laughed, more surprised than anything. “Don’t tell me you’re scared. Clarisse, chicken?”

She got to her feet and slammed her hands onto the table. “You don’t understand anything, punk.” Her words shook. “I’m never going in there again. Never!”

She stormed out of the room. Despite the severity of the situation, Lee met my eyes and raised his eyebrows. So not the first time that happened, then.

Once we officially voted for Annabeth we had to sit and wait for her to hear the prophecy. I was strangely at ease. None of the prophecies had been altered so far. The Fates were consistent with that, at least. I fought the urge to envelop Annabeth in the tightest hug of her life when she came downstairs. Her expression was one pure fear; her movements were stiff and robotic when she made her way across the silent room and to her chair, collapsing into it silently.

“Well?” Daedalus asked. Gods, he was a bit of an ass. I imagined he was sizing up the current generation of his half-siblings. And right now, he found them lacking.

“I heard a prophecy. I will lead the quest to find Daedalus’s workshop.”

Chiron tapped the arm of his wheelchair. “What did the prophecy say, exactly? The wording is important.”

Rachel and I tried not to lean forward too obviously.

“It... ah... Well...” Annabeth took a deep breath. “*You shall delve in the darkness of the endless maze...*”

We waited.

The dead, traitor, and lost one raise...”

Grover perked up for the first time all meeting. “The lost one! That must mean Pan! That’s great!”

“With the dead and the traitor,” Percy added. “Not so great.”

“And?” Chiron asked. “What is the rest?”

Annabeth looked around uncomfortably. When her eyes landed on me I didn’t understand. Rachel did, though. I saw the moment she connected the dots, the faint look of horror. But I got to listen right along with everyone else as Annabeth stuttered out the words in a near-whisper.

“*You shall rise or fall by the witch queen’s hand,*” Annabeth said, “*the child of Athena’s final stand!*”

Now everyone was looking at me. Even Percy, who I really needed to offer some kind of support right now. When he didn’t, I stared at the ping pong table and did my best not to let how hurt I was show. Silena squeezed my hand tightly. “Hey, we shouldn’t jump to conclusions.”

“She’s right.” Beckendorf nodded assertively and offered us a confident smile. “Annabeth isn’t the only child of Athena, right?”

Silena gave him one second to say something more, then stepped on his foot hard enough to make him yelp.

Chiron frowned at Annabeth. “Are there more lines? The prophecy does not sound complete.”

She hesitated. Then she stood up, the quiver to her upper lip suddenly gone. “Look, the point is, I have to go in. I’ll find the workshop and stop Luke. And I need help.” She turned to Percy. “Will you come?”

“I’m in.” The little wound in my chest seemed to carve itself deeper at his lack of hesitation.

She smiled gratefully, which made Percy just about melt. It was all well and cute, but... I shook my head, determined not to let anyone know how I was feeling. “I guess that makes me your witch queen or whatever,” I said airily, pushing myself to my feet. “I’m one-for-one on final stands right now, so I figure I’ve got pretty good odds.”

Rachel scoffed. “Yeah, because you had that situation under control.”

“Does that mean you’re volunteering?” I challenged.

“No,” Chiron said before Rachel could respond. He was looking back and forth between us reproachfully. “That would go against ancient laws. A hero is only allowed two companions.”

Grover wilted. “But I need to find Pan before I join the circus!”

“You’d do great, buddy,” I told him honestly, “but it doesn’t matter. You can come.”

“Phoebe,” Chiron began.

“No, think about it.” I glanced at Rachel, who did not look happy at my going off script. “Our first quest you were all, ‘a hero only has two companions!’ Then we went with four heroes and came back with four heroes.”

“But that was a unique case,” Annabeth reminded me.

“Then what about Tyson in the Sea of Monsters?” I countered. “Or last winter, when Percy and I crashed a quest meant for five. Seven heroes left and...” I forced out the final words, even though they tasted like ash, “Six came back.”

“What are you trying to say?” Connor asked, head cocked to the side.

I turned to Grover. “Sorry, buddy. I had it right our first quest. The ancient laws don’t account for satyr. Or monsters of any kind.”

I knew I had stumbled onto something because Chiron and Quintus shared an intense look. I wondered if Chiron knew who Quintus really was; keep your friends close and your enemies closer and all that. It didn’t matter, though; somehow, I had said something so profound that we were *totally* going to get away with this.

Annabeth, who had yet to look at me since she name-dropped me in her quest update, offered me a tentative, grateful smile. It widened significantly when she directed it towards Grover, who wore the same expression he had in the human hunting simulator at the Lotus Hotel. I was tempted to hand him a shotgun and see how far he could take things, Kratos style. I’d be right there with him. The gods were such fucking *losers* man! Without Tyson and Grover, we wouldn’t be here. Why didn’t they count?

“Well, Grover?” Annabeth said softly, a reminder that they had been friends for twice as long as Percy and I had known them. “The Wild God is waiting.”

He grinned. "I'll pack extra recyclables for snacks!"

"And Tyson," Annabeth said. "We'll need you, too."

"Yay! Blow things up time!" He clapped loud enough to rattle the windows.

Chiron pursed his lips. I tried not to be offended; I had to remind myself that he was a few thousand years old, and I was a fourteen year old girl who was anxiously waiting for *Girls* to start airing on television (the L Word was a canonical experience, but *Girls* hits *different*). I wasn't the most inspiring of scholars.

"Annabeth..." He began gravely. "Is this a risk you're willing to take?"

"I need them all," she insisted. "Chiron, it's important."

It was hard not to see a child pleading with their parent. Chiron's lined face softened, though he didn't look at all pleased with the conclusion. "Very well. Let us adjourn. The members of this quest must prepare themselves. Tomorrow at dawn, we send you into the Labyrinth."



I decided the plot was fucking with me when Annabeth took me by the arm and dragged me back to her cabin. I thought through a million excuses I could make to escape her clutches even for five minutes, but Rachel was jockeyed away by the other counselors as they set off to help Chiron prepare the perimeter. At the very least it meant me and Annabeth had Athena cabin to ourselves.

She sat me down in the chair opposite her, and for the next few hours she alternated between forcing me to read books at knifepoint and telling her everything I knew about magic, all while she jumped between reading, throwing her dagger at a dartboard nailed to the wall, and pacing around and around in circles.

I'm afraid I wasn't very helpful. Need I remind you, my magical powers were still pretty much just vibes. Circe's notes were *really* useful for understanding how to manipulate the Mist, but it really boiled down to manifesting the energy of Bobby Hill when he kicked that lady in the nuts.

That's my purse! I don't know you!

"Phoebe, can you *please* focus!" Annabeth's hair was out of its ponytail, frizzy and tangled all around her head.

I shifted guiltily; I must have done my Bobby Hill impression aloud. "Sorry, yes. What were you saying?"

"Do you think you'll be able to navigate it?"

“I don’t know,” I replied, infuriatingly honest. “I’ll only know once we go in.”

“But it’s made of magic,” Annabeth countered forcefully. “If you are Blessed by Hecate, you should be able to manipulate the enchantments. We might not even need Ariadne’s String! We can just get to Daedalus before Luke does!”

Maybe if I didn’t know Annabeth so well I would think she was just being confident. But beneath her fervor she was anxious—more anxious than I had ever seen her. I knew I should have told her what I saw the night before. I couldn’t, though. Not when Annabeth looked so fragile, so overwhelmed, so in need of assurance. Which was really a shame, considering I could use some assurances of my own. I still had no idea how the canon railroad track was operating now, but considering how little I’d seen of Rachel, I had a sneaking suspicion it was designed just to fuck with me. Who knew? Maybe we’d walk three feet into the Labyrinth and come out in Antarctica.

I was saved from my thought spiral by my brother, who awkwardly poked his head into the library. “Knock-knock?” he called out, like a total doofus.

Annabeth started. “Percy? Sorry, we didn’t hear you.”

“Right, Annabeth, I’ll ttyl,” I said, miming a phone next to my ear as I sprinted out of the room. I let them think I was going to let them off easy before I called over my shoulder, “Don’t fuck it up, Percy!”

Then I slammed the door shut and took off for the forest. What, did you think I would let Percy off the hook because he was being weird around me? We’re siblings! Of course I had to make fun of him!

I did my best to put him and all of my complicated feelings (gods, being hormonal *sucked*) out of mind as I trekked deeper into the woods. Once again, we should all be saying ‘Thank you, Rachel!’ because she really cooked with a secret lair for us to meet up in. During the school year she managed to convince her father to let her tour my school, which gave us a few hours to chat, but other than that, we had to find random weekends during the school year where we could both slip away, meeting up at random parks and coffee shops to plan for the end of the world.

But at camp? At camp? Oh, did we have a fucking *sick* hideout.

The further into the woods (a horrible musical, by the way) I went, the more silent my surroundings grew. Which, unfortunately, meant I was on the right track. “No scary dragon,” I murmured to myself. “You aren’t allowed to come out until next year...”

Homophobic? Perhaps. But I did not want to deal with our favorite tabasco loving friend just yet.

After half an hour of swatting gnats and glaring at various monsters that tried to come too close, I finally reached my destination. “Took you long enough,” Rachel sighed, pushing herself to her feet.

“I got distracted.”

“Percy and Annabeth?”

“Being awkward and sentimental.”

“Great, that gives us at least a few hours.” We exchanged a smirk. Then Rachel turned around and stared at the limestone cliff. “There should be a place for you to put your hand.”

“I can think of a few places—”

“Phoebe.”

“Right, sorry.”

It didn’t take long to find the subtle indents hidden amongst the jagged rocks. I slotted my hands inside of it and concentrated. Something tugged in my stomach, the feeling spreading down my arms and hands and to the very tips of my fingers. Rachel backed up when they began smoldering, and her jaw fully dropped when ghostly black flames ignited like gunpowder, sizzling across the limestone. The burning lines formed an outline of a glowing black door large enough for a warship to pass comfortably through. I backed up to join Rachel, and we watched as the slab of rock swung open silently.

“D’you think Hephaestus is going to be mad at me when I see him?” I asked after a few moments.

“Probably,” Rachel admitted.

I sighed. “Right. Let’s get after it.”

While Rachel started setting up base in one of the many garages that lined the main hangar, I cleaned. Magic made it a lot easier, which was honestly super lit. I haven’t mentioned that, but being able to magically clean up is an *incredible* perk. A few snaps of my fingers and some mild exhaustion resulted in mops racing around the dusty hangar, brooms going absolutely brazy, and wet rags cleaning the artificially lit ceiling panels. Rachel and I had yet to decide if we would magically make the space look abandoned once Leo ‘discovered’ it, or if we would leave it a mystery who had set up base here, but that was a later dilemma. I was not about to spend the foreseeable future sneezing every thirty seconds because of all the dust!

Once the hangar was reasonably safe for work I joined Rachel in the garage. I put my hands on my hips with a soft smile as she stuck drawings and documents to the walls, all of them connecting with different colored thread. Remember, Rachel was not ADHD, had an extensive history of planning art projects and protests, and also was a de facto leader of camp once she became the Oracle.

“Pepe Silvia,” I said once Rachel had finished.

“What?”

“Carol—!”

Rachel ignored me and collapsed at the center table. She plopped her feet onto the worn wood and laced her fingers behind her head. I wanted to live out my Charlie Day dreams, but ultimately we didn’t have that much time.

I’m not sure how long we went over everything. We started by double-checking the original timeline, then the potential off-shoots Bianca’s presence might cause. If you’ve seen the Loki TV show, it was sort of like how the TVA tracks Nexus Events. Each branch was denoted with a different string, with blue being the best case scenario and black being the ‘Please Say This Is Like Edge of Tomorrow’ scenario. Once we had everything squared away, we turned to the more immediate problems.

“But why Iris?” I asked for the third time, feeling far too much like Zoolander for my liking. “A demigod, sure, it means we can do more together, but why Iris?”

“Iris is the goddess of the rainbow and of messengers, right?” she said, clearly thinking through her thoughts as she spoke them. “Iris is the closest thing to a god of communication barring Hermes, who... Well, I think Iris is a lot more likely to agree to something like this. If it means... But is *that* different, too? I wonder...”

Sometimes Rachel got like this. Now that I knew both of them personally, I understood why Percy developed a crush on Rachel. I’ve already mentioned how similar they were, but I really felt it then. Just like Annabeth, Rachel was curious, opinionated, not afraid to call Percy (or anybody) an idiot, and had a strong sense of morality and loyalty. Their differences were subtle; where Annabeth wore her pride on her cheek, Rachel kept hers hidden. And although the daughter of a billionaire was somehow less presumptuous at times (see Rules 5 and 6), she was *far* more entitled. It wasn’t something she did intentionally; remember, this was the girl who spent all her free time attending protests and rallies for the good of humanity and all that.

But in a way that almost made it worse. Although she had championed movements of the oppressed, Rachel Elizabeth Dare herself was *never* oppressed directly. You know exactly the kind of person who I’m talking about. Not performatively woke, necessarily, but someone with *a lot* of blind spots. Not that I could talk, white lesbian from Bushwick that I was, but still... There was a magnitude of difference between us.

If I were talking to Annabeth right now, I would have no problem interrupting with a dumb joke that would probably make her pinch the bridge of her brow, but she would still listen to whatever I said, or at least acknowledge she had disappeared into intelligent mumbling territory and come back to the land of the living. I wasn’t, though, so I kept my mouth shut until Rachel had puzzled through whatever it was she was considering. I couldn’t say I was surprised, though, when she ultimately just changed the subject.

“What are we going to do about Silena?”

“Why?”

Rachel stared at me. “What do you mean, *why*?”

“I mean—” I stumbled, trying to justify something I had never really addressed before. In the end, I gestured at all of our work sprawled out on the walls. “We did *all* of this so we could stick as close to canon as possible so we can take down Kronos without all of our friends dying! If we want to stay as close to canon as possible, then all we need to do is be on hand to save her before she—”

“What?” Rachel was, in a word, flustered. “You don’t want to change anything?”

“What? No, that’s exactly what I’m trying to do—”

“Phoebe, seventeen campers die because of Silena’s actions.” Rachel met my gaze stonily. “Fourteen in the Battle of Manhattan. One in the sinking of the Andromeda. And two in the Battle of the Labyrinth.”

I hopped out of my chair and started pacing. “I know that! But we know we can save Lee and Castor without exposing her! We can tell Beckendorf to take a dive early with Percy, and the Battle of Manhattan will be better this time—”

“You don’t know that!” Rachel said over me. “You simultaneously think you can save everyone, *and* you think the Fates—”

“The canon railroad track—”

“—are going to keep everything the same that you need them to. It doesn’t work like that!”

“I think it’s a fix-it fic.” One glance at Rachel was enough to know that the time for jokes was far gone. I sighed petulantly and collapsed back into my chair. “I just... Rachel, the moment we *really* start messing with things is the moment we lose the only advantage we have. That’s like, Rule #1 of isekai and time-travel fics.”

“This is real life, Phoebe,” she replied, more patiently than I thought I deserved.

I looked away and tried to ignore the tight feeling in my chest, the one I had been ignoring ever since Bianca di Angelo walked out of that scrapyard with her chin held high, the one that made me question everything I had done, and everything I *hadn’t* done, since I first woke up in that dorm room at Yancy. “What do you think we should do?”

“Personally? I want to reveal my power and expose her.”

“Your power?”

A hint of a smirk graced Rachel’s features. “I can hijack Iris Messages.”

“No fucking way,” I breathed. Then I shook my hand at the heavens. “Apollo, you bitch, why didn’t you give me any cool powers!?”

Rachel glanced at the holsters stacked on the table between us. “I can say I heard them talking, and then—”

“Then what?” I said over her. “Silena is expelled from camp? *Killed*?”

“She’s a traitor!” Rachel reminded me loudly. “That’s the least she deserves!”

I realized we were both breathing really heavily. “But you said before we could use her,” I said quietly.

“That was before I was reminded of how popular she is. She’s too dangerous, Phoebe.”

I looked away. “I know.”

“Then... When it’s time... You’ll back me up?”

I was a little surprised at the vulnerability in Rachel’s tone. I don’t know if you can tell this already, but girlie was really fucking confident. And so far I had rarely challenged her—much. My bad for wanting to ride Festus into battle! Talk about being a cunty ass bitch!

Yet now Rachel was looking at me a little like how Annabeth looked at Percy in the rec room. Hesitant, hopeful, nervous... It made Rachel’s green eyes go wide, her freckles dark against her pale skin.

“Yeah.” The words came out strangely garbled, and I had to clear my throat. “I mean, yeah. Of course I will, Rachel.”

And gods damn it, I meant it! Every time I tried to conjure an image of Silena, my best friend, the traitor, all I saw was Rachel’s smile of relief after I spoke. “Okay. Right. Everything else we can deal with later. For now, focus on finding Nico, and...” She hesitated, knowing I wasn’t going to be pleased. “What *this* prophecy means.”

I looked away. “Let’s start with Nico. He’ll be at Triple-G Ranch, which should make things easy.”

Rachel chewed her lip. “Maybe. I don’t know how much we bank on the Fates—”

“Canon railroad tracks.”

“—keeping the same. Not with the new prophecy. Not with how much has already changed. I mean, look!”

And, just to demonstrate, she waved her hand and a dazzling rainbow appeared between us. “Holy shit,” I whispered. “Instant IMS?”

“I feel like a glorified iPhone,” Rachel grumbled as she wiped her hand through the rainbow.

“What else can you do?” I asked instead.

Rachel tapped the table and it changed from dark brown to white with red polka dots. I watched, entranced, as she proceeded to change the color of pretty much everything around us.

“Is food still edible? Dude, can you taste the rainbow?”

Rachel shrugged, took out a granola bar, turned it purple, and took a bite for science.

“Oh, our birthday is going to be *way* easier next year,” I breathed.

“Annabeth and Tyson bake Percy that cake, remember?”

I scowled. “*I’m* going to help. And you are too!”

Rachel put her hands. “Alright, alright. Other than that... I’m faster than I was as a mortal, and I need *way* less caffeine, though that may just be because I’m younger than when... But that’s beside the point. Phoebe, we need to focus on the Labyrinth.”

“I mean, yeah, his music goes crazy.”

“Phoebe.”

“Yeah, yeah.” I pouted for a few seconds before I sat up. “Look, I don’t think there’s much to worry about. We would have found Nico already if he was anywhere but the Labyrinth, and it’s pretty clear everyone who survives that nightmare long enough finds their way to Triple-G. Assuming Geryon knows he’s a son of Hades again he’ll keep him there, and we can swoop in and save him!”

“How?”

“Rachel, he’s like, ten years old. We can just take him.”

“You can’t just abduct a child, Phoebe.”

“I can if it saves him from Kronos!”

Rachel gave me a look that felt like she was hitting me over the head with the book on avoidance.

“Alright, alright.” I slumped in my chair. “We could IM Bianca once we get there. If she and Thalia showed up...”

“That’s assuming Nico *wants* to see his sister.”

“Are you kidding? That’s the whole reason he’s being so angsty.”

Rachel’s lips pursed. “You mean that’s why he *was* so upset last time around. This time... With Bianca alive... There’s too much we don’t know.”

“Yes, which is why I’m advocating to kidnap him.”

“Phoebe—”

“Look, if we get everyone to Geryon’s Ranch and tell him how much we love and care about him, we can overcome Minos being a creepy little loser! The power of love prevails!”

Rachel blinked. “That was the most like your father that you’ve ever sounded.”

“Oh, you bitch!” I glared at her. “That was a low blow.”

“What? Reminding you of your sunshine personality?”

“My personality is not—wait.”

“What?”

“Oh, fuck,” I breathed. “Rachel, do I get energy from the *sun*? Do I need to photosynthesize?”

Rachel eyed me critically. “I mean, it might make you more powerful—”

“Fuck fuck fuck fuck *fuck*! Rachel, I’m cooked!” I let out a wail and reached for her.

“What? Phoebe, what’s wrong?”

“The sun! Without it... I’ll die!” I gasped.

“Phoebe, what are you talking about?”

I sat up with a shudder. “When Will went to the Underworld and Tartarus he said the lack of sunlight nearly killed him. Now, that could be because he’s the most perfect angel ever and his powers are more related to the sun than me—”

“What do you mean, Will went to Tartarus? When does Will go to Tartarus?”

I stared at Rachel. Unfortunately, my growing horror at what her question might imply was drowned out in a celebratory screech. “Yes! The newer books *aren’t* canon! Well, wait, Lester better be, because Apollo *needs* that character development.”

Thunder *BOOMED*! Overhead, so loudly Rachel and I covered our ears and flinched.

“Phoebe. What do you mean, Will goes to Tartarus?” Rachel’s voice shook.

“I dunno, a year after the Giants and Triumvirate are defeated? I didn’t care about those ones nearly as much as the originals. I know they go back for Bob and Damasen, which is really cute...” I shrugged. “But you know that, right?”

Rachel stared at me, still taken aback, then shook her head. “For now, let’s focus on the Labyrinth. Even if the sun thing is true, I think it won’t affect you nearly as much. Hecate’s children are capable of more powerful magic at night, you know—”

Didn’t know that, actually!

“—and if the Labyrinth is as magical as you described, then your magic should counteract any lack of sunlight exposure. I could try to get one of those mood lamps before you leave. As for the *other* line of the prophecy... That might mean you’re going to be the one to lead everyone through the Labyrinth. I wonder...”

I fought the urge to close my eyes and listen as Rachel spoke. After years of doing everything based on vibes, it was really fucking nice to have someone else around to help me save the future.

Chapter End Notes

rachel: i'm the one who planned the quest!

phoebe: and i'm the passenger princess!

percy: i brought the snacks!

tyson: i ate the snacks :)

grover: i wanted the snacks :/

annabeth, gripping the wheel with whitened knuckles as everyone scream sings along to

Crank That: i'm going to commit vehicular manslaughter

Chapter 5: We Peer Into The Abyss Of Mommy Issues

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

The rest of the day was dedicated to getting ready for my upcoming quest. Which, following my conversation with Rachel, was more than a bit strange. I spent most of the afternoon with Will at the medical tent he and the others set up on the perimeter of Zeus's Poop Pile Fist. Fortunately Chiron had pulled a few strings to get us an express order of nectar, ambrosia, and other healing supplies from Olympus.

I did my best to be present, but every time I looked at Will, I imagined Nico. They were basically the same age, which was really the only similarity between them. Despite the tension lurking in the air Will was still as positive as ever, smiling when he re-organized my hanny pack and laughing loudly when I told him I'd bring him back a souvenir. This was my fourth quest, which I guess made Will feel more secure that I would be coming home.

Meanwhile, Nico was somewhere deep underground, being manipulated by an old ghost king to do... What? Now that Bianca wasn't unalived, what could Nico want from Minos? With that thought in mind I planted a quick kiss to Will's head and went in search of the biggest doofus at camp. As you might expect, I found him in the arena. I watched him whack a row of dummies for awhile, keeping both my literal eye and my ~magic eye~ (I don't know just go with it) peeled to make sure Daedalus or Mrs. O'Leary didn't sneak up on us.

Yes, she was as large as a tank. Yes, Percy thought she was adorable. I... Well, she was a fucking massive hellhound that could go 'chomp chomp' and I would be a screaming mess of broken bones and blood. I knew she would one day become the goodest doggie on the planet. But Daedalus? I didn't trust him, and so by extension, I couldn't trust his pet quite yet.

You might be expecting Percy and I to have some kind of emotionally intense conversation about what happened with Paul. If you have a sibling—and especially if you have a twin—you know that those conversations are a dime a dozen. Instead we just kind of looked at one another awkwardly until I cleared my throat and asked him if he'd had any dreams lately. He latched onto the subject gratefully and confirmed my suspicions that no, he hadn't weird Poseidon dreams (apparently Apollo complained about his 'fluidity' to my half-siblings all the time), so he had no idea what Nico was up to yet, either.

Once I was finished treating Percy like an NPC in a Bethesda game I tried to ask him about his conversation with Annabeth, and *fine*, maybe I asked him if he had finally grown a pair and kissed her, which culminated in him chasing me around the arena as he tried to stab me with Riptide.

One 'training session' later I stumbled to the forges, where Beckendorf and Jake Mason (stop with the foreshadowing, Fates!) showed me the improvements they were working on for my gear. I had subtly been implying for a while that we should have a 'contingency' in place in case I found myself in a cramped environment totally not conducive to a bow and arrow. Now I greedily listened as the fruits of my labour paid off. I'll clue you in on what

they had cooked up for me (aided, of course, with a few simple ‘nudges’ from me. Gods, magic was cool when the vibes were in my favor!).

First things first: remember last winter how I had to stick my guns into their holsters in order to reload them? None of that! Beckendorf made it so I could empty the chamber of its casings and it would refill automatically with bullets stored in a modified box in my softball bag. Now all I had to do was figure out how to summon my weapons like the Hunters, and I would be more unstoppable than prime Steph Curry.

Still, I now had an ungodly amount of celestial bronze bullets that should last me *years* by Beckendorf’s stern estimation, not to mention all of the emergency supplies: nectar, ambrosia, and some poultices preserved in unbreakable glass courtesy of Jake, who smiled bashfully when Beckendorf heaped praises on him for displaying such a feat of technical prowess.

Then I sat on a countertop and shot the shit with him while Beckendorf inspected my guns (not my biceps. I, unfortunately, did not have a lot of meat on those bones). I’ll spare you the full rundown; I realized about halfway through a five minute long rant about gun polish that Beckendorf might be a big fan of trains, if you catch my drift. It was really useful, though; he adjusted the barrel length and width so they would be easier to carry, and walked me through fixing a jam if they malfunctioned for any reason.

It was surreal, but also not. That was the thing about being a demigod; we sort of just picked shit up and *did* it. I mean think about it. Percy wasn’t even fifteen years old yet, had spent only two summers at camp and a few odd weekends the last few months, and he was already the second best swordsmen on the planet. There was something to be said about fighting with real stakes, but still. If you think my magic was lazy, how do you explain that? Checkmate, woke liberal America! Nepo babies are way more important than losers who ‘work hard’ for their place in society!

Unfortunately my conversation with Beckendorf veered into Silena territory. My future memories told me they were already together on the DL, but would tell everyone about their relationship following the Battle of the Labyrinth. Because there’s nothing like mortal peril to inspire you to get hitched, am I right or am I right, Baby Boomers? Only now Beckendorf seemed genuinely hesitant, like he wasn’t sure if Silena liked him back or not. Which was... Odd.

Very odd.

So odd that I couldn’t shake it from my memory when I stumbled into Aphrodite’s cabin at five in the fucking morning for my pre-quest makeover. Which was decidedly odd in itself. I’ve mentioned it already, but my fellow campers were still quite nervous about the whole ‘witch thing.’ And because this was a summer camp, pretty much everyone already knew the wording of the quest (or at least the gist of it). Which meant everyone knew that the fate of the quest pretty much came down to me.

(Quick: somebody get the metaphysical book on avoidance before past-Phoebe can ignore— Ah, fuck, she ran into the woods hissing!)

While Beckendorf and Jake couldn't care less about magic because it was so useful for the crazy weapons and inventions they came up with, the rest of camp was much more hesitant. To the children of Aphrodite, though, magic was love or something, so they were at least more on board with the idea than say, Connor and Travis, who really hadn't looked at me the same since last summer, or Ares' kids, who saw it as just another reason to hate the 'P P Jacksons.' Yes, I heard a seventeen year old child of Ares mutter that to his friend at dinner. Yes, it took immense restraint not to see if I could turn him into a chicken with the Mist.

No, they wanted to hear all about the new girl, and her sexuality, and where she bought her jeans because they're just *so* cute... And the quest. Of course they wanted to talk about the quest. To her credit, Silena noticed my reluctance as soon as the topic came up and shooed everyone else away, leaving me to soak my head in the basin of warm, sudsy water and try not to moan erotically when she starting running her fingers through my hair, tousling and teasing with gentle scratches that made me feel like a cat.

Once my hair was dry she started braiding it, which was now a much more involved process. The humidity was still making it a bitch of curls even after Silena's ministrations. I met her gaze in the mirror and found she was looking at me strangely.

"What is it?" I asked, even though I had an idea.

"I just—" She bit her bottom lip. "Your eyes have a bit of green in them."

My stomach fluttered. *Another* 10 Things I Hate About You reference? Gay? My traitorous heart beat loudly in my chest. "I hadn't noticed," I replied with an awkward laugh. "Do you like them?"

Sue me! Silena was gorgeous! She smiled as she finished twisting my hair into its braid. "Yes, Phoebe, I like your eyes."

Then, for at least half a minute, we stared at one another through the mirror. Say what you will about Silena, but we *had* become close over the last two summers. She knew better than most. Enough to see right past my facade of confidence.

"It's going to be okay," she said quietly, totally not glancing at herself in the mirror like she was trying to convince herself. "Last winter everyone thought someone would die in the desert. But you came back to us then, didn't you?"

And to my immense surprise, Silena put her hand on my cheek. "'You shall rise or fall by the witch queen's hand' could mean a million things. Maybe you're going to find, I don't know, an elevator that you need to fix to survive."

I couldn't help but smirk. "You think the Fates are willing to bank the fate of the quest on my elevator repair skills?"

Silena's laughter was like water bubbling over a stony creek. When she stopped, it was as if a dam had been erected. Abrupt and cold. "The rest of the prophecy, though... I wish you weren't going, Phoebe. I—"

She cut herself off, and suddenly I *knew*. I knew she wanted to convince me to join her in her betrayal. She was willing to put me above everyone else at camp. I was as honored as I was affronted. Thankfully she didn't go right out and say it, and we spent the rest of the beauty sesh in silence. When Silena finished and turned me around to face the mirror I couldn't help but smile. My hair shone, my braid now so long it curled around my shoulder and across my chest. Then, with a deftness that would have surprised everyone else, Silena helped me into the same leather armor Annabeth had given me for my very first game of capture the flag. I slipped my cloak over my shoulders with a flourish and stood in front of the full length mirror, Silena's head hovering over my shoulder, perfectly plump lips pursed.

"Rule 1," she whispered, the words tickling my ear and making me shiver.

"Rule 1," I nodded, fighting the odd feeling squirming around in my stomach. One that only relented when I stepped out into the cool, pre-morning air, and breathed in the smell of the dew on the grass.

Then I set off for the forest, where my fourth—and hopefully, final—quest awaited me.



My questing companions and I made for an odd sight. Of course, it was hard not to look strange, what with a satyr in Shaggy Mode, a young cyclops, and a girl cosplaying as a Ranger, but that made Percy and Annabeth's relative normality look even more strange. They wore their camp shirts and shorts (cargo for Percy, jeans for Annabeth) and had their backpacks slung over their backs. I let them talk quietly while Grover introduced me to Juniper. It was both brief and filled with tears, considering her new boyfriend was venturing into the depths of madness to find a missing god. I mean, *same*, girl.

I smiled kindly at her, pointedly did not look at Chiron and Daedalus, and approached Rachel. "What are you going to do?" I asked lowly.

She shrugged. "Help out. I mean, what else am I supposed to do?"

"Well—"

She silenced me by grabbing my cloak and concentrating. In place of the mottled greens and browns was now a cloak of darker browns and grays that would blend in more seamlessly in the Labyrinth. I found myself staring at the way her lips pursed in concentration when she worked, the tip of her tongue sticking out of her mouth. When she finished I let out a breath I didn't know I was holding and took a very purposeful step away from her.

"Cunt!" I said, my voice annoyingly breathy, and threw my cowl over my head with full dramatic relish.

Rachel laughed me off, then to my surprise, approached Annabeth and Percy. “Thanks again for saving me at Goode,” she said. “Try not to let Phoebe blow herself up.”

“Hey!” I protested, but everybody laughed.

Percy, who still seemed shocked that Rachel was a demigod, smiled sheepishly. “Don’t worry. I’ll get your girlfriend back home in one piece.”

“*Girlfriend?*” Five different voices shouted from the chaos surrounding us.

“I hate you,” I told Percy honestly. I could have responded with deadly force but held my tongue; this quest was going to offer me plenty to mock my brother for. Soon Chiron pulled him off for a bit of one-on-one time, leaving me, Rachel, and Annabeth largely alone.

I was taken aback by Annabeth’s genuine, if awkward smile. “Don’t worry about it, Rachel. Demigods have each others’ backs.”

I saw a hardness cover Rachel’s gaze for a flicker of a moment before her warm smile returned. “You’re right. We do.”

With that reminder Annabeth set off to see how the preparations were going. Rachel, meanwhile, took the opportunity to introduce herself to Tyson, who smiled widely and eagerly showed her the ‘big stick’ he found in the woods and fashioned into a weapon that could concuss an entire team of football players with one swing.

“Phoebe Jackson.”

Fuck.

Daedalus leaned against Zeus’s Fist, arms crossed, biceps bulging like that muscle arm from SpongeBob (no I was not jealous, chat!). His eyes—no, everything about him—was utterly unnatural. It felt like I was in the presence of an affront to the universe. The pleasant early-morning breeze, the whisper of the woods and the calm, steady power of nature that Circe spoke of... It all seemed to vanish in his presence, like he was a dark hole consuming everything in our surroundings.

Even, I realized when I focused more intently, the Labyrinth itself. The tendrils I had seen reaching for Annabeth and Percy now resembled Pride/the Truth’s creepy little hands in Full Metal Alchemist. Only instead of trying to pull Daedalus in, they seemed to be trying to latch onto him.

To join him, I realized dully.

“This is some Lovecraftian shit you got going on here,” I said before I could stop myself.

To my surprise, Daedalus smiled. “It is rare that someone matches all of your expectations. You are a rare sort, aren’t you?”

“I—Well,” I stammered.

He waved a hand. “Keep your secrets. You’ve been gracious enough to keep mine. Though I would not be my mother’s son if I did not admit my *burning* curiosity.”

He spoke with the quiet fervor of a preacher at the pulpit. I didn’t like it one fucking bit. “Right. Um... Good for you. Guess I’ll see you later, then?”

He laughed. “Good luck in the Labyrinth, Phoebe Jackson,” he told me, dark, empty eyes now staring at the ground. “I hope you have prepared yourself.”

When I looked down, I saw the creepy arm like tendril things had moved away from him and were not coming towards me. I darted out of the way, making a damn fool of myself as I ran and yelped across the grass like I was being chased by snakes. “There better not be a Gate!” I screamed at the top of my lungs as I ran. “I am *not* losing any body parts, do you hear me, universe!”

So (at least according to everyone else) I started with negative points on the Questing Leaderboard. Which was totally fine with me, honestly. I was too busy watching in absolute terror as the tiny little hands started wrapping around my friends and pulling them into the clutches of the Labyrinth. I’ll go ahead and say it. The whole thing reminded me of fucking Monster House. Without even stepping foot in the place, I could tell that the Labyrinth was—magically speaking—alive. It had intent. *Evil* intent.

I ran in place, made a point of hyping myself up, then I sprinted at Zeus’s Fist. As I suspected the gap widened as I approached it, looking uncannily like a Georgia O’Keefe reference and *gods why was I imagining the Labyrinth's pussy—*

I landed on a hard stone floor with a loud *oomph!* of pain, followed by a low groan when Tyson hurriedly pulled me to my feet. For a single moment I got to take in just how huge he was, so huge he had to duck his head to avoid the ceiling of the corridor, before I—

Well. How do I describe what happened? I mean, it’d be kind of bad to me to say, ‘Hey, kids! Have any of you taken shrooms, acid, cocaine, and adderall at the same time?’ So I guess I’ll just tell you what my questing companions told me happened after the fact.

Picture me wearing my badass cloak. Now picture me suddenly appearing overhead and hitting the stone floor hard enough to crack most people’s ribs. Then I bound to my feet, take one look around, and am immediately back on the ground, convulsing and groaning with my eyes rolled into the back of my head.

And that concludes my D.A.R.E. Program sponsorship! Head to ‘Silkroad.com/drugs’ for more information!

Now, to describe what happened magically. Remember all those fun little black limbs I described earlier? Picture them all deciding to cocoon me, each of them determined to make me experience one aspect of the Labyrinth’s magic. It was incredible and horrible in equal measure, like I was given a single glimpse of the Void then thrust back into my mortal body, isekai’d post-Lovecraftian Horror experience. Magic made physical distance bend like it was made of rubber. The Labyrinth was a patchwork quilt stretched across the world like a thin membrane of skin, All Tomorrows style. Magic flowed all around me like gushing blood

through veins. I could sense how it drew mortals in, snuck into their minds, rotted their brains and led them to personalized horrors conjured by the Mist and most evil nature of man...

Where the hell had my happy-go-lucky crack fic gone?

Well, I'll tell the answer: the Labyrinth was *fucking* with me. The tiny arms weren't cocooning me; they were *hugging* me! No, it was more like they were giving me a little kiss on the head to welcome me to the madhouse. I watched in a daze as they crept away from questing companions and I, disappearing into the shadows and joining the rush of magic all around me.

"Yup, that was the Gate," I wheezed, rolling around like a fish breathing out on a deck.

"Phoebe!" Percy grabbed me and pulled me into his lap. "Nectar and ambrosia, come on!"

I waved him off. "No, don't do that. I don't need more drugs right now."

"You are on drugs?" Tyson scratched his head.

"I'd be able to smell it," Grover said, though he didn't exactly look at Tyson while he spoke, and nor did he seem exactly confident in that assessment.

Annabeth understood right away. "It's the magic of the Labyrinth," she breathed, stormy eyes widening in surprise and, just beneath it, a hint of anger. "Percy, look for the Delta symbol in the wall, we'll have to bring someone else."

"No." I pushed myself out of Percy's lap and stumbled to my feet. "She was just trying to welcome me, wasn't she? You masochistic bitch, I'm not into that!"

A distant groan wailed in response.

"I do not like this," Tyson whispered to Percy, loud enough to echo in either direction.

"Neither do I," I told him bluntly. "But—Fuck, hold on. Stay out of the way a sec." I raised my hand into a gun and pointed it down the corridor. "Bang."

We all jumped when a massive explosion of fiery magic shot out of my finger like a cannon, careening down the corridor for at least ten seconds before it finally vanished from view. My questing companions looked fearfully from the now darkened corridor to me, standing stock still with my finger still raised in the air.

The only thing I remember thinking at that moment was, 'Oh.' Like a child who tried to climb onto the counter to reach the cookie jar and accidentally knocked over an entire shelf full of fine china, or a high schooler getting into their first car accident. It was very Green Goblin right before he died core.

I turned around with a smile I knew didn't extend to my eyes. "Well, I guess that line of the prophecy makes sense, at least." I snapped my fingers and a torch appeared in the air above me, floating freely with a ghostly flame that shone so brightly Grover and Tyson had to avert

their eyes. I concentrated and dimmed it a little, though it still filled the entire corridor with light.

Annabeth's expression hadn't changed the entire time. "Does this mean you can lead us to Daedalus's workshop?"

"Um." Rachel described there being some kind of glow to the ground that told her which way to go. When I looked down and concentrated on the magic, all I saw was a swirling miasma of color and texture, like a toddler's finger painting that somehow acquired half a bowl of cheerios and snot.

"Maybe?" was all I could answer. My gut was pretty strongly telling me to go right, and so with a shrug I led my companions forward.

"Keep your hands on the left wall," Annabeth said from right behind me. "We should be able to find our way out again by reversing course."

As soon as she said it, I saw the magic ripple before the left wall disappeared entirely. Then everything rippled, corridors appearing in front of me as if they had always been there. In a single moment we now stood in the center of a circular chamber with eight tunnels leading out, and no idea which one we'd come in from.

Well. For them, at least. I could sense the faint magic of my questing companions floating from one of the corridors. I didn't like doing that because it made me feel a bit too much like a hunting dog, but it was useful in moments like this.

"Left walls are mean," Tyson said. "Which way now?"

Annabeth swept her flashlight down all eight corridors. Then, almost like it pained her, she turned to me. "Phoebe?"

I shrugged, and headed towards the tunnel behind Grover. "This way."

"How do you know?" asked Percy.

"It's got good vibes."

Annabeth grabbed my arm. "What, are you serious?"

"It's..." I tilted my head to the side and thought. "Lighter."

"*Lighter*?" Annabeth spluttered.

"We're all going to die," Grover whispered to Percy, this time much more quietly than Tyson.

But Percy only had eyes for me. "If you trust it."

I did. So we set off, Annabeth muttering about deductive reasoning in the back of the party. The corridor we walked down transitioned from stone to metal to sandstone, then for a bit

was like a subway, all concrete and grime and the scuttling of rats, even though my light didn't reveal any.

"I can't stand it anymore," Grover whispered. "Are we there yet?"

"We've been down here for maybe five minutes," Annabeth told him. The *you big baby* went unsaid.

"It's been longer than that," Grover insisted.

"He's right."

I could practically hear Annabeth's brain short-circuit at my words. "How do you know that?"

"Child of Apollo thing. I knew how long we were in the Sea of Monsters for."

"Then why didn't you say anything?"

"I didn't know 'till we saw the newspaper."

"And after?"

"It wasn't relevant. Well, unless you're tracking your—"

"*Phoebe!*" Her face was bright red.

"Alright, alright! Sorry."

"It's okay." Annabeth bit her lip. I could tell she was still embarrassed, which was tragic because there's *nothing* embarrassing about natural bodily functions, but her curiosity won out in the end. "What's the conversion?"

"The conversion?" asked Tyson.

"Well, if you're gay it means—"

"Phoebe," Annabeth, Percy, and Grover groaned.

"Gods, this is such a sick questing party," I whispered. We really had the A-team here. "Uh, the conversion's sort of squiggly. Because we all experience time a little differently, you know?"

"Do you mean like how Grover was a middle schooler for six years?" asked Percy.

"Exactly like Grover being a middle schooler for six years."

"Don't remind me," Grover complained.

"But *you* know how long it's been," Annabeth reminded me.

“Right, yeah.” I concentrated as hard as I could on the idea of the sun. “It’s been about two hours. Maybe three.”

“Three hours?” Annabeth squawked.

“More or less.” I shrugged. “It’s not a big deal. Luke is similarly constrained.”

“Now you sound like Annabeth,” Percy chided me, elbowing me in the ribs.

“I can use big words too, you know!”

We kept going, bickering about how many words we knew (Annabeth didn’t join in, even though she would have smoked us) until we reached the Roman mosaic room. It was way cooler than I pictured it. Although the pictures were grimy and faded, the colors were still eye-popping. We all inspected the awe-dropping depictions of the gods, even though it was a bit like looking at a funhouse mirror. They *were* the gods, but there was something off about them. Dionysus was more handsome and way too buff. Hermes was wearing a really strange hat, and last I saw him, he didn’t have blonde hair.

“What is this place?” Percy muttered. “It’s... wrong.”

“Roman,” Annabeth corrected. “These mosaics are about two thousand years old.”

“But how can they be Roman?”

“The Labyrinth is a patchwork,” Annabeth said, confirming what I’d gleaned through magical vibe alone. “I told you, it’s always expanding, adding pieces, connecting. It’s the only work of architecture that grows by itself.”

Percy frowned. “You’re making it sound like it’s alive.”

Another groan echoed from somewhere deep in the Labyrinth.

“Can we make it a rule not to discuss it being alive?” Grover whimpered. “Please?”

“It’s not general enough to make the Rules,” I argued. “Let’s just pinky promise.”

Annabeth was far less amused than the rest of us (or terrified, in Grover’s case) but nevertheless joined our pinky chain link. She only held mine for a perfunctory amount of time before she stepped forward. “Let’s keep going.”

Tyson hesitated. “Down the hall with the bad sounds?”

Annabeth nodded assertively. “The architecture is getting older. That’s a good sign. Daedalus’s workshop would be in the oldest part.”

As soon as she finished speaking I felt the tunnel in front of us swap out with another. I bit my tongue when it quickly went from old weathered stone to cement, with brass pipes running down the sides. The walls were sprayed with graffiti that could have been tagged just hours before we showed up. Percy and I inspected it curiously.

“I don’t think this is Roman,” he said helpfully.

I pointed at a rendition of a frankly massive dick. “Nah, the Romans invented dick pics, Perce. We’re onto something here.”

“What is a dick pic?” Tyson asked.

Everyone looked at me. “Oh come on, I’m not going *that* far!” I exclaimed.

Tyson scratched his head as we set off again, through a wine cellar, some kind of metal tube, and finally into a basement. The floorboards overhead squeaked and protested like there was an entire party going on. Oh, and there was a dead milkman propped up by a door without a handle.

My questing companions approached it solemnly. I stayed back as they discussed mortality and other serious topics, like how long ago milk men were popular. Even without magic my companions knew that we had been led here deliberately. This was a warning; a reminder of what was at stake. Ordinarily I would have shrugged it off. But now... With so much changed...

I gritted my teeth and led us back into the Roman mosaic room. Only this time we weren’t alone.

Janus managed to make Daedalus look perfectly normal. He kind of reminded me of the dude from Spy Kids. You know, the one with little heads sticking out of his face? It was something about the rubberiness to his skin, the unnatural stretch of his mouth... Gods, this quest really *was* a descent into eldritch horrors, huh?

He was dressed like a New York City doorman, with all of the impatience and sliminess of Adam Sandler’s character in Uncut Gems. In the pre-quest guide, Rachel and I decided we could save Annabeth some mental anguish by having me step in here. Be all like, ‘Yo Janus! Get your *anus* out of here!’ or something.

But now that I was in his presence I was helpless to do anything. The stimulation of the Labyrinth made me feel like I was at the Lotus Hotel on cocaine and acid. Factor in Janus’s stupid creepy face that made the words of my oath to Percy echo in my head over and over and over again, reminding that everything was so dangerous now because I had somehow changed fate, even though I never *wanted* to—

A brilliant light flooded the room. Janus raised his hands to either side of his head to cover both sets of eyes. When the light died, a woman stood at the dry fountain in the center of the room. She was tall and graceful, hair the same shade and texture as mine but more lush, more shiny, more perfect than mine could ever be, and *fuck* did it make me envious. Her face was heart-shaped, angelic yet powerful, outline graceful yet athletic, perfectly poised yet perfectly relaxed.

Hera, in other words, was the walking embodiment of that America Ferrera speech in Barbie. Or, to put it more simply: she was the living embodiment of mommy issues, the source of the

most primal contradiction in history. How can the woman who brought you into this world do so much to hurt you? How can she make you crave a hot, hot, woman to call Mommy?

Not that I had that problem, of course. Sally Jackson was perfect in every way.

“You are the least subtle person on the planet.”

“Where do you think you get it from? Your mother?”

I rolled my eyes. “No, Mom is more—”

Hera’s expression narrowed on me, for just a moment. Then she looked away, like I was never there in the first place.

“Janus,” she said, and fuck was her voice warm as melted butter, “are we causing trouble again?”

I was honestly surprised when both heads didn’t say ‘yes mommy’ in the most meek tone imaginable. “N–no!” stammered one face.

“Yes!” said the other.

“Shut up!” they both said in unison.

“Excuse me?” Hera asked wryly.

I wanted to smile right along with her. I wanted to enjoy the food and drinks she summoned us, the light, cheerful magic that transformed the room into something fresh, the water of the fountain sparkling to life like it had never run dry, the mosaics as fresh and eye-catching as the day they were made...

But I remembered how much of a bitch Hera would be. How she would send *cows* after Annabeth for displeasing her. Drop a statue on Thalia’s legs just to make sure she wasn’t the hero of the prophecy. Take Percy and Jason’s memories while implanting fake ones into Jason, Piper, and Leo’s minds. Gods, wait—didn’t she trick Piper into thinking she was straight?

I contained my rage, even though it was like the crashing of a thousand waves, battering me over and over, begging me to tell Hera she represented what a toxic mom could only achieve of doing to their children. I was the golden god! I would show her!

But I knew Hera was the most fearsome of the Olympians. Athena may have been more wise, but the goddess of wisdom was not nearly as patient, or as powerful. Hera—or Juno, whatever—was a goddess that couldn’t be bargained with. She was a queen (and not in a fun camp way). She did what she wanted, when she wanted, and felt justified in doing so, all because her husband didn’t understand what ethical non-monogamy should look like.

My anger only mounted when Percy foolishly opened his mouth to bring up Thalia.

“Percy Jackson, isn’t it? One of Poseidon’s... children.” Hera’s lip wrinkled, like she would have rathered referred to him as demonspawn. “As I recall, I voted to let you live at the winter solstice. I hope I voted correctly.”

Then she turned back to Annabeth with a cheerful smile. I put my hand in Percy’s so I didn’t ‘accidentally’ shoot the Queen of Heaven in the face.

“*Minor* gods like Janus have always been frustrated by their small parts to play in the universe. Some, I fear, have little love for Olympus, and could easily be swayed to support the rise of my father.”

“Your father?” Percy said. “Oh, right. Him.”

I somehow managed not to elbow him in the ribs.

“We must watch the minor gods,” Hera said. “Janus. Iris. Morpheus.” Her lip curled once again and she hesitated for only a breath before saying, “Hecate.”

Annabeth, Grover, and Tyson eyed me nervously. Percy was too distracted by the realization that Mr. D was tasked with checking in on the other gods to notice. I chewed on the side of my cheek as Hera blathered on about how her only goal was the ‘unity of her family’ and how she would grant us a ‘wish’ like she was fucking Glinda. I noticed how her nostrils flared ever so slightly when she told us to seek out Hephaestus before she let Annabeth ask for her wish...

And then promptly make fun of her instead of providing any actual clues.

“How do we get to Daedalus’s workshop?” Annabeth asked. “That’s my wish. I want a way to navigate the Labyrinth.”

Hera looked disappointed. “So bet it. You wish for something, however, that you have already been given.”

Now everyone turned to look at me. I threw my hands in the air. “I’m swimming in magic soup right now!”

Hera didn’t hide her distaste, even though she still had yet to look at me. “The answer is within your grasp,” she said.

“But that’s not fair!” Annabeth exclaimed. “You’re not telling us what the solution is?”

Hera shook her head. “Getting something, and developing the ability to use it... Those are two different things. I’m sure your mother would agree that true wisdom comes from the journey of discovery.”

Oh, that bitch! I silently fumed as she stood up, brushed the nonexistent dust off of her dress, and reminded Annabeth that her decision was still looming. As if she hadn’t made the most heartbreaking decision of her life not two weeks ago.

When Hera left, the mosaic walls dimmed and the water vanished from the fountain. Tyson's teeth clacked together when he tried to take a bite of what I believe was his eighteenth peanut butter sandwich.

Annabeth stamped her foot. "What sort of help was that? 'Here, have a sandwich. Make a wish. Oops, I can't help you!' Poof!"

"Poof," Tyson agreed sadly, looking at his now empty plate.

"We really shouldn't be saying that, guys."

Everyone collectively ignored me.

"Well," Grover sighed. "At least we know that we *should* know the answer."

I shook my head when everyone looked at me. "I don't know what she was talking about."

"Then how did you lead us earlier?" asked Percy.

"I don't know. It just... felt right."

Annabeth stared at me, long and hard. "Alright then. Let's just keep going."

"Which way?" Percy asked me.

But this time, Grover and Tyson knew the answer before I did. "Left," they said, unison.

"How can you be sure?"

"Because something is coming from the right," said Grover.

"Something big," Tyson agreed.

"Something ugly," I added, prickles of magic now shooting down the corridor with every distant thump.

"Left is sounding pretty good," Percy decided. And together, we plunged into the dark corridor.

Chapter End Notes

mitch mcconnell is brain dead!! 🎉🎉🎉

Chapter 6: Tyson Prepares for the Revolution

Chapter Notes

this chapter is not the only thing that's a little short >:)

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

You know, after everything that happened, I was pretty fucking enthusiastic that the only obstacle we had to face on Alcatraz was Kampê.

Because there was enough else going on, I'll give you the highlights. Number one was my rendition of Johnny Cash's cover of 'Rusty Cage.' Because, duh, I knew we were on Alcatraz! You mean you haven't sunk hours into Mob of the Dead? What kind of nerd are you? Best Zombies map, hands fucking *down*, chat!

I whispered to my companions about how this island, just like most places in America, was stolen from indigenous people. I bit my lip to not say anything more; the imperial war machine was a future Phoebe problem. Now I had more pressing concerns, like not gawking when we saw Briares.

If I hadn't accidentally imagined Argus's nether regions a handful of times, I think Briares might have been my limit. There's no way I'm going to be able to describe to you what a hundred arms looks like on a person. There's just not. It was so stupid and so absurd I wanted to send him flying at Kampê like a fleshy beyblade. If I conjured an ungodly amount of duct tape and some blades, maybe my Levi Ackerman dreams could be made real.

And speaking of eyesores... Gods, was Kampê a lot, both biologically and magically. She was like a centaur, only instead of horse and man she was dragon and woman. Which unfortunately sounds incredibly hot to freaks on the internet! And like, look. Her human head *was* stupidly attractive! Like Smite or any other MOBA that sexualizes every woman it touches in the name of profit. Only capitalism had nothing to do with this monstrosity. From her head of snake hair to the strange place where dragon and human met which (for some unholy reason) bubbled between various animals and monsters. She was something half-formed, something from the beginning of time, when shapes had not been fully defined and magic still tied the foundations of reality together. She spoke in the ancient tongue, the time before the gods...

I realized later that I didn't need Tyson to translate her words for me, that I somehow had the ability to understand her. When I did remember that fun little tidbit of information I stayed up for an entire night shivering, but in the moment, I brainstormed ways we could cap Kampê before she showed up to camp while Percy cheated his way through Rock, Paper, Scissors because of ME!

“One game of rock, paper, scissors,” Percy blurted out. “If I win, you come with us. If I lose, we’ll leave you in jail.”

Annabeth looked at him like I was crazy. I had to hide a smirk once I realized what was going to happen.

Briares’s face morphed to doubtful. “I always win rock, paper, scissors.”

“Then let’s do it!” Percy pounded his fist in his palm three times.

Briares did the same with all one hundred hands, which sounded like an army marching three steps forward. He came up with a whole avalanche of rocks, a classroom set of scissors, and enough paper to make a fleet of airplanes.

“I told you,” he said sadly. “I always—” His face morphed to confusion. “What is that you made?”

“A gun,” Percy declared, showing off his finger gun. “My sister taught me that a gun beats anything.”

“Hell yeah it does, brother!” I put both my fingers into small guns and mimed like I was shooting them.

“AHH!” Grover cowered in fear with his hands over his head.

I blinked, and slowly lowered my hands. “You did not.”

He stood back upright and made a point to brush some non-existent dust off of his shirt. “I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

“Yes, you do! You thought I was going to shoot!”

“I did not!”

I put a hand to my heart, equal parts flattered and offended. “How could you doubt me?” I gasped in my best impression of a southern belle. “I am a *lady*, good sir! I am respectable, and I always choose the safest option.”

“Well—” Grover, Annabeth and even Tyson began in unison.

Fortunately for my pride and nothing else, Kampê chose that moment to notice us. Instantly a primal voice within me screamed *Run!* and so I did. We did, rather; with Annabeth at the lead we darted down a metal staircase, through a corridor past a guard’s station (where the first dog is) and into another block of prison cells.

“I remember this from our tour,” Annabeth continued right as I said, “We can sneak out past Speed Cola.”

Nobody even tried to question me this time around. We burst out the doors near the Warden’s Office and hurried down to the docks. After being inside for so long the sunlight nearly

blinded us. I stumbled; within the prison there was still plenty of magic, but out here, it felt like I had burst to the surface after doing a polar plunge into Lake Superior.

We were surrounded by a sea of clueless tourists. To the south, San Francisco gleamed, but to the north, over Mount Tamalpais, huge storm clouds swirled where Atlas was imprisoned. “It’s even worse,” Annabeth breathed. “My father said something was strange, but I should have—”

“Keep moving!” Briares wailed. “She is behind us!”

“Kampê’s too big to get through those doors,” Percy said helpfully.

Then the wall exploded (take that, Nostalgia Critic!).

Tourists screamed. I squinted my eyes so I could ‘see double’ and saw the monster as the mortals did. Which is to say, she transformed into a rogue construction crane, which I had to admit was really fucking funny. Maybe I shouldn’t have laughed, though, because Briares briefly looked like he was going to throw me at the monster and make a bid for the sea.

In reality, Kampê held two swords: long bronze scimitars that glowed with a greenish aura, boiling wisps of vapor that smelled sour and hot like a nuclear caramel apple. “Poison!” Grover yelped. “Don’t let those things touch you or...”

“You’ll die?” Percy guessed.

“After you shrivel slowly to dust, yes,” Grover replied.

“Let’s avoid the swords.”

“Briares, fight!” Tyson urged. “Grow to full size!”

“Yes, Tyson, yes!” I screamed. “Tell your fellow man to fight back against his jailors! Down with the imperialists! Skewer the Winged Beast!”

Instead, Briares looked like he was trying to shrink even smaller. I supposed he now experienced what the frigidity of Lake Superior could do to a man’s dick. I saw Percy debate fighting the monster, but then he and Annabeth shared a look and spoke in unison: “Run.”

There was no end to the debate, no way any of us could fight this thing. We ran through the docks towards the distant sight of a ferry, but Kampê’s massive strides quickly caught up to us.

“The boat?” Grover asked.

“The plane,” I said, committed to the bit until the last.

Tyson shook his head. “Too slow. Back into maze. Only chance.”

“We need a diversion,” Annabeth said.

Tyson ripped a metal lamppost out of the ground. “I will distract Kampê. You run around, back to the prison.”

“I’ll help you,” Percy declared.

“No,” Tyson argued. “Go. Poison will hurt cyclopes. A lot of pain. But it won’t kill.”

Percy didn’t look happy. “Are you sure?”

Tyson nodded. “Go. I will meet brother and sister inside.”

It was really fucking cute. I was so proud of him! Which meant that, unfortunately, I had to lie to him. With everyone distracted by the most terrifying monster imaginable, I focused on the mist swirling around us. It was the first time I planned on manipulating the Mist since I had—Fuck, since I had totally fucked with Paul’s mind! Gods fucking damn it, this *was* becoming a Harry Potter fanfic, wasn’t it?

There was nothing else for it, though. I couldn’t risk my friends getting chomped or turned into goo by Kampê. I closed my eyes and snapped. With a small pop a mirrored image out of myself seemed to step right out of my body and join my questing companions as they took off for the prison while Tyson bellowed with rage and charged Kampê like a jousting knight. He easily caught her attention, impaling her on the side of a brick wall (near where the second dog is!) She slashed her scimitars and the pole melted. Our questing companions vanished just as Tyson picked up a Dippin’ Dots and threw it at Kampê. Ice cream and poison exploded everywhere, leaving all of her little snake heads covered in sizzling ice cream.

I figured that was as good a time as any. I drew one of my revolvers, flicked open the chamber, and concentrated. The ends of the casings changed from standard celestial bronze to a dark green. “I fucking love you, Beckendorf,” I said to myself as I stepped into view, pointing my revolver at the most fearsome monster alive.

“Say goodnight, bitch!” I screamed as I shot.

The echo of the gunshot bounced chaotically across the dock and over the open water of San Francisco Bay. I scarcely heard it. I was too busy staring at Kampê, who tried to *eat* the bullet with her lion’s head. The moment its mouth closed it exploded in a shower of golden ichor that drenched Tyson and the cobblestones below. Good *gods* I love Greek Fire.

Kampê stumbled backwards due to the force. Her dark, beady eyes lasered on me, giving Tyson a perfect opportunity to leap into the air and punch her in the face. I shot Kampê in the chest, succeeding in making her stagger backwards, but already the wound around her middle was closing to reveal a snarling dog.

“God damn it, Fluffy,” I sighed.

“Not time! Go!”

Tyson easily scooped me into his arms and slung me over his back. I emptied the chamber over my shoulder, cursing every time I missed, then refilled it with another special gift from

Beckendorf. The moment I heard a roar from behind I shot another bullet over my shoulder. I heard the electric *shing!* of the enchanted net coming to life when it connected, and Kampê roared again, which meant she could *totally* melt celestial bronze with her poison.

“What the fuck is wrong with this bitch?” I screamed over her roaring.

“Be quiet,” Tyson yelled at me. “Do not die!”

“Well when you put it like that,” I muttered, but nevertheless stayed silent until we reached the rest of our questing companions.

“*Phoebe?*” Percy gasped. “But you’re—”

He, Annabeth, and Grover watched as fake Phoebe faded from view. “You know, I really should have said something when she kept her mouth shut the entire sprint for our lives,” Grover commented, in the delirious tone that only mortal peril can inspire in a person.

“Look for the mark!” Annabeth barked.

We did, and soon Grover found the Delta etched into the back of the prison cell. The stone wall opened slowly. Too slowly. Kampê was barreling towards us, swords flashing as dangerously as her eyes. Percy pushed Briares, Tyson, Annabeth, and Grover into the maze. I beat him to it, though, and shoved him through the opening.

“Phoebe—!”

“Bang!” I screamed as I leapt backwards into the Labyrinth, both guns pointed out like I was Star Lord from Infinity War giving Thanos a double bird.

It was just barely enough. Kampê staggered from the impact of both bullets and didn’t reach us in time. At the very last second her arm shot forward, but the entrance to the Labyrinth closed on her sword, snapping it in half. I rolled out of the way of the venom dripping onto the stone floor.

For a while, the only sound in the corridor was our breathing and the sizzle of venom. Slowly, I took stock of our surroundings. We were in a room full of waterfalls. Beneath our feet water rushed through a complicated path that emptied into a black hole, sort of like an open manhole on the street. But regular manholes didn’t breathe in with evil intent.

“Tartarus,” I whispered hoarsely.

Briares nodded. “Yes. I should jump in and save everyone the trouble.”

I didn’t join the Briares pity party. Not that anyone’s words worked; the moment he brought up his ‘faded’ brothers I knew there was no way he was going to listen to us. Percy marched after him when he left, leaving Tyson curled up in a large ball beside one of the waterfalls. Annabeth’s eyes were glued on the entrance to Tartarus.

Enough with the foreshadowing, jeez, I thought to the Fates.

Annabeth looked away from the pit and at me. “How were you able to do that?” she asked quietly.

“Do what?”

She gave me that perfected *You’re being an idiot* look.

“Oh, the clone? I—Well... Um...” I scratched the back of my head. How *did* I do that? It wasn’t something I had ever attempted before. “I wanted to help Tyson, and it was the only way I could think of.”

Annabeth’s expression, if possible, grew even more scornful. “You mean you didn’t know what you were doing.”

“Yeah, hasn’t that been pretty obvious?”

“Then what did that book teach you?” Grover asked.

I scowled. “That magic is all about vibes.”

“You mean you weren’t joking.” Annabeth was now openly glaring. “All this time, you’ve just been, what? Goofing around?”

“Well, no,” I protested weakly. “It’s, I don’t know, instinctive. I’m not really sure of what I can do until I try it. And there’s nothing like mortal peril to inspire you!”

Nobody, not even Tyson, laughed. So when Percy came back to us a few minutes later he lingered in the threshold awkwardly, clearly aware of the less-than-stellar vibes. Annabeth looked like she wanted to keep berating me, but instead she went and helped Tyson to his feet. “Come on. We should find a better place to make camp for the night.”

After a little while we settled on a corridor made of huge marble blocks. It looked like it could have been part of a Greek tomb, with bronze torch holders fastened to the walls. Annabeth decided it was a good sign.

“We must be close to Daedalus’s workshop,” she said. “Get some rest. I’ll take first watch.”

She didn’t need to look at me to know that I was also on first watch. I kept my back to the wall and extended my legs out in front of me as Grover, Percy, and Tyson got ready for bed. Grover was out like a light. Tyson was not. He tinkered with some metal scraps from his building kit for a while, but he kept disassembling the pieces with a frown. His eye was bloodshot from crying.

“I’m sorry about Briares,” I said.

“He was just scared,” Percy said. “I’m sure he’ll get over it.”

“He is not strong,” Tyson said. “He is not important to me anymore.”

He heaved a big sad sigh, then closed his eye. The metal pieces fell out of his hands, still unassembled, and he began to snore. I found myself looking back and forth between Percy's shield, which because of my actions was no longer melted into goo, and the holsters at my side. Last summer I tried to befriend Tyson so he could make me cool weapons at the forges. Only now I had yet to ask him for anything. I only had to wonder why for a moment when an image of Beckendorf, smirking as he showed off the insane ammo types he and Jake had cooked up, sprang to mind.

Maybe I had been bracing myself for the deaths of my friends. Maybe I was just eager to have something to remember them by. Only now that they weren't certain... I didn't know. So much of canon had stayed the same. Which was what I wanted, wasn't it? The closer to canon we were, the easier it was to predict what would happen next. Easier to try to save them. Something about the idea made my chest tighten. Rachel's face floated in my mind's eye, reminding me that *everything* had already changed.

I shoved the reminder away. I didn't need to have a panic attack while we were in the Labyrinth.

Percy eventually stood up, stretched, and sat on the wall opposite me and beside Annabeth. "You should sleep," she said, trying hard to sound stern and utterly failing.

"Can't." Percy glanced at me, like he was begging me not to make fun of him, then faced Annabeth. "You doing all right?"

"Sure. First day leading the quest. Just great."

Percy, thank the gods, knew Annabeth was being sarcastic. "We'll get there," he said, quiet and reassuring in a way I'd only seen when he was talking to me or our mother. "We'll find the workshop before Luke does."

I felt like an intruder, watching Percy watch Annabeth. The way his expression softened... The concern in his eyes, the furrow to his brow... I'd spent a lot of time making fun of my brother for his crush, but in moments like this, it was easy to understand why *everyone* at camp, even Clarisse, was rooting for them. If soulmates existed, then this was what it should look like. Not perfect. Not by a long shot. But undeniable in its quiet intensity and honesty.

I felt it when Annabeth looked at Percy like I wasn't there, like it was just the two of them, both covered in dirt and grime, physically and mentally exhausted, but still alive. Still fighting. "I just wish this quest was *logical*," she complained like a little kid. "Percy, I was kidding myself. All that planning and reading—I don't have a clue where we're going."

"You're doing great," Percy reassured her. "Besides, we never know what we're doing. I mean, we were hoping Phoebe could lead us to Daedalus's workshop."

"Hey!" I protested.

Annabeth laughed, and both my brother and I didn't react to how wet it sounded. "We should just leave you in charge of distractions," she sniffled.

“Miss Piggy hasn’t failed us yet,” Percy said with a smirk.

“Not for a lack of trying,” Annabeth murmured, but I could tell she wasn’t really mad anymore. Resignation was an emotion one had to get used to quickly when dealing with me, I’d found.

“If we could make it out of the Underworld, we can make it through a stupid maze,” Percy argued.

“We got lucky,” Annabeth argued.

“No we didn’t. Your plan worked perfectly.”

Annabeth smiled softly. “I guess. Remember when Phoebe asked Hades not to eat her?”

“Don’t remind me,” I sighed.

Percy and Annabeth laughed. “What about Polyphemus’s Island, with the sheep?” Percy continued. “Or Waterland, when you got us thrown off that ride?”

“I got us thrown off?” Annabeth retorted hotly. “That was totally your fault!”

“See? It’ll be fine so long as you’re here.”

Did you hear that? That was the sound of my heart melting into goo. Annabeth’s expression softened, and for a moment I thought she was going to reach out for his hand, or maybe his face. Instead she pulled her knees up to her chest.

“What did Hera mean when she said we knew the way through the maze? Phoebe, are you sure...”

I groaned and tried to concentrate on the magic. But it was like trying to take an ACT while construction is going on outside, 100 Gecs is being blasted full volume from the overhead speakers, and a middle school band is practicing 1812 Overture in the room over. “I think I could,” I managed. “But you might have to carry me. It’s... A lot. And if I could traverse the maze, I would...”

“You would what?” Percy asked.

But Annabeth, as always, knew what I was implying. “Nico is down here somewhere,” Annabeth said. “That’s how he disappeared from camp.”

Percy nodded and scratched the back of his head. “Oh, that makes a lot of sense. I thought he was just in a cave.”

Annabeth and I looked at him sharply. “Dreams?”

He nodded, and told us about his dreams of Nico and Minos, where Nico tried to raise the dead and muttered to the ghost king about his vengeance. All in all, it sounded really not

good. By the time he was done, Annabeth looked like she had aged five years without a wink of sleep.

“How about I take first watch?” Percy said. “I’ll wake you if anything happens.”

Annabeth looked like she wanted to protest, but then to my immense surprise, she nestled her head onto his shoulder. “Four hours,” she mumbled. “Then I’m taking watch.”

As soon as she fell asleep, I smirked at my brother. “You’re going to fall asleep with her like that.”

“Am not.”

“I’m staying up until I can take a photo.”

Percy tried to protest, but a few minutes later he was out, too. Needless to say, the picture turned out *perfect*.

Gods was I looking forward to Mount St. Helens.

Chapter End Notes

i wrote this entire chapter a month ago. feels like the fates guided my hand now that black ops 2 is available on playstation again...

Chapter 7: This Chapter Is About Cows. I'm Sorry.

Chapter Notes

CONTENT WARNING:

There is a description of a birth in this chapter. It is an adaption of Madeline Miller's *Circe* if that gives you any ideas. Obviously birth is a part of life so i debated not including this warning, but it is a little visceral and this is a crack fic so i just wanted to warn you all.

If you do not need that in your life, skip to the first sun emoji, or you can command/control f for the line, 'Needless to say, the next morning I was not fully present.'

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

In my dream I stood on a boat bobbing in the gentle waters of a harbor. The docks were a flurry of activity; fishermen, soldiers, and other men wearing garb I could best describe as 'Ancient Greek coded' shouted at one another and worked tirelessly, shielded from the sun by the shadows of a great city that loomed in the hills above us. The buildings were made of stone, weathered and worn but still somehow timeless. I could have believed I was looking at the ruins of an Ancient Greek city if it were not so busy, if there was not so much color; pillars and roofs were stained brilliant crimson, deep blue, gleaming gold... Bare-footed children raced up and down every road and alleyway, their laughter nearly as loud as the men working the docks.

"It is beautiful, is it not?" asked a man to my left.

I turned and tried hard not to gasp. "Bald," I whispered. "Bald, bald, bald..."

I should have known Daedalus would be the sort of guy to take a quick trip to Turkey to regain his masculinity. Was there such a thing as magical hair plugs? I wasn't sure, but what I *did* know was that Daedalus sans-magic/metal body had a head as bald and shiny as King Triton's. Unfortunately, he found a way to make it work. I kept finding myself drawn to his smoky eyes that held such obvious intelligence, a voice in the back of my head begged me to sit down and let him mansplain anything he wanted to me.

Luckily, our other companion was not such a fucking loser. "I have little use for beauty or vanity," Circe replied.

She was just as hot composed as I remembered her from her island, long brown hair and long legs and gorgeous green eyes. Only this time, buried just beneath the surface, I could sense a hint of tension. Looking around, I noticed that their boat was suspiciously lacking in sailors. There were a handful, sure, but not nearly enough. Beads of sweat coated the line of every

man who ran to and fro to get the ship into harbor, all while Circe and Daedalus stood completely still until they were at the docks.

A whole host of men approached, with one especially rich-looking fellow standing in the middle of an armed guard. “You are to come at once,” he declared. “You and the craftsmen both.”

I was fortunate enough to be in a dream-state, because the trek up to the castle was *long*. We climbed a massive staircase with the city of Crete spread out all around us like a honeycomb, pathways twisting this way and that, all full of bronzed men and women scurrying around like little worker bees. Our destination lay at the very top of the hive, where a mighty golden palace shone so brightly it was as if it were a sun in its own right.

The difference between the interior and exterior was stark. Without AC they did everything in their power to keep the palace cool: ventilated slits were placed strategically along the walls to allow air to flow freely, and all of the windows either faced away from the sun or were built beneath strategic overhangs so no direct sunlight could roast us all alive. I kept getting distracted by the tapestries and paintings that lined the walls, but unfortunately I had no control of my limbs; I floated like a ghost behind Circe and Daedalus, the latter of whom seemed just as keen to inspect the palace as I was.

We finally reached a massive doorway engraved with flowers and waves, so magnificently done it put the rest of the golden palace to shame. Circe’s eyes lingered on the space above the threshold, where rather than the symbol of an axe I had seen literally everywhere else, there was a carved drawing of the sun. I felt like I was missing something that should have been obvious.

The man who led us ashore turned around at the door. “The queen is within,” he announced, and knocked.

Daedalus, suddenly no longer as cool as a cucumber, leaned over to Circe. “Lady,” he said, his voice low, “I have offended you and I am sorry. But I am sorrier still for what you will find inside. I wish—”

The door opened. A handmaid stood breathless before us, her hair pinned at the top of her head. “The queen is in her labors—” she began, but another, crueler, voice cut across her.

“Is it them?”

I had no choice but to follow Circe and Daedalus into the room. At its center... At its center... There was a woman...

Fuck, chat. What I’m about to tell you is nightmare fuel. Well, unless you’re an especially kinky freak, in which case... Good for you? I guess? I don’t know, but either way: brace yourselves, and be thankful I’m affording you this moment of collection, because Circe sure as hell didn’t offer *me* any warnings.

Let me start by saying that the woman in the center of the room was gorgeous in the way only an immortal can be. Though she had the same brown hair as Circe, her eyes were an inhuman

gold, sharp and bright and vivid with malice. Even though she was a sweaty, shaking, mess, if I looked only at her face and upper body, I could forgive myself for wanting to drop to my knees and swear my undying loyalty to her. It was as if all of the light in the room was drawn to her, like she commanded the very air that we were all gracious enough to breathe.

Yeah, I'm a simp for sexy women who look like they'd degrade me. What's it to you?

Unfortunately, that vibe was ruined by the fact that she was. Um. Let's go with *heavily* pregnant.

Don't take this the wrong way. There's nothing wrong with pregnancy! I just... I don't know how to describe how wrong it was. She was *exceedingly* pregnant. Mega-pregnant? I don't know, I'm sorry! Her stomach was a swollen, distended thing that stretched the fabric of her admittedly super cunty dress to proportions that were impossible without some kind of enchantment.

"Holy octo-mom, Batman," I whispered to myself in horror.

Circe had no such qualms. "Twelve dead," she announced as she stepped forward. "Twelve men for a joke and your vanity."

The other woman smirked, and somehow managed to push herself onto her elbows. "It seemed only fair to let Scylla have her chance at you, don't you think? Let me guess: you tried to change her back." Circe's face twitched minutely, but it was enough to make the other woman laugh. "Oh, I knew you would! You made a monster, and all you can think of is how sorry you are. *Alas, poor mortals, I have put them in danger!*"

"It was you who put them in danger, sister," Circe retorted while I frowned. Scylla... She had been in my last dream! But she was a regular nymph back then. A nymph who Glaucos...

"Oh," I murmured faintly, staring at Circe. "You didn't..."

"But you are the one who failed to save them, the one who created those monsters in the first place," Pasiphaë was saying. "Tell me, did you weep as you watched them die?"

Circe inhaled slowly. "You are in error. I saw no men die. The twelve were lost on the way out."

Pasiphaë did not even pause. "No matter. More will die on every ship that passes." She tapped a finger to her chin and smirked cruelly. "How many do you think it will be in a year? A hundred? A thousand?"

I glanced at Daedalus as the two women continued to bicker. "I feel like I'm intruding," I whispered. Even though he couldn't respond, the way he lingered right next to the door and seemed to have shrunk in on himself told me we were of the same mind.

"I can tell you are not a queen," Pasiphaë was saying. "Believe me, most of the families would rather have the gold. Now, are there any other—"

She grunted and dug her nails into the arm of a handmaiden kneeling at her feet. I had not noticed the girl before, but I saw now that the skin of her arm was purple and smeared with blood.

Circe's expression hardened. "Out," she said, steel in her voice. "This is no place for you."

The attendants fled. Daedalus looked like he wanted to run as well, but before he could slip through the door, it slammed shut of its own accord.

Circe waited until the echo had faded to turn around. "Well, sister?"

"Oh, *fuck me*," I whispered. "Circe, *please* don't tell me you're going to make me watch this."

She ignored me, too focused on Pasiphaë. "What do you think?" her sister grunted. "It's been days. It needs to be cut out."

She threw back her robes, revealing the swollen skin. A ripple passed across the surface of her belly, from left to right, then back again.

I gagged. "Nope. None of that!"

"Have you tried pushing from your knees?" Circe asked, calm as can be.

"Of course I've tried it! I've had eight children! Just cut the fucking thing out of me!"

Circe drew a leather pouch from her bag. I could smell the mixture of honey, sage, apples, goat milk, hyacinths, and most of all, the soft, rosy, and delicately sweet scent of poppy. Something about it sharpened my own senses. Now when I looked at Pasiphaë, I didn't think, *Holy shit! That woman is about to give birth to a furry monster thing!* All I saw was a woman in need of help.

"Are you stupid?" Pasiphaë said savagely to her sister. "I'm not going to be put to sleep like some infant. Give me the willow bark."

"Willow is for headaches, not surgery," Circe and I said in unison.

"Give it to me!"

Circe gave it, and Pasiphaë drained the bottle. "Daedalus," she said, "take up the knife."

We all turned to face the only man in the room, who, in typical loser man fashion, was deeply uncomfortable at the sight of a pregnant woman (ignore my initial revulsion! Even the cuntiest of ladies aren't perfect!). "Pasiphaë," Circe said in the tone of voice I use when Percy tries to convince me to try a half-pipe with him, "do not be perverse. You sent for me, now use me."

Pasiphaë laughed, a savage sound. "You think I trust you with that? You are for after. Anyway, it is fitting that Daedalus should do it, he knows why. Don't you, craftsman? Will you tell my sister now, or shall we let it be a surprise?"

“I will do it,” Daedalus said to Circe. “It is my task.” He stepped to the table and took up the knife. The blade was honed to a hair’s edge.

Pasiphaë seized his wrist. “Just remember,” she hissed. “Remember what I will do if you think to go astray.”

He nodded mildly, though for the first time I saw something like anger in his eyes.

She drew her nail across the lower portion of her belly, leaving a red slice. “There,” she said.

After that... Chat. I’ll spare you all the gory details, but because I had to endure it, so do you. Pasiphaë’s blood was a mixture of red and gold and something else, something not even liquid that swirled around her as bright as the sun. Because she was an immortal, her flesh literally kept trying to stitch itself back together, that golden essence coating her skin over and over again as Daedalus repeatedly sliced into her swollen belly. Once it was finally open Pasiphaë turned to her sister.

“Now you,” she said, hoarse but stern, the model of an older-sister. “Get it out.”

Her words echoed in my mind. Not, get *him* out. Get *it* out. Somehow, her words were more horrible than the sopping mixture of immortal and mortal blood that made the couch sag, that filled the room with the stench of iron and ambrosia.

Circe must have noticed, too, for she hesitated. “What is in there?”

“What do you think? A baby.”

Circe looked at her sister, long and hard. Then, finally, she reached inside of Pasiphaë’s stomach. I surprised myself by not looking away. Even though it was really, really, nasty, I was still in that strange zone where nothing seemed to affect me. I watched clinically as Circe’s expression softened, her hands grasped onto something deep within her sister.

Then she screamed.

If I could have, I would have jumped a mile high. Daedalus did. Panicked, Circe yanked her arms, tugging and tugging and tugging and—

You know what? I’m going to stop there. Gods, it was a nightmare. I’ll tell you what you probably already know: when Circe finally got ‘it’ out of her sister, she, Daedalus, and I all stared in collective horror at the tiny little Minotaur that had bitten off two of Circe’s fingers.

“The knife,” she panted, pinning down the monster that I noticed faintly was covered in that strange golden stuff.

“I am here,” replied Daedalus, cold as stone.

“What are you doing?” Pasiphaë cried. “Do not hurt him, he must live!”

I watched as Circe and Daedalus cut the umbilical cord, then, to my absolute horror, shoved the little monster into a sack that they then squeezed into an honest-to-gods birdcage full of

screeching finches. Pasiphaë was covered in blood, her belly a slaughter-yard. Drips fell wetly to the sodden rug beneath the couch. Her eyes were wild. “You did not hurt it?”

Circe stared at her. “Are you mad? It tried to eat my hand! Tell me how such an abomination came to be.”

“Stitch me up.”

Circe, rightfully in my humble opinion, shook her head. “You will tell me, or I will let you bleed yourself dry.”

“Bitch,” said Pasiphaë.

I laughed.

Despite the bravado of her words, Pasiphaë was wheezing. The pain was wearing her away. The sisters stared at one another, golden sun meeting emerald sea. “Well, Daedalus?” Pasiphaë said at last. “It is your moment. Tell my sister whose fault this creature is.”

Annoyingly, Daedalus did not shy away, even though his face was weary and streaked with blood and sweat. “Mine,” he said. “It is mine. I am the reason this beast lives.”

From the cage, a wet chewing sound. The finches had gone silent.

“The gods sent a bull, pure white, to bless the kingdom of Minos. The queen admired the creature and desired to see it more closely, yet it ran from any who came near. So I built the hollow likeness of a cow, with a place inside for her to sit. I gave it wheels, so we might roll it to the beach while the creature slept. I thought it would only be...I did not—”

“Oh, please,” Pasiphaë spat. “The world will be ended before you stammer to your finish. Minos disrespected our marriage bed, *again*, so I fucked the sacred bull, all right? Now get the thread.”

Before anyone could respond to *that* declaration, I woke up. Even though I was not fully conscious I sprinted down the corridor of the Labyrinth and dropped to my hands and knees, where I dry heaved for a good ten minutes or so. Once my stomach had stopped contracting (the first time I thought the word I heaved so hard I started crying), I pushed myself to my feet and stumbled back to my companions. Although Grover and Tyson were both supposed to be on duty, only Grover was awake, clearly freaked out and debating whether or not he should wake up Percy and Annabeth.

We stared at one another in the gloom. “Time of the month,” I managed to get out in a strangled sort of grunt.

I didn’t wait to hear Grover’s reaction. I collapsed onto my sleeping roll, curled up into a tight little ball, and did my best not to make obvious that I was crying.



Needless to say, the next morning I was not fully present. I was too busy thinking ‘*She **FUCKED** the bull?*’ and fantasizing over the many ways I could make Minos suffer if he managed to pull a Roman Triumvirate and return to something resembling life. I’m not above admitting the appeal of a human centipede scenario with a few other sexist pigs...

That wasn’t what I was really focused on, though. Because that wasn’t the point of the dream, was it? For as much as my so-called mentor annoyed me, I knew in my gut Circe wouldn’t show me a dream like that without a point. Especially when I remembered that my father was in charge of dreams or whatever. And for as much as I thought Apollo was a loser, I didn’t think he would make me watch the Minotaur’s birth if there wasn’t a point.

But that was the question. What *was* the fucking point of that shit? My gut instinct was to focus on the cruelty of the immortals. For as slay queen, brat-pilled cunt mommy as Circe was, her sister certainly made it sound like she was responsible for Scylla and Charybdis becoming monsters. Which meant that my mentor had *a lot* of blood on her hands. Then there was Pasiphaë, who purposefully summoned her sister not only to help her birth a monster, but to make her witness the consequences of her actions. She also [REDACTED INFORMATION] just to get back her admittedly shitty husband, and in doing so birthed a monster who would go on to kill—Well. I didn’t know how many people the Minotaur killed, but I’m sure it’s a lot, gods-damn it! Besides, that monster was the one who sent my Mother to the Underworld! Seriously, fuck that thing!

(No! Not like that you sick freaks!)

I didn’t think that was the point, though. The immortals, as a rule, suck major ass. I didn’t need to witness monster birth to know that. So what else? Now that I was no longer in the thick of it (fuck off KSI), I decided Daedalus didn’t come off as nearly as much of a dick as he could have. Sure, he helped Pasiphaë [REDACTED INFORMATION]. But he did show up and help, even if he was a bit of a baby about it.

Other than that... What, was I going to have to be a midwife? That better not be the Fates showing me their foreshadow again, because this story was *not* about to become Secret Life of the American Teenager core.

I was so lost in my thoughts I didn’t notice the occult ritual site until Percy grabbed me by the arm. “Oh, fuck me,” I sighed as I remembered what we were looking at. “That little twerp...”

Percy’s flashlight illuminated a rectangular pit full of brown carbonated muck and McDonalds wrappers. Percy’s expression hardened. “Nico. He was summoning the dead again.”

Tyson whimpered. “Ghosts were here. I don’t like ghosts.”

“We have to find him,” Percy said, almost urgently.

While Percy had a well-deserved crash out, I dug through my softball bag. “What are you doing?” asked Grover.

“Gathering evidence. Chiron will need to know what Nico is doing.”

“You aren’t—Oh. Of course you are.”

Now, I want you to picture a polaroid photograph for a moment. The glossy sheen; the low focus that makes everyone look infinitely hotter and more fun, or mysterious as a photograph from Twin Peaks. That lyric from Strangers?

“I tried to be good, am I no good? Am I no good? Am I no good? Am I no good? With my memory restricted to a Polaroid in evidence,” I hummed to myself as I took the craziest polaroid of my life.

Percy and Grover thought I was being ‘seriously disrespectful,’ Tyson didn’t like the flash, but Annabeth privately shot me a grateful look when I took a few more photographs of the literal crime scene I had led us to. I prayed they’d all approve of letting me use it for an album cover somewhere down the line. My questing companions were dark blurs huddled around a grave with a McDonald’s happy meal tossed inside of it.

Art.

Now you may be saying to yourself, *Phoebe. Don’t disrespect the dead! And your promise to Bianca to keep her brother out of trouble!*

And you know, you’d be right. But also, have *you* ever dreamt of a monster birth, then woken up and seen death magic that none of your friends can see?

No?

Then shut the fuck up.

Yeah, that’s right, fuckers. When we walked into the little fucked up nightmare room, all my friends could see was the grave and the McDonald’s, accompanied the general feeling of dread that comes with the Underworld. But me? I got to sit and stare at what would have been the most fucked up thing I had seen in my life if it weren’t for Circe. Though to say I was staring at it would be exactly right. I’ve been told my attempts at describing magic are unhelpful at best, to eldritch-horror nightmare trauma at worst. To be fair, it’s hard to describe something that’s pretty much a sixth sense.

So I’ll say this: the air was full of a thick, yucky smog the color of a bruise. It was kind of like the strange cloud alien from Nope, but also kind of like the Dirty Bubble? Every time one of my questing companions brushed through it they shivered, unaware that they were quite literally being hugged by evil death magic. I locked in to get the photos we needed (and the photos *I* needed) then urged them to get the fuck out of there.

Fortunately the entrance to Geryon’s Ranch was just down the corridor. I nodded along stoically when Grover complained about something or another, too busy tapping my feet and willing myself out of the Labyrinth. As soon as Tyson opened the gate over our heads I raced forward and vaulted off of him. I inhaled deeply, grateful for the sun on my skin and the absence of creepy death magic.

Then something mooded, and I screamed loud enough that the rest of my questing companions came flying out of the hole in the ground, weapons drawn. “What is wrong?” asked Tyson. “Where is bad guy?”

“No bad guys,” I wheezed, dutifully looking at the ground. “Just cows. *Normal* cows.”

“They do not look like normal cows,” observed Tyson.

“Because they’re not,” said Annabeth. “They’re red cattle. The cattle of the sun.”

“What?” Percy and I asked in unison.

Annabeth had the audacity to offer me a tentative grin. “They’re sacred to Apollo.”

“You mean—” Percy began.

“Don’t say it!” I tried.

“*Holy* cows?”

I shook my head with a grimace. “Terrible. Just terrible.”

While I was grateful to my brother for adding some levity to the situation, I was less pleased when he, Annabeth, and Grover all started laughing at my reaction to the ‘holy cows.’ Because chat: the cows were *obsessed* with your girl. They meandered over to me, mooing in a manner that should have been very cute, but I kept imagining a screaming little monster with grubby baby hands and—

“Are you scared of cows?” asked Tyson seriously.

“Nope, not at all!” I said cheerfully. “Just—Allergic. Yeah, allergic. A-a-achoo!”

Grover lost it completely, falling onto Percy’s shoulder as his shoulders heaved with sobs. “She’s scared of cows!”

“New Yorkers,” Annabeth sighed. “They aren’t going to bite you.”

An image of bloody fingers came into my mind and I turned around to dry heave. Which, let me assure you: did nothing to help my case.

Fortunately the baying of hounds soon interrupted us. Right, focus up chat, because we were back on the canon rails! Soon enough we met Orthus, the adorable two-headed greyhound, and his gentle-giant owner, Eurytion. He was massive, nearly as tall as Tyson, wearing a *Don’t Mess with Texas* t-shirt and a denim jacket with the sleeves ripped off. He was the kind of guy who you think is going to say a slur to your face, then winds up ordering you drinks and keeping the riff-raff away from you all night so you and your friends can have fun. You might think I was projecting, but chat, he *did* give us the opportunity to head back into the Labyrinth without dealing with Geryon. However, as soon as he mentioned another demigod, we were determined.

The walk to Geryon's house was long, and for my questing companions, miserable. The air was so humid it almost felt like we were walking through a pool, and there wasn't a cloud in the sky to protect us from the sweltering sun overhead. I, on the other hand, was in my element. You might have noticed that I did not go through Will Solace sun-withdrawal syndrome, which told me he really was that bitch when it comes to children of Apollo, but that didn't mean I wasn't happy to be back in the sun. Even if I imagined my father pulling the chariot overhead with an annoying, blindingly white smirk the whole time.

I cackled like a maniac as I sprinted ahead, then spun around in a slow circle with my eyes closed and my hands stretched out wide. "I'm just a girl who's going to be okay," I whispered. "Gods, where can a bitch get a matcha latte around here?"

"You are okay?" Tyson called. Right, monster hearing.

"More than okay, buddy. Want to race?"

He scratched his head. "Not fair?"

"That's what you think," I retorted, and after confirming with a visibly nonplussed Eurytion that the trail would lead us straight to Geryon's ranch, we took off. Tyson handily destroyed me, but I was just grateful to stretch my legs and get my blood moving. Plus, it got us fucking *away* from the cows, which was really all I needed to feel better.

I joined Tyson at the crest of a ridge that overlooked the big ranch house, all white stone and wood and big windows. When the others joined us, Annabeth gasped. "It looks like a Frank Lloyd Wright!"

"That's an architect," I murmured to Percy.

"I knew that."

"Did not."

"Did too."

Eurytion grunted to interrupt us. "Don't break the rules," he warned us. "No fighting. No drawing weapons. And don't make any comments about the boss's appearance."

"Woke king," I said, impressed that he would remind us not to body-shame someone for something they can't control. I put up my hand for a knucks. "Respect."

Eurytion stared at it, then at my face, then started heading towards the ranch house. "Why?" Percy asked, hurrying to keep up with his long strides. "What does he look like?"

But Eurytion didn't need to respond, for Geryon was waiting for us on the porch. After Briares, the monster birth, and a McDonald's sponsored death ritual site, he honestly wasn't all that bad. His three-body-problem was a bit jarring to get used to, but so was his greasy black hair and pencil mustache. I've talked mad shit about a lot of men so far, but this guy looked the most like he belonged in Trump's cabinet. He looked like he would chew on a

cigar and cackle about how he was going to sell protected indigenous land to a mining corporation, then amble off to have horrible sex with an escort and think he's winning life.

I was the only member of our questing companions not to visibly gawk at the guy, so I took a step forward and extended a hand, determined to fix my image. "You must be Geryon. My father says *great* things about how you keep the cows."

Unlike Eurytion, Geryon took my hand immediately. "Does he? Tell me, girl, are you close with your lord father? I have a few questions about breeding."

I managed not to curl my lip in revulsion, but I also kind of wanted to laugh, because he sounded *just like* Daniel Craig in *Knives Out*. "I can try to get a hold of him tonight. Dreams, you know."

He laughed and slapped one of his bellies. Percy stared openly. "Hi," he said, dazed. "Nice chests—Uh, ranch! Nice ranch you have."

Before Geryon could respond, Nico came out (not like that) of the glass doors onto the porch. "Geryon, I won't wait for—"

He froze when he saw us. I did as well; somehow, I'd forgotten he made such an immediate appearance. And speaking of appearances... Gods, I wanted to dart forward and sweep him up in a big hug. He was in his official outfit: Hot-Topic core skeleton shirt and black leather aviator jacket. His face had the same color and texture as melted white wax, his eyes two dark smudges of anger.

Then he drew his sword, and any concern I had for him vanished. You know about Nico's sword, right? Stygian Iron, mined and forged in the Underworld and cooled in the River Styx? The only material capable of *absorbing* the essence of a monster, which, in other fucking words, *prevents them from returning to Tartarus*? I could feel its magic from across the porch. It was cold, heavy, and *dark*, choking the air with malicious intent. Despite the intense summer heat, I shivered.

"Put that away," Geryon snarled. "I ain't gonna have my guests killin' each other."

"But that's—"

"Percy Jackson, Phoebe Jackson, Annabeth Chase, and a couple of their monster friends. Yes, I know."

Monster friends?" Grover cried indignantly.

"That man is wearing three shirts," Tyson said, like he was just realizing it.

"Good, Tyson," I said, my voice strangled, "but we shouldn't make comments about peoples' bodies, even if it's just an observation."

Nico refused to put his sword away. "They took my sister from me," he snarled. "They want to kidnap me, to stop me!"

Percy and Annabeth exchanged a quick *What the fuck?* look. I wasn't involved, because they were in the middle of their cute era or whatever, but I certainly was thinking *what the fuck?* as well. Did a ghost eavesdrop on me and Rachel's conversation? That'd be so creepy! But more importantly... Stop him from doing *what*, exactly?

"Nico, we're not here to kidnap you," said Percy.

I grimaced and looked away, because I was *not* going to be making any promises.

"Bianca has been looking for you—"

"Don't say her name!" Nico snarled. "She's dead to me!"

Percy stared at him intensely. I don't think anyone else noticed it, but Annabeth lightly put her hand to his lower back to steady him. "Wait a minute," she said, pointing at Geryon. "How do you know our names?"

"I make it my business to keep informed, darlin,'" Geryon chuckled. "Everybody pops into the ranch from time to time. Everyone needs something from ole Geryon. Now, Mr. di Angelo, put that ugly sword away before I have Eurytion take it from you."

Eurytion sighed, but he hefted his spiked club. At his feet, Orthus growled. I bit my lip from saying something stupid about sticking it to the man. Time and place, and—

"You did it at my birthday party!" I whispered, unable to help myself.

Thankfully, everyone ignored me. Nico reluctantly sheathed his sword, and that terrible, choking magic I was doing my best to ignore vanished. "If you come near me, Percy, I'll summon help. You don't want to meet my helpers, I promise."

"I believe you," Percy said.

Geryon patted Nico's shoulder. "There, we've all made nice. Now coming along, folks. I want to give you a tour of the ranch."

I blanched. "Um. Does that include seeing my father's cows?"

"It most certainly does!" Geryon beamed.

"Maybe I could, I dunno, stay here?" I asked. "Gosh, I'm just so tired! You know how quests are."

"Phoebe," Annabeth muttered, clearly displeased.

Geryon laughed and shook his head. "Come along, now. I've got a mother who's just bursting, might be able to show you what I'm hoping your father will help with..."

As I trudged after my questing companions to the cow-themed trolley that would take us around his ranch, I raised my eyes to the heavens. "Apollo, you b—Actually, you know what? Dad, *please* don't make me see any more cow births. I'm good on that. Thanks."

“Excuse me?” Grover spluttered.

I patted him grimly on the arm. “Trust me, my dude, you do *not* want to know.”

Chapter End Notes

for my money this is the funniest final line to a chapter i've written for this fic

Chapter 8: Nico Enters The Alt-Right Pipeline

Chapter Notes

Hello! For any Harry Potter fans, I posted my first chapter of a 'Harry has a twin sister' fic. It is nothing like this series barring there being a twin, but I thought I'd shout it out :) Let me know what you think.

phoebe, lurking under my desk: 'we hates the hag! we hates her!'
me: 'i know i know, but I've had this idea for years and I'm trying to make a point about fascism and scapegoating and i'm including genderqueer characters—'
phoebe, cocking her gun: 'my precious...'

seriously though - don't financially support the hp series! fuck transphobes, fuck idiots who don't understand that transphobia just hurts women, and fuck neoliberalism!!!!!!

See the end of the chapter for [more notes](#)

My father proved to care about me at least a little bit, because I did not need to witness any cow births during our tour. Even better, I got away with dozing next to Eurytion in the back of the trolley while his boss droned on and on about his 'huge operation.' Under different circumstances I would have made a joke (you know what else is huge?), but I actually was really tired. I let Annabeth, Percy, and Grover be the main characters and figure out Geryon was the monstrous embod-ies-ment (get it?) of capitalism.

"You kill the sacred cows of the sun god for hamburger meat?" Grover asked, aghast. "That's against the ancient laws!"

"Oh, don' get so worked up, satyr. They're jus' animals."

"Just animals?!"

"Yes, and if Apollo cared, I'm sure he would tell us."

"If he knew," Percy muttered.

"Apollo sees all, knows all," I murmured, still half-asleep.

"See! If his daughter don't care, why should I?"

"*Phoebe*," Grover sighed, but I had nestled my head against Eurytion's shoulder, which was so beefy I could almost pretend it was a pillow. I expected him to push me off, but to my surprise he only adjusted slightly. I sighed in content, and got away with dozing for the rest of

the tour. I certainly smelled the flesh-eating horses, but it didn't matter. Sue me! I hadn't slept on account of my Minotaur-birth nightmare! I was distantly aware of my questing companions doing the good work of calling out Geryon for his grossly inhumane treatment of monsters and animals, which made me more proud than I can put into words, but I knew it wouldn't matter in the end.

Or at least, that's what I thought.

"My ghost told me you could help," Nico told Geryon, and it was terrible how a voice so young could sound so intense, so angry. "He said you could guide us to vanguard."

I sat up in my seat as if I had been electrocuted. "Vanguard?" I repeated stupidly. "What about a soul?"

"Whose soul? Yours?" Nico sneered. "Why would I want your soul?"

"The vanguard?" Percy repeated more warily, glancing at Annabeth. She, unlike my brother, knew immediately what Nico was getting at.

"Can you help me or not?" Nico demanded.

"Oh, I imagine I could," Geryon replied. "Your ghost friend, by the way. Where is he?"

Nico looked uneasy. "He can't form in broad daylight. It's hard for him. But he's around somewhere."

Geryon smiled. "I'm sure. Minos likes to disappear when things get... Difficult."

"*Minos?*" Percy gasped. "You mean that evil king? *That's* the ghost who's been giving you advice?"

I glanced around the moo-mobile as if I could see Minos lurking. "Bull cuck," I whispered. "Bull cuck, bull cuck, bull cuck."

"Girlie, *what* are you on about?" Eurytion said loudly.

"Nothing!" I squeaked.

"It's none of your business, Percy!" Nico turned back to Geryon. "And what do you mean about things being difficult?"

"Well, you see Nico—Can I call you Nico?"

"No."

"You see, Nico, Luke Castellan is offering very good money for half-bloods. Especially powerful half-bloods. So I can't just let you go on your way! Not when I tell him about your little *secret*. Why, he'll pay me very well indeed."

Percy and Nico drew their swords in unison. It didn't matter. Eurytion knocked Nico's sword out of his hand at the same moment Orthus pounced on Percy's chest and growled. I glanced at Annabeth, who was staring at Nico with a shocking amount of loathing. Percy, finally realizing the horrible canon-divergence that was playing out in front of us, managed to tear his gaze away from the two-dog heads whose bared fangs were inches from his throat. "Nico, you can't be serious. Why would you do that?"

"Don't pretend like you understand me!"

"Oh, that's so tweenager coded," I muttered.

"You have *got* to learn to keep your mouth shut," Eurytion sighed.

"I would stay in the car, all of you," Geryon warned us, "or Orthus will tear young Mr. Jackson's throat out. Now, Eurytion, if you would be so kind, secure Nico here."

Eurytion spit in the grass. "Do I have to?"

"Yes, you fool!"

Eurytion sighed and picked up the sword, careful not to touch the blade.

"Now," Geryon said cheerfully, "let's go back to the lodge, have some lunch, and send an Iris-message to our friends in the Titan army."

"You fiend!" Annabeth cried.

I nearly complimented her on her word choice, but Eurytion gave me a look and I clamped my mouth shut.

Geryon smiled at Annabeth. "Don't worry, my dear. Once I've delivered young Nico here, you and your party can go. I don't make it my business to interfere with quests. Besides, I've been paid quite handsomely to give you safe passage, which does not, I'm afraid, include young Nico."

"Paid by whom?" asked Annabeth. "What do you mean?"

"Never you mind that, darlin.' Let's be off, shall we?"

Percy, saying 'fuck you' to the derailed canon tracks, still volunteered to clean up the flesh-eating horse pit in order to 'free Nico.' Only this time, Annabeth, Grover, and I were all side-eyeing one another warily. Before, freeing Nico just meant unleashing one mentally ill gay child into the wild of the Labyrinth. Now, we were unleashing one mentally ill gay child to join Kronos's army. Unless we took Nico up on his offer to kidnap him, we had no way to ensure that he wouldn't jump into the alt-right pipeline like his Italian forefathers. Let's-a-go!

Once we got back to Geryon's ranch house he made Eurytion tie us all up, rodeo-style. I remembered playing enough Red Dead Redemption Two to know that being hogtied fucking sucks, so before Eurytion could even get close to me, I made my bid for freedom.

“I thought we were going to talk about your cows!” I yelled across the porch.

Geryon, who was busy tying a massive apron across his chests that read ‘KISS-THE-CHEF,’ turned with a shit-eating smirk. “We were, weren’t we? You going to behave yourself now?”

“Yes, sir,” I replied, sick to my stomach.

It was enough, though, because unlike my questing companions, I got to sit at one of the tables on the deck with only my hands tied behind my back. Chat, I’m not going to bore you with our conversation, but I’m going to go ahead and say I *felt* like I had rolled a natural 20 on a charisma check, because I managed to talk to Geryon for nearly an hour about cows. Grover’s expression was horrified by the end (I may or may not have discussed the intricacies of sacred cow paddy melts, and introduced him to the topic of Juicy Lucy’s. Minnesotans are just built different), while Eurytion looked torn between wanting to swear his next oath of loyalty to me, and knocking me upside the head with his massive club.

Once we were done and I had a whole list of questions and requests for my father that I *prayed* he never brought up to me, I cleared my throat. “Geryon, sir?”

“What is it, lassie?” he asked as he grilled up that savory sacred cow meat.

“I was wondering if you could let me talk to Nico.”

“What fer?” he asked. I mentally decided my Bill Hader impression was pretty damn accurate.

“You mean you don’t want to know why the edgy tweenager is planning on joining Kronos’s army?”

“Shoot, no. I ain’t bothered.”

“Well...” I sighed. “It was worth a shot.”

So all my hard work was for nought; by the time Percy came back to us, flushed and smelling horribly of poop but successful, I was hog-tied and bound like the rest of my questing companions. Nobody needed to tell me I was at the bottom of the leaderboard. That much was very apparent.

Percy wound up killing Geryon the exact same way he did as in my memories, with a Hera-inspired triple-heart-kill. When he came back out to the porch Annabeth made a horribly soppy noise against her gag that made my heart melt, but there wasn’t enough time to focus on it. Because once Percy had all of us untied and unbound, we had to acknowledge the ginormous fucking elephant in the room.

“I’m going to untie him,” Percy declared.

Annabeth put a hand on his forearm. “Wait.”

“What do you mean, wait?” he retorted hotly. “We aren’t going to leave him here.”

“I’m not saying that. Only...” Annabeth opened her mouth, but something about Percy’s expression made her hesitate.

“He said he was going to join Kronos,” I said for her. His name lingered in the air between us. “We can’t just ignore that.”

“Why?” asked Grover. “Why would he want to join him?”

I had a horrible suspicion, but before anyone could stop him Percy leaned down and tugged the strip of leather out of Nico’s mouth. He glowered up at us defiantly. “Nico,” Percy began.

“No.” To his credit, Nico didn’t squirm, and didn’t shy away from the truth. “The gods stole my sister away from me. She *abandoned* me, then you all left me behind, too! At that stupid camp, where I would have to spend my entire life crammed in Hermes’ cabin, like I don’t matter, like I don’t belong! Why should I care about you, when you don’t care about me?”

“We didn’t have a choice,” Percy began. It was the wrong thing to say.

“There’s always a choice,” Nico spit. “You either are going to have to kidnap me or kill me, because I’m not coming with you willingly. I’d decide quick, if I were you.”

He glanced past us at the setting sun. Right. Creepy ghosts came out to play at night! “Tyson could carry him,” I said quickly.

“We aren’t going to kidnap him,” said Percy.

“Then what’s your plan?” I retorted.

He frowned, so frustrated I could see his jaw ticking. “Nico, I know you’re upset, but Kronos—he’s evil! He doesn’t care about you.”

“I don’t care!”

“I—what?” Percy shook his head. Even Annabeth appeared taken aback.

“It’s not like the gods care about me, either,” Nico said. “At least Kronos is honest about it. At least he can offer me what you can’t.”

Revenge.

The word lingered in the air between us. I crouched in front of him. “Nico, when we were on our quest... I talked to Bianca. She knows what she did was wrong. She was planning on talking to you when we got back. Apologizing.”

He turned his head away so he didn’t have to listen to him.

I sighed, and reminded myself that Nico was a traumatized ten year old child. *And* he was a gay, so I had to give him more of a leash because #community. “Bianca is still your sister, Nico. She still cares about you. She loves you more than anything in the world.”

“Yeah? She has a funny way of showing it.”

I glanced back at Annabeth, helpless. I thought she might have an answer for the situation. Then I saw her grimace, saw the way she looked just as helplessly at Percy, and I realized that we were at a true impasse. And night was approaching quickly. “Guys,” Grover said, his nose twitching.

Tyson stood up straight. “Something is coming.”

Then Orthus started barking, and I realized something was very, very, wrong: the dusk was silent. There should have been crickets and birds chirping, critters rustling in the tall grass. Even the wind was gone. I stood up slowly and looked out the porch, but everything was hidden by an unnaturally thick mist. Something about it tugged at my mind, sort of like the feeling you get when you have *deja vu*, but it was hard to concentrate on it when the monsters started appearing.

Dracanae. Harpies. Even a few cynocephali, which was wild considering they should have been sticking to the Roman half of the conflict. I guess Geryon was right when he said he dealt with *everyone*. One of the dracanae stepped forward, her voice piercing the silence like the moment you break free from water, strangely distorted. “We are here for the son of Hades. Release him, and we will let you live.”

Percy looked at me and our other questing companions. The odds didn’t look great; we were outnumbered four to one, and besides Percy, who must have been exhausted from toiling under the hot sun all afternoon, we had spent most of the day hog-tied and thrown in the corner of the porch while Geryon grilled away. “We can’t let them have Nico,” Annabeth said.

Percy nodded gravely. “Fat chance,” he called out. “Why don’t you slither back from wherever you came from?”

The dracaena hesitated. Then she smirked. “Very well, son of Poseidon. Let us dance.”

Then everything went to shit. Arrows emerged from the mist; if Tyson didn’t knock me and Annabeth over we both would have been skewered. Percy managed to bring his shield out in time while Grover ducked out of the way and played a frantic tune that made the grass come alive, trapping the dracanae in place. The harpies looked like they were eager to dive bomb us, however, and in the enclosed space of the porch we had no chance of evading them.

“Go!” I cried. “I’ll cover you!”

Tyson let out a great roar and charged into the lawn, Percy and Annabeth a step behind him. I cursed myself for not going more hard on the firepower and settled for drawing my bow. In doing so, I saw Eurytion staring at the yard in shock. “Where did they come from?” he murmured, more to himself than to me or Grover, who was continuing to support our questing companions with that frantic, upbeat tune. It was strange, though; even though I could hear it clearly, it sounded as if it wasn’t making it very far beyond the porch. Grover, strained, began moving down the steps, his face growing redder by the second.

“I don’t fucking know, man!” I replied, a little distracted by the monster army. I loosed a few arrows and nodded in satisfaction when a few harpies went poof in an explosion of feathers and monster dust. “Are you going to help us or not?”

“Nothing better to do, I suppose.” And with that, Eurytion picked up his club and joined the others, Orthus barking at his heels.

I tried my best to support my friends, but with the mist swirling around us it was impossible to shoot perfectly. A small voice in the back of my head whispered that I would be more successful if I left the porch, that I could use my gun and *really* show Kronos’s losers’ how a real bitch got things done. And what was I going to do, say no?

I tossed my bow aside, drew my guns, and hurried down to join the chaos. Percy and Annabeth stood back to back, fighting a horde of dracanae and cynocephali that did not seem game to fight. They poked and prodded but maintained a strong formation that proved difficult to break.

At least until I showed up with my guns blazing, that is. “Bang!” I screamed, elated when their formation scattered to the wind.

Emboldened, Percy and Annabeth darted forward, and soon we were surrounded by a sea of monster dust that swirled in the thick mist.

The thick mist...

I glanced at Tyson, who was causing a scene with Eurytion. The pair of them were unstoppable, plowing through enemies as if they weren’t there. Even Grover seemed confused, his nose twitching as he continued to play that frantic, up-beat song that sounded strangely muted from where I stood...

“No,” I murmured. “No, no, it can’t be...”

I turned around, but I was too far away to do anything. I could only watch as green runes burned into the ropes that bound Nico, sizzling and fraying until he sprang free and darted to the table where we had carelessly left his sword. “Guys!” I shouted. “Nico!”

Annabeth was the only one who heard me in time. She stabbed one of the monsters and tried to make a run for him, but a rune appeared in the air between her and the porch. A hand threw out a hand but I was too late; with a terrifyingly loud *BOOM!* the rune exploded in a shockwave of green energy. Annabeth flew backwards and skidded through the grass, tumbling over and over again until she lay limply.

“*Annabeth!*” Percy’s voice tore from his throat. “Tyson, protect Nico!”

Tyson sprinted through the chaos at once, and somehow, nothing seemed to touch him. I kept my eyes on the edge of the clearing where all of the arrows had come from. If I was right... If I had fucked up this badly... I was torn between hurrying towards Annabeth and trying to do something *really* drastic when Tyson reached the porch. He vaulted the steps in a single bound and reached down to grab Nico.

His big eye widened in confusion when Nico appeared to dissolve, black mist slowly drifting into the shadows at his feet. "Nico went bye!" Tyson called out helpfully.

I grimaced, my eyes narrowed. I wasn't sure what I was looking for, exactly, but the more I concentrated, the more I was able to glean. There was a pattern to the mist surrounding us: Grover was surrounded by a dark, evergreen color like a spruce tree, while Tyson's burned red and hot. Annabeth was surrounded by a clump of gray and blue mist that swirled chaotically around her, even more violent than the deep blues and greens that surged around my brother like a violent tide.

Then the Mist cleared. Nico stood across the clearing from us, sword in hand and triumphant. Standing behind him was a single boy. He had long brown hair that fell on either side of his face in two messy curtains, but they did nothing to hide his shit-eating smirk, nor the cruel glint to his eyes. I glanced down, where he held a leather-bound book in his open hand, and suddenly everything made sense.

"Oh, *fuck me*," I muttered.

"Who is that?" asked Percy, breathing heavily.

"I don't know," I replied, even though that wasn't really true. I had an *idea* of who this was, but I couldn't remember his name for the life of me. Sue me! He was from a supplemental text!

"You have much to learn about magic, daughter of Apollo," the boy called across the clearing to me. "Truthfully, I expected more from one blessed by my mother, one whose magic could fool even Luke Castellan."

My heart beat loudly in my chest. "Phoebe, what does he mean?" asked Percy.

The boy reached into his pocket and took out a small black card. "I pray the next time we meet you better impress. Here. In case you change your mind." Then he flicked the card at me.

We all watched as it flew with unnatural speed and accuracy. I couldn't say I was surprised when it slowed to a stop right in front of me, though.

Nor could I say I was surprised when we all looked back, and saw that where the boy and Nico had been standing was now a swirl of green mist, and the 'army' of monsters had likewise vanished without a trace.



While Percy wanted to catch Nico before he could disappear into the Labyrinth, Grover managed to talk some sense into him while I half-led, half-carried Annabeth back into Geryon's ranch. Now that it was night, Nico had the advantage; he could summon an army of

the dead that could actually harm us, unlike the Mist-conjured monsters. Fortunately Annabeth was only concussed (and isn't that a crazy sentence?) so I didn't need to prepare any poultices or potions. Not trying to out-magic the other demigod proved to be a blessing in disguise, because I had no problem concentrating my magic and putting a hand to Annabeth's head to heal her.

I still muttered a prayer to my father, though. I didn't trust magic nearly as much as I had before we were ambushed. I watched in amazement as her head glowed with my black ghostly flames and the golden light of my father. When she settled back onto the cushions of the bed and started snoring, I let out a small sigh of relief. I doubted Annabeth would be taken out by something so banal, but for a moment there... It was a close call. And Annabeth had *far* too many of those since I met her. The reminder did nothing to soothe the emotions boiling somewhere deep within me.

Fortunately Eurytion offered to keep watch for us so that no other agents of Kronos tried to ambush us in our sleep. Percy was so distracted worrying over Annabeth that he didn't even question it; I shoved him towards the bathroom and made sure I heard the water running before I stumbled into the nearest bedroom and collapsed. As soon as my head hit the pillow I fell asleep, like Morpheus remembered that one time we met, became besties, and I kind of sorted threatened him.

Yeah, remember when *that* happened? When he said all that creepy shit to me while my friends were under his enchantment?

Gods, my life was a fucking mess.

Now you might think I should have seen it coming when my father offered me twin birds instead of an actually useful dream, but I guess I'm a bit of a dumbass, because when I realized I was *not* dreaming of Circe, who I really wanted to speak my mind to, I cursed violently and tried to pinch myself awake. After a few minutes of wincing and yowling in pain I accepted that I would only be able to wake up when daddy dearest allowed me to.

With a frustrated grumble I took in my surroundings. It didn't take me long to realize I was back in Crete; the sprawl of buildings descending down the hillside to the brilliant turquoise sea was the same as I remembered it, as was the gleaming golden palace that sat at the very top of the hill. In the shadow of the palace was a brilliant garden. I struggled to imagine how much effort it would take to keep all of the plants alive without modern technology, the labor and money necessary to acquire all of the flowers and trees that were clearly not native to Crete. Gods, the amount of water that would need to be brought from wells every single day...

I drifted through the garden towards the sound of humming. It was nothing like the creepy, eldritch-horror shit I heard when Circe turned her mortal into a shitty sea-god. Hearing it made me feel warm and relaxed and safe, like I was being held by my mother while blue cookies were baking in the oven. Even if I was in control of my limbs, I would have drifted until I reached the source of such a mesmerizing song.

At the very center of the garden was a circular courtyard basked in the shadow of tall leafy trees. The stoney ground was carved into a geometric pattern that scratched my brain just the

right way: a circle, within a circle, within a circle, within a circle... It was almost as distracting as the girl dancing her way through the carvings, humming as she went along. Her hair was caramel brown, bouncy and curly like mine had grown but shiny with products that made it look less insane scientist and more fanfic Hermione Granger. Her narrow, elfin features didn't help things, either. Even with her eyes closed she danced through the circles with purpose, her footsteps light but sure. I was immediately jealous and *deeply* attracted to her.

At least until I noticed who was also watching her.

Sitting on a bench in the shadow of a particularly leafy bush was Pasiphaë. To my relief, she was no longer pregnant with the Minotaur. She was a vision; the dappled sunlight seemed to warp around her, growing more rich and vibrant when it hit her. Or maybe she was giving off a light of her own. She *was* an immortal daughter of the sun god.

Once I got over my shock (read: clamped my mouth shut and reminded myself that she was an evil queen who birthed a monster that would kill a lot of people and one day get absolutely shit on by my twelve year old brother), I took the time to really look at her. No longer was she the cold, cruel, queen I recalled from my last dream. She looked at the girl dancing around the courtyard with an expression that felt strangely familiar to me. She focused entirely on the girl, but not with criticality. The corners of her mouth were turned up in a small, gentle smile, and her golden eyes danced with something like pride.

For some reason, though, when the girl reached the center of the courtyard and came to a stop, she turned around with tears in her eyes. "It's no good, Mother. I cannot feel it."

I expected Pasiphaë to berate her daughter, to treat her with the same cold fury she had treated Circe. Instead, she smoothed out her golden dress and patted the space beside her on the stone bench. The girl wiped the tears impatiently from her eyes and crossed the courtyard, no longer bound by the intricate pattern and—

Oh, I'm actually so fucking stupid, I thought to myself.

The girl collapsed on the bench and put her head on her mother's shoulder. Pasiphaë wasted no time running a hand through her hair, untangling knots with patient diligence. "You are my daughter, Ariadne. The blood of Zeus and Helios flows in your veins. It is not a question of ability, but of belief."

Ariadne did not look up. "I do not understand, mother."

"You are too harsh on yourself."

Something about the words made something tickle my throat dangerously. Here was Pasiphaë, Queen of Crete, the daughter of Helios and Perseis, one of the most famous witches in history, a reviled villain who birthed the Minotaur, betrayed Daedalus and her husband and finally her daughter when she escaped with Theseus. Here was Pasiphaë, reminding me of my own mother.

She sat with Ariadne in silence for a time, just like my mom did whenever she knew I was close to crying. Birds chirped overhead, the salt-tinged air sighed with every gust of wind, the city buzzed and chattered and shouted in the distance. It was peaceful. Not a word I ever would have connected with Pasiphaë.

“I have told you little of my sister, Circe.” Ariadne looked at her mother sharply, but didn’t interrupt. “When we were young, together in the halls of our father, I thought her a weak, pathetic thing. She hid in our grandmother’s skirts, cowered before our father, begged for even a morsel of attention or praise. She even,” Pasiphaë continued with a laugh, “fell in love with a mortal man! My sister! Daughter of Helios and Perseis, a nymph of unspeakable power, chasing after a mortal. *Pathetic.*”

She huffed out the last word in disbelief. Then she shook her head and continued, “So imagine our surprise when this mortal entered our father’s halls transformed into a powerful god of the sea! Oh, how the other nymphs trembled in awe and wonder! Yet it was only I, and your Uncle, Aeëtes, who wondered *who* might have transformed a measly fisherman into a god of such unspeakable power. Not Zeus, certainly, nor Poseidon. They are too proud, too wrathful. Only the greatest of mortals are granted divinity, daughter, and *that* man was certainly not one of them.”

”Enough with the foreshadowing,” I whispered, entranced.

“It was Circe?” Ariadne hazarded quietly.

“Indeed. She, who had suffered in the halls of our father, she, who was forgotten, mocked, ridiculed... *She* was the one who learned the truth of our blood. And she did it with pharmakeia.”

“Pharmakeia?” asked Ariadne. “I am not familiar with the word, Mother.”

“You would not be. It is not a practice the gods wish mortals to know of, let alone to understand.” Pasiphaë glanced up at the sky, where her father drifted by on his cycle around the Earth. “Circe told me once sorcery is not a divine power, not that which comes from a thought, or a blink, or an urge. To hear her tell it, sorcery is something to be made and worked, planned and searched out, dug up, dried, chopped and ground, cooked.” She shook her head. “It is a toil, a struggle, a *yearning* that no immortal should be capable of. It can even fail. Of course we immortals could not conceive of it. We, who are perfect beings, could never believe ourselves capable of such folly.”

“All magic begins with desire, Phoebe. Why do you think we women are more oft blessed by Hecate? Men are given everything on a silver platter. They grow lazy and fat and apathetic. Women are denied. Most of our sisters are beaten down, molded in a forge to whatever shape is expected of them. If they resist, they are broken beyond repair. We, Phoebe, are swords. Forged in fire, sharpened with Magic...”

“But Circe could,” Ariadne said quietly, staring at where her hands were joined together in her lap. Beside her mother, who glowed golden with divinity, she was just a girl. “Because she understood what it is like to be mortal. To be like...” Her voice faded out, but her mother understood her.

“Yes,” she replied, simply. “But that was many years ago. She was exiled for transforming Scylla, who caught the eye of her lover Glaucos, into the terrible beast all sailors must face if they are to traverse the seas. Poseidon is grateful, of course. Not that he would ever say it. For Scylla resides in his domain; sailors pray to him for strong winds and calm seas when they must pass her island. Even so, your aunt was sent to exile, sent where none could learn the secrets of her sorcery.”

“But you did?” asked Ariadne.

“In a manner of speaking.” Pasiphaë smiled. “What you must understand, daughter, is that Hecate, the goddess of magic, is a being of choices, of multitudes. She watches over crossroads, over the conjoining of the sea, the sky, and the earth. She is a goddess of fluidity, of transitions. So too is magic. It is not something that can be defined, not something that can be understood. Magic exists in the space between. For Circe... For my sister...”

Pasiphaë’s expression shifted, and I suddenly knew that beneath all of the bluster, all of the bitching and arguing, Pasiphaë loved her sister. Her vulnerability only shone through for a single moment, but it was so startling, so powerful, I knew I would never forget it. Ariadne must have seen it, too, for she sat up.

“She has always existed at the margins. Daughter of Helios, forever scorned. The most powerful sorceress to walk the earth, confined to an island where she may never leave. An immortal who loves a mortal. Bah!” Pasiphaë shook her head doggedly. “Her connection to magic is tied to her sense of self. To her struggle, to her connection to the earth that entraps her, but that once offered her salvation. It is for that reason that her pharmakeia is so powerful.”

“Then what of you, mother?” asked Ariadne urgently. “What is your connection? How did you discover it?”

Pasiphaë leaned over and took one of her daughter’s hands with both of her own. “Words.”

“Words?”

Ariadne did not look convinced. “Yes, sweetling, *words*. Or have you not heard your father condemn my wicked tongue before?”

“Yes, you are sharp-witted and intelligent, mother, but... How is that magic?”

Pasiphaë glanced at one of the attendants who lurked in the shadows, always at the beck and call of royalty. She was a tall, thin, thing, with an unfortunately large nose. Somehow, before she spoke, I recognized what she was going to do. “**Ἀλλαγή**,” she commanded, in the language of before time, the language that Kampê used, the language of Magic. *Change*.

Golden light swirled around the attendant. When it faded, a pale brown bird stood on the ground. It hopped around, chirped once, then took off for the trees. The other attendants waiting in the shadows all stiffened and did their best not to look like they just shit themselves. “Mother!” Ariadne cried.

“She will be more happy as a bird than as a slave. She was found in your father’s bed.”

Ariadne’s face colored. I felt sympathy for them both; Minos was such an utter tool that even his daughter knew he was cheating on his immortal wife. “Still, mother...”

“That is beside the point.” Pasiphaë took her daughter’s hand in both of her own, her expression now fervent. “Magic is about *belief*, Ariadne. If you do not believe yourself capable, you will never succeed. If you do not see your relation to magic, then you do not see your relation to the world. It is the most personal of all arts, for it reveals who *you* are, how *you* connect with the universe.”

Her words echoed in my mind as the scene melted like an impressionist painting in a rainstorm. When it reformed a crescent moon hung low overhead, the entire galaxy spread out like a luminous scar, an arch stretching as far as the eye could see. The courtyard shone with ethereal light, revealing the shadow of a girl standing at the edge of the carved pathway. Then she began to hum the same quiet, mesmerizing, tune I heard earlier.

Ariadne danced, and the Labyrinth grew around her.

Chapter End Notes

Percy: 'Nico, don't you dare do it!'

Nico, hissing under the bed: 'I'm an Italian raised during WW2! Of course I am a fascist!'

I hope you liked this update! Canon divergences are happening! Finally! And have you figured out the meaning of phoebe's dreams yet? Conclusions are coming shortly, chat...

Chapter 9: I Have An Epiphany

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for [notes](#)

The next morning I raided Geryon's pantry and set to work making breakfast. I don't know when I memorized Mom's recipes, but they all came to mind effortlessly as I worked, whisking eggs, frying bacon, and dumping blue food dye into a mixing bowl. Grover and Tyson woke first thanks to their enhanced scent. Tyson was a risk to eat all of the food before the others woke up, so we tasked him with keeping an eye and a nose out for any lingering monsters or demigods.

Grover and I worked in silence for a little while, but I could tell he wanted to say something. "You missed your deadline," I finally said.

Grover looked up from where he was flipping pancakes with a stricken expression. "You remembered?" he asked quietly.

I nodded, but couldn't meet his eye. When Rachel and I were creating our timeline it had been a fleeting detail, overshadowed by Bianca's ghost and Percy's dream of Perdix, Daedalus's nephew who 'fell' off a cliffside the way one of Vladimir Putin's enemies 'falls' from a building. Somewhere along the way, though, I had neglected Grover almost as much as the narrative had abandoned him in the books. Every book featured a customary Pan reference until Grover finally met the Lost God... Who promptly faded, and with it, so too did Grover's relevance to the plot. I wasn't going to stand for that. He was a Lord of the Wild, and Percy's oldest and closest friend. He deserved better than side-character status. I had only exchanged a brief introduction with Juniper before I was running away from the eldritch Labyrinth tentacles! It wasn't fair!

"It's going to work out," I told him confidently. "Institutions are inherently corrosive, Groves. You're going to find Pan whether or not those old fat fucks agree with you. Juniper sees your vision. Percy, Annabeth, and I do, too. We've got your back."

Grover smiled, but he was too sheepish to meet my eyes. It was cute. "Yeah?"

I nodded. "If Pan is in the Labyrinth we'll find him soon. If not, you're going to live for another, what, two hundred years? I forget the human to satyr conversion."

"Something like that," Grover laughed.

"Either way, that's plenty of time. Who knows? Maybe he's in Cuba with Tupac."

"I don't think he's in Cuba, Phoebe."

"Hey! Pan would have seen Che and Fidel's vision."

Grover shook his head ruefully. Then his smile faded, and I knew our moment of respite was over. “It’ll be hard to find him if the Titan Lord takes over the world and ushers in a new Dark Age.”

I scoffed with as much conviction as I could muster. “Yeah, right. That geezer is going the way of the boomers: six feet fucking under.”

“Maybe,” Grover conceded.

We left the conversation there. Once we finished cooking we brought everything out to the porch to eat. Annabeth and Percy trudged onto the porch together, but kept an awkward distance away from one another in the way that teenagers who like one another do. They were too close to be friends but not close enough to *be* friends, if that makes sense. Plus they kept exchanging looks with one another which made me wonder if I had missed a canon-divergent conversation this morning. I made a mental note to ask Percy about it later while I took a mental picture of the pair of them: their hair was delightfully messy and unkempt, and both sported deep shadows under their eyes. While Annabeth yawned hugely and collapsed beside Grover so she could have easy access to the pitcher of coffee, Percy eyed the mountain of blue pancakes and smiled gratefully at me.

“Questing takes a lot of energy,” I said softly. “And breakfast is the most important meal of the day.”

“That sounds like a rule,” murmured Grover, nursing his coffee like it was a sacred artifact.

I smiled brightly. “By the gods, Grover! You’re right!”

Percy and Grover shared an exasperated smile as I reached into my softball bag and added my first rule in nearly a year. “Rule #9,” I murmured. “Demigods eat a healthy breakfast, or else.”

“Mom would be proud,” Percy teased me.

“Or else what?” added Grover. “They have to eat an unhealthy breakfast?”

I stuck my tongue out and threw a raspberry at them both. To my annoyance, they both caught their raspberries on their tongues and then high-fived with smug smiles. After that we ate in silence for a while, entertained by Tyson inhaling enough pancakes to feed an entire football team. It was broken when Eurytion stepped onto the porch, eyeing the food and us with a hesitance completely at odds with his massive frame. “Sit down,” I said. “We are eating your food, after all.”

I was surprised when he chortled and sat down next to Tyson. “Reckon you’re right, lassie.”

“You’re going to stay, then?” asked Annabeth thoughtfully.

“Yep. Things are going to be a run a little different on this ranch from now on. No more sacred cattle meat. I’m thinking soy-bean patties. And I’m going to befriend those flesh-eating horses. Might just sign up for the next rodeo.”

Percy shuddered. "Good luck."

"You're such a woke king," I told him solemnly.

"Thought you'd be happy to hear that," he said, and then he leaned over and mussed up my hair! I couldn't stop myself from giggling; despite Silena's magic the Texas humidity had my hair almost as unruly as Annabeth's. She caught my eye with an expression I couldn't read. Then it shuttered, and she turned to Eurytion. "You won't be helping Kronos's army, then?"

"Shoot, no." Eurytion spat so hard it flew all the way into the grass. Percy and Grover's eyes lit up in interest. "I reckon you'll be looking for Daedalus's workshop now?"

Now Annabeth was the intrigued one. "Can you help us?"

Eurytion shifted uncomfortably. "Don't know where it is. But Hephaestus probably would."

And now *I* was the one intrigued! "Oh, fuck yes," I whispered under my breath, and pumped my fist.

Annabeth glanced at me, then looked back at Eurytion. "That's what Hera said. But how do we find Hephaestus?"

I realized what was about to happen before Eurytion reached for his collar. "Daughter of Athena!" I yelped, unprompted.

He glanced at me, abashed. "Shoot, you're right."

"What are you talking about?" asked Annabeth and Percy in unison.

I flushed, realizing my mistake. "Magic gut."

"Magic gut?" Tyson scratched his head. "What is that?"

"Uh—"

Eurytion put the silver disc on the table and did *not* activate. "This will turn to a spider, lassie," he explained to Annabeth. "It'll lead you straight to Hephaestus."

"How'd you get your hands on it?" asked Grover while Annabeth stared at the silver disc with revulsion.

"Hephaestus comes here from time to time," replied Eurytion. "Studies the animals and such so he can make bronze automaton copies. Last time I—uh—did him a little favor. A little trick he wanted to play on my dad, Ares, and Aphrodite. He gave me that chain in gratitude."

Percy and Annabeth glanced at one another and then looked away, both deeply red in the face. I smirked in satisfaction. "Kind of you to give it to us," I told him.

"I don't need to see the forges, miss. Got enough to do here. Especially now that the Titan Lord will want to know why we're not sending him cattle meat." He spit again.

My questing companions and I (barring Tyson, was still going ham on the pancakes) shared a dark look at the mention of Kronos. “Phoebe...” Annabeth started.

I looked away. “It was my fault.”

“That’s not what I was going to say,” Annabeth said at the same time Percy exclaimed, “No, it wasn’t!”

I smiled at them both. “It was,” I repeated. “I should have noticed something was wrong.”

“I should have noticed the lack of monster dust,” said Annabeth.

“I should have felt the disturbance in the Wild,” said Grover.

Tyson burped. “I should not eat more.”

“Good call, man,” said Percy, and clapped him on the back. I smiled softly at the pair of them, which Percy returned in kind. “Just because that demigod used magic, doesn’t mean it was your fault.”

Tyson shoved his plate out of reach. “Brother is right, Phoebe. Is not your fault. We are a team.”

I turned away again so I could wipe tears from my eyes. “Stop glazing me, guys.”

“Glazing?” asked Eurytion.

“Don’t ask,” everyone—even Tyson!—said in unison.

Then Annabeth nodded and pushed herself to her feet. “We’ll convince Hephaestus to help us, and then we’ll find Daedalus.”

“What about Nico?” asked Percy. “We have to help him.”

Grover winced. Annabeth hesitated for a moment, then her expression cleared. “If we have Ariadne’s string, we should be able to find him. We need to figure out who that demigod was, anyway. He was too powerful to ignore.”

“Shoot him, or something!” I cried before I could stop myself.

“Phoebe,” Percy began, aghast.

“It’s a reference!” I protested. I crossed my arms when everyone, even Eurytion, looked at me in disappointment. “You know I can’t help but make references. Chat would rebel if I abandoned the bit now!”

“Chat?” Eurytion said, then added before anyone else could speak up, “Don’t ask about it. Right.”

“I can try to pick up the trail once we find Hephaestus,” I said. “If he summons the dead again, I should be able to sense it.”

“Are you able to do that?” asked Annabeth.

“I’m not sure,” I admitted quietly. “There’s so much magic in the Labyrinth that I won’t know until I try, but... After what that demigod did...”

I didn’t need to elaborate. After a few seconds of awkward silence, Eurytion clapped me on the back. “Best get on with it, then.”

And so we got on with it. When we re-entered the Labyrinth I thankfully did not have another magical-drug euphoria rush, but I did need a few seconds to adjust. Only now there was something different about the Labyrinth. More familiar. It was like the moment you realize you’ve grown used to the way your friend’s place smells. It’s not home, but it’s not *not* home, either. That should have scared me more than it did, but honestly, I was just glad the little black tendrils didn’t make another introduction. I’d had enough of that.

Now, about the Sphinx. I definitely could have done more to tell Annabeth to get a grip. The sphinx was a really scary monster! It was massive, and each of its teeth were as long as Annabeth’s dagger! A more intelligent, more careful isekai-protag would have interjected before the sphinx decided to attack us. But truthfully? I was torn between seeing Annabeth do the most on-brand shit imaginable, and giving Tyson the opportunity to get a confidence boost by kicking some sphinx ass. I’d like to say I was a supportive half-sister or whatever, but truthfully I was too busy shitting myself with Grover to do much more than run.

Hephaestus lived in a bachelor pad of the most honest variety. It was part mechanic’s garage, with hydraulic lifts sporting cars, a bronze hippalektryon (a horse with a rooster for a butt), and a few war chariots for good measure, along with a ping pong table, a cluster of retro arcade games, and a vending machine Grover was doing his best not to drool at. Tyson was drawn to the projects littering the many, *many*, worktables that took up the rest of the space, while Annabeth pursed her lips at the tools laying haphazardly all over the place or put in the wrong sections of a pegboard.

That left Percy and I to stare at the grubby grey overalls and massive rubber boots sticking out from underneath a Toyota Corolla. Fortunately the spider made our introduction for us, running over to its master and doing several backflips just to flex or whatever.

Similar to the sphinx, there wasn’t much different about our introduction to the god of the forge. I will disclose with complete honesty that my brother somehow managed to undersell how gnarly Hephaestus looked. His head was shaped like a misshapen strawberry that happened to be on fire and covered in pubic hair, and he walked with a permanent limp thanks to Mommy dearest. A little voice in the back of my head wanted to ask him if he would be interested in having dinner with my mom, because he could really use a positive parental figure in his life, and then I remembered he was a god and I was a demigod, and he would probably turn me into a charred spot on the floor of his workshop if he heard me openly pitying him like that. It was hard to remember that, though, when I saw him bonding with Tyson, who also needed to have more meals with our family.

I spoke up for the first time since we entered his workshop when Mount St. Helens was brought up. Actually, that's not true. I went *eep!* and then slapped a hand over my mouth. When everyone turned to look at me, I glared at the floor. "Oh sure, judge a girl for being scared of the five hundred foot tall walking nuke! My bad!"

When I managed to pry my eyes up from the oil-streaked floor, I found Hephaestus's burning black eyes boring into my own. I suddenly remembered I had opened Bunker 9 and potentially stolen his son's moment in the spotlight. Thankfully I managed to avoid asking him to eat me, or anything embarrassing like that. I did gulp, though. But still—character development!

Hephaestus humphed and looked away from me. "The witch is right to be afraid. The gods themselves ran from Typhon when he was free. No, lately I have sensed intruders in my mountain. Someone or something is using my forges. When I go there..."

The rest was more or less how I remembered it from canon, right down to the spider being the one to lead us to the volcano. The only problem? I *totally* forgot Grover and Tyson branched off here! It was only when I sensed the magic of Pan that I remembered. The path that led to Pan had a magic to it that was as foreign and as superior to the Labyrinth as Caleb Hearon is to straight men. Again, I can't really explain what it was like to a normie like you (shout out plot contrivances!), but it was fresh? Green? What really stood out was the smell, like the woods after a heavy rainfall, earthy and wet and ancient. There was a faint breeze that seemed to whistle down the passageways of the Labyrinth, calling to me like escaping to a commune in the woods of the Pacific Northwest calls to polyamorous people who refuse to wear deodorant.

When we finally reached the turn off Grover stopped dead in his tracks. "This is the way," he murmured in awe. "This is it."

"What way?" asked Percy. "You mean... To Pan?"

Grover looked at Tyson. "Don't you smell it?"

In hindsight, that *really* should have triggered some warning bells, but gods damn it there was a quest going on, and as we have established, there was *a lot* of foreshadowing going on! I know you've missed a lot of it, too! If you don't know what I mean, trust me: you're going to.

Anyway, Tyson was nodding along. "Smells like earth," he said. "And plants."

"Yes!" Grover's eyes were practically bulging out of his head. "This is the way, I'm sure of it!"

Up ahead, the spider was getting further down the stone corridor. A few more seconds and we'd lose it.

"We'll come back," Annabeth promised. "Once we have the string... Or if Phoebe can figure out how to navigate the Labyrinth..."

Grover looked at her sadly. "I can't wait, Annabeth. Don't you understand?"

She looked desperate, there was no denying that, but... She did understand. She had known Grover for twice as long as Percy and I had. She had spent *years* hearing Grover talk about his life's dream to find the lost god. Her loyalty to the quest and to her friend were pulling her in different directions. I could practically hear Janus laughing on either one of her shoulders.

"We'll split up."

We all looked at Percy, who was doing that thing where he looks less like my dork of a fourteen year old brother and more like the son of Poseidon who had already saved the world numerous times, and would keep doing it even though the gods were fucking ungrateful little shits.

Annabeth's face paled. "That's way too dangerous. How will we ever find each other again? And Grover can't go alone."

Tyson put his hand on Grover's shoulder. "I will go with him."

I couldn't help it. I teared up and darted forward to hug both of them. I could only get my arm halfway around Tyson's torso, but managed to nearly yank Grover off his feet. "Tyson, are you sure?" asked Percy.

Over my head, Tyson nodded. "Goat boy needs help. We will find the nature god person. I... I am not like Hephaestus and Briares. I help my friends. I trust my family."

"*Family!*" I bawled.

Grover awkwardly patted my back. "We'll find each other again. "We've still got the empathy link, Percy. I just..." His voice faded out, and when he spoke again, it was quiet but fervent. "I have to."

I pulled away from them and wished I had some kind of way to track them that was more reliable than an empathy link. I settled for the next best thing and shoved my ziploc bag full of drachmas at Grover. "Take this. If you run into any problems, IM us. We'll find you."

"A bag of drachmas," Grover sniffled. "How sentimental."

"Save it, goat boy," I replied, but my voice was wet, too.

Annabeth's face twisted before she straightened her spine and her upper-lip. "Splitting up is a really bad idea," she said, a daughter of Athena through and through.

"Be careful," Percy said for the pair of them, translating the mess of Annabeth's emotions for her. Yes, it was cute as you're probably envisioning it!

Tyson stepped forward, hugged Percy so tightly I thought I heard his spine crack, and then he and Grover set off, soon disappearing into the darkness. Once they were out of sight I took Annabeth by the hand. "I'll figure out how to navigate the Labyrinth so we can find them

again,” I vowed. I inhaled deeply, trying to memorize the strange scent, the breeze that settled the anxiety in my bones.

Annabeth squeezed my hand tightly. “Phoebe...”

“I will,” I repeated.

Annabeth nodded, and gently removed her hand from mine. She looked past me at my brother, and—

Oh, dear god, I thought. Their kiss is going to be even more intense, isn't it?

I wanted to be giddy about the realization, but uh... Remember the metaphorical textbook on avoidance? Well, here it was! Chat: how had I forgotten about *Calypso*? Percy was about to commit an act of ecoterrorism so intense he would unleash the king of monsters! It felt different when Rachel and I were sitting in the (relative) comfort of Bunker 9, discussing how we might look after Annabeth while she waited for Percy to come home from his week-long vacay to the island of the cursed nymph, all in the name of not fucking over the canon timeline. That's rule #1 of *any* time-travel or isekai fic! The moment canon derails too much, you're *fucked*!

Now, though... Now that I saw the way she looked at my brother... There was no way I could do that to her. Could I?

I'd like to say I felt confident in what I would do once Percy blew up a volcano, but the entire time we chased after that metal spider, I debated my options. “Fuck off, Janus, you Spy Kids looking-ass,” I muttered darkly under my breath.

I was torn out of my thoughts when Percy, adorable idiot that he is, absolutely ruined the moment he and Annabeth had been steadily building up to for awhile now. “Something Hephaestus said back there... About Athena.”

Annabeth frowned. “She swore never to marry, like Artemis and Hestia. She's one of the maiden goddesses.”

Percy blinked. Despite my anxiety, I cracked a knowing smile behind them. “But then—” Percy began.

“How come she has demigod children?”

Oh, he was *so* blushing! I fought down a cackle as he shifted awkwardly and nodded to Annabeth.

“Percy, you know how Athena was born?”

“She sprang from the head of Zeus in full battle armor or something.”

“Cunty,” I murmured from the now-empty peanut gallery.

“Exactly,” Annabeth said, ignoring me. “She wasn’t born in the normal way. She was literally born from thoughts. Her children are born the same way. When Athena falls in love with a mortal man, it’s purely intellectual, the way she loved Odysseus in the old stories. It’s a meeting of minds. She would tell you that’s the purest kind of love.”

I stared at her. “Annabeth, is your mom a lesbian? Because that sounds like something a closeted lesbian would say.”

She continued to ignore me.

“So your dad and Athena...” Percy said slowly. “You mean they didn’t... You weren’t...”

“Oh, gods,” I wheezed.

“I was a brain child,” Annabeth said, terrifyingly unflustered by the topic of conversation. Only Annabeth could have an academic conversation about her conception literal minutes after having a near-breakdown over the quest splitting in half. “Literally. Children of Athena are sprung from the divine thoughts of our mother and the mortal ingenuity of our father. We are supposed to be a gift, a blessing from Athena on the men she favors.”

Percy did not look appeased by her explanation. “But—”

“Percy, the spider’s getting away. Do you really want me to explain the exact details of how I was born?”

Percy’s face was now bright red. “Um... no. That’s okay.”

Annabeth smirked at him. “I thought not.” Then she finally deigned to glance at me. “And Phoebe, only a few gods are known to be fluid in their identities. Your dad chief amongst them.”

She took off after the spider, leaving Percy and I standing together. “Did she just call my dad gay?” I whispered.

“I think she did,” Percy whispered back. “Phoebe... Would Mom be mad at me if I *never* want to think about how Annabeth was born?”

“Nah,” I replied, a shit-eating grin spreading across my face. “But Percy.”

“What?”

Do you know if Annabeth has a belly button or not?”

“I—*what?*”

I smirked at him. “Your belly button is where the umbilical cord is. Annabeth is a brain child.”

“She has a belly button...?” Percy replied, unsure.

“Wouldn’t you like to know, weather boy.” I followed Annabeth, leaving my brother to ponder the mysteries of the universe behind us.

While I appreciated the levity of the conversation, the joy was short-lived, for we soon reached the forge of Hephaestus. There was no floor, just bubbling lava hundreds of feet below. We stood on a rocky ridge that circled the cavern. A network of metal bridges spanned across it. At the center was a huge platform with all sorts of machines, cauldrons, forges, and an anvil the size of a house. Telekhines, those demon seal things, were moving around the platform hard at work.

“We’ll never be able to sneak up on them,” Percy observed.

Annabeth tugged her Yankees cap out of her knapsack. “I can. Wait here.”

“Hold it!” He tried to grab Annabeth before she could turn invisible but wound up whiffing on open air. I laughed under my breath as he looked around anxiously. “I don’t like it,” he muttered crossly. “If those things can sense Hephaestus, what if they can sense her?”

“They won’t.” I put a hand on his shoulder. “Annabeth’s aura is much less powerful than Hephaestus’s.”

“What do you mean?”

“What do you mean, what do I mean? He’s a god. His aura is all—” I gestured at the magma beneath us and added a “*WOOSH!*” with a dramatic arm flourish for good measure.

“What is Annabeth’s like?”

I frowned. “Cool. Restrained, but... Powerful.”

“Huh.” I thought I had placated Percy, but the power of ADHD and the anxiety of your crush sneaking up to investigate monsters in a volcanic forge was too much to ignore. “I want to get a better angle.”

I knew he was going to do it, but that didn’t make me any more happy. A little part of me hoped canon might diverge, and no Calypso side-quest would be needed. “Just wait for her!” I hissed.

“What if she’s in danger?”

I drew my bow, which I was more accurate with at range, and waggled it around. “I’ve got her back. Hawkeye, remember?”

“What?”

“Oh, I forgot you’re a fake nerd. That was two references in one, you know. Three if I have to heal either of you.”

Percy didn’t look amused. “Watch my back.”

“Percy—*Percy!*”

But he ignored me and set off down the path. I grumbled darkly under my breath, even though I wasn't surprised in the slightest. A tiny voice in the back of my mind urged me to follow him, but my place was back here. I had my bow, and if something happened to either of them... If canon shifted again... They might need a healer. Annabeth already had, hadn't she?

I wondered what Rachel would do if she were in my shoes. She was much more willing to say fuck canon, but she wasn't the one on the quest, wasn't the one who risked fucking everything over. But what could I do? There was no guarantee joining Percy would lead to a better outcome. It was better to just wait.

Wasn't it?

I was interrupted by my dearest brother, who suddenly sprinted onto the center platform with Riptide drawn. I set off in a crouch, running around the perimeter of the volcano to try to get a better angle on my brother and Annabeth. They were huddled behind a huge bronze cauldron that did *not* remind me of Voldemort, thank you very much. A group of telekhines worked at a forge near them on Kronos's scythe. I could feel it even from across the chasm. It made Nico's sword seem like a nerf sword in comparison. Kronos's scythe could divide someone's soul from their body, leaving them to wander the planet as less than a ghost.

I swallowed my terror as best I could. If Percy blew this place up, he would vaporize the telekhines. That should destroy the scythe, right? I couldn't remember. I had to fight the urge to bite my nails in anxiety when a door on the other edge of the volcano burst open and a horde of telekhines came pouring out.

“Fuck!” I cursed. Abandoning all subtlety I rose to my feet and rained fire down upon them. Despite focusing on annihilating sea-lion demons, I kept an eye on where Percy and Annabeth were still hidden. I couldn't hear them, not from this distance, but I could make out enough to see the moment Percy told Annabeth to leave him. She protested wildly, hair bouncing erratically and arms flailing like two windmills. Opposite her Percy remained resolute, like a sturdy rock beating against the current of the ocean.

Then Annabeth surged forward, kissed him, and put on her invisibility cap before I could even blink.

"Gods *damn it!*" I screeched under my breath. I didn't even have a moment to think about reaching for my camera! The injustice of it all! At the very least I got to witness my brother staring stupidly into the distance, punch-drunk on his crush, until the telekhines noticed him. The four biggest blocked each of the bridges that offered him an escape. With his sword raised he stood in the middle of the platform, spinning slowly so he could try to keep them all within sight.

This was it: the moment where Percy blew up Mount St. Helens worse than Grover blew up the bathroom at Yancy after enchilada night. Percy spun Riptide. One of the telekhines grabbed a handful of fire from the nearest furnace. I held my breath, waiting for Annabeth so we could get the fuck out of there.

Then everything went wrong.

With a great bark of surprise and pain one of the telekhines exploded into dust. Percy stared, as absolutely shooketh as I was, when Annabeth materialized where the telekhine had just stood, dagger in one hand and her Yankees cap in the other. “Percy!” she shouted.

I recovered a second after my brother, nocking an arrow and sending it flying towards the pack of telekhines flopping down the bridge towards my brother and my best friend. And, for a single moment, I thought we had a chance. Percy deflected a goopy handful of lava while Annabeth rolled out of the way of a telekhine’s bite. I hit a young telekhine in the eye with an arrow and it exploded over all its friends.

Only then I tried to use a Greek Fire vial like an idiot, because none of the telekhines were affected.

Then Percy had to turn his back on Annabeth to address the huge crowd of telekhines surging onto the platform.

And then Annabeth got lit on fire.

Not to break the fourth wall, chat, but to this day I can still hear the noise she made when the molten lava hit her skin. It was otherworldly, a bestial cry of pain that reminded me we really are just animals with strangely designed brains. Percy roared in anger and took out a whole line of telekhines with a single slice, but it wouldn’t be enough. Annabeth collapsed on the ground, crying out in agony as she tried to get the burning magma off of her skin. Percy was too far away, and he was on the same platform as her. What was I supposed to do? Conjure up a big fireball and yell ‘Bang!’

Everything suddenly slowed. I could see what would happen clearly in my mind's eye. With Annabeth injured, Percy would never use his powers to make the volcano erupt. He would fight—valiantly, to be sure—but it wouldn't matter. He and Annabeth would die.

All while I sat on the ledge of the volcano with a bow in hand, and did *nothing*.

Again.

It was the same as Geryon’s Ranch, the same as Westover Hall, the same as Polyphemus’s Island. The same as I'd done since I first realized I had memories of a false future.

Gone was the roar of the volcano, the beating of my heart, the stream of consciousness worried about Annabeth, worried about my brother, about Grover and Tyson and Rachel... In its place, all I could hear was the melodic humming of Ariadne as she danced around the Labyrinth, her magic literally shaping the crust of the earth to her will.

“Magic is about belief, Ariadne. If you do not believe yourself capable, you will never succeed. If you do not see your relation to magic, then you do not see your relation to the world. It is the most personal of all arts, for it reveals who you are, how you connect with the universe.”

...

Circe seized a handful of the flowers and ripped them by their roots. She tore the petals and broke the stems into pieces. Damp shreds of yellow, green, and brown soon stained her hands, sap bleeding across her skin. The scent rose raw and wild, acetic as old wine. Once the mess in her hands was good and goopy she held it over Glaucos's lips, which had fallen open as he dreamed, and squeezed. Sap leaked and gathered on his tongue. A stray bead landed on his lips, and Circe slid it onto his tongue with her finger. She leaned over him and whispered, "Your truest self. Let it be."

...

"Manifest your desire onto reality and it will comply."

...

"Ἀλλαγὴ," she commanded, in the language of before time, the language that Kampê used, the language of Magic. Change."

...

"Change."

...

"Change."

...

"Because I didn't want anything to change!"

My own words echoed in my mind like the tolling of a belfry, over and over and over again, until they were replaced with a memory I had buried deep within my mind.

"I am a Hesperide, Phoebe Jackson," Zoe said. "I am the sunset, the daughter of the Evening, the guardian of day's transition to night. Does thou'st think I do not know what thou are?"

...

"Hekate, the goddess of magic, is a being of choices, of multitudes. She watches over crossroads, over the conjoining of the sea, the sky, and the earth. She is a goddess of fluidity, of transitions. So too is magic. It is not something that can be defined, not something that can be understood. Magic exists in the space between."

What better described the space between than me? Both from this world, and not? Sally Jackson's daughter, Percy Jackson's sister... But not. And if I thought all the way back to my very first quest... When I met Morpheus, the god of dreams, who rules the domain between sleeping and waking... What had he told me?

“You alone can walk the veil, which means you alone can pierce it.”

All this time I had been terrified of changing the ‘canon timeline.’ Even after I watched my own mother die at the hands of the Minotaur. After I watched my brother get poisoned by Luke. After I watched Reyna and Hylla get kidnapped, after I watched Annabeth hold up the weight of the sky, after I watched Zoë die... *Everything* I had done had been in an effort to keep things the same, afraid that if I interjected, I would make everything worse. I stood at the back of fights, refused to use my magic unless I absolutely had to, all to make sure things played out the way they were supposed to. I had denied myself, denied my power, so I wouldn’t change anything drastically.

But that wasn't the truth, was it? No, I knew the real reason now. The horrible, selfish, *nauseating* reason I had refused to see my real purpose here.

I didn't want blood on my hands.

I wanted this—isekai, future memories, whatever you want to call it—to not matter. I wanted to believe the Fates had willed the canon story to progress with or without me. If I saved the lives of my friends that was all for the better, but if not... At least I could blame the Fates.

At least then I wouldn't have to blame myself.

But where had that gotten me? Nico was fully in his alt-right era. Annabeth was on fire. Rachel was a fucking demigod, which meant we had no clue who would guide us through the Labyrinth, who would tell Percy he wasn’t the hero of the prophecy, and who would usher in the Heroes of Olympus with the next Great Prophecy. I had lied to my friends, to my family, to *everyone*, and for what? For Annabeth and my brother to *die*?

I guess the book on avoidance was actually a boomerang, and here it was coming around to hit me in the face, all as I sat back and continued to do *nothing*.

Hera was right. I always had access to the answer.

I had just been running away from it.

I stood up, my bow falling limply from my fingers. Later I would realize I dropped it right into the pit of the volcano. I tried to remember the feeling of magic. The euphoric rush of it. The thrum of it. The hum of it.

And there it was, waiting for me. Like it always had been, only I had been too scared to acknowledge it.

Across the fiery pit of Mount St. Helens, Percy and I locked eyes. Even though it should have been impossible, I knew what he was mouthing to me: *Save her!*

I didn’t hesitate.

I thrust out a hand and allowed magic to flow through me. “**ἔμοί!**” I commanded. *To me!*

It was like a hook wrapped around Annabeth's middle and yanked her towards me. She flew over the lava, shrieking all the while, fingers clenched around her dagger and her Yankees cap. I concentrated, sweat beading my brow, as my brother burned. He stumbled onto one knee, Riptide clattering onto the platform beside him. The telekhines surrounded him.

I caught Annabeth, hauled her over my shoulder, and took off for the entrance to the Labyrinth. Just as we reached it I heard my brother scream, a terrifying bellow befitting a god.

I clenched my hand into a fist and the ceiling of the Labyrinth came crashing down behind us in a pile of rock and dust as Mount St. Helens erupted.

Chapter End Notes

So... I have a lot of thoughts I want to share with you all!

One thing I've always hated is that Rick made Annabeth a little selfish in this book. In canon, she does not support Grover running off to find Pan, and straight up ditches Percy in the volcano. i only have one thing to say to that: fuck that shit! I've seen some people who think that Annabeth and Percy's fatal flaws should be reversed, and while I'm not totally sure about Percy, I do think Annabeth's loyalty isn't talked about enough. I just can't see her abandoning Percy, or telling Grover to abandon his dreams.

As for the ending... This was a moment I have been trying to build toward for awhile :) While part of the slowdown in posting is due to good old fashioned business, it's also because we're finally getting into some of the more plot-heavy parts of the fic. Phoebe's magic has been a chekov's gun looming over the hearth since book 2, and now we're finally starting to learn why it hasn't gone off yet!

I would love to hear your thoughts on it below. There's never an obligation to comment, but if you can't tell - I love talking about this fic and the writing process in general. Even if you're just dropping hearts or saying 'nice!' I'd appreciate it :))

Please [drop by the Archive and comment](#) to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!